

CIVIL SERVICES EXAMINATION

UPSC • GENERAL STUDIES PAPER 4



Ethics, Integrity & Aptitude

Class Notes



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Contents

1 Ethics and Human Interface	11
1.1 Values	11
1.1.1 Meaning of Values	11
1.1.2 Types of Values — Moral, Immoral and Amoral	11
1.1.3 Relative Hierarchy of Values	12
1.1.4 Ethical Dilemmas Arising from Value Conflict	12
1.2 Collective Values	13
1.2.1 Family Values	13
1.2.2 Societal Values	13
1.2.3 Constitutional Values	14
1.2.4 Organizational & Professional Values	15
1.3 Meaning of Ethics	15
1.3.1 Sources of Ethics	16
1.4 Ethics vs Morals	16
1.4.1 When Ethics and Morals Conflict	17
1.5 Ethics vs Law	18
1.5.1 Legal but Unethical	18
1.5.2 Illegal but Ethical	19
1.5.3 Right vs Right	20
1.6 Constitutional Morality	20
1.7 Determinants of Ethics	21
1.7.1 Institutional & Human Determinants	21
1.7.2 Technology as a Determinant	22
1.7.3 Economic & Global Determinants	22
1.7.4 Evolution of Norms — The Concept of Justice	23
1.7.5 Changing Context Must Be Under Constant Scrutiny	23
2 Consequences of Ethics and Applied Ethics	25
2.1 Consequences of Ethics	25
2.1.1 Why Individuals Should Be Ethical	25
2.1.2 Why Organisations Should Be Ethical	27
2.1.3 Why Society Should Be Ethical	28
2.2 Dimensions of Ethics	29
2.2.1 Normative (Theoretical) Dimension	29
2.2.2 Applied (Practical) Dimension	31

2.3	Ethical Relativism and Ethical Absolutism	31
2.3.1	Ethical Relativism	31
2.3.2	Ethical Absolutism	33
2.3.3	Reconciling Relativism and Absolutism	33
2.4	Environmental Ethics (Applied Ethics)	34
2.4.1	Shallow Ecology vs Deep Ecology	35
2.4.2	Ecocentrism	35
2.4.3	Key Principles of Environmental Ethics	36
2.5	Technology Ethics (Applied Ethics)	36
2.5.1	Key Principles of Technology Ethics	37
2.5.2	Challenges of Technology in Administration	39
2.6	Media Ethics (Applied Ethics)	40
2.6.1	Key Principles of Media Ethics	40
2.7	Ethics in Public and Private Relationships	42
2.7.1	Distinction Between Public and Private Relationship	42
2.7.2	Role of Traditions in Private Relationship Ethics	42
2.7.3	Why Private Relationships Are More Informal	42
2.7.4	Consequences in the Context of Public vs Private	43
3	Human Values and Value Inculcation	45
3.1	Recap: Technology Ethics, Media Ethics & Public vs Private Relationships	45
3.1.1	Technology Ethics	45
3.1.2	Media Ethics	45
3.1.3	Ethics in Public vs Private Relationships	46
3.2	Ethical Standards in Public Relationships (Nolan Committee Principles)	46
3.2.1	Selflessness	47
3.2.2	Integrity	47
3.2.3	Dignity and Compassion	47
3.2.4	Leadership	47
3.3	Ethical Standards in Private Relationships	47
3.3.1	Love and Fidelity	48
3.3.2	Responsibility	48
3.3.3	Dignity in Private Relationships	48
3.3.4	Traditions & Customs and Rule of Law	49
3.3.5	Commonalities and Differences between Public & Private Standards	49
3.4	Why Ethics in Private Relationships Matters More Today	50
3.4.1	Core Reasons	50
3.4.2	The Concept of Pitr-rin (Debt to Parents / Ancestors)	50
3.4.3	The Fragility of Life — Lesson on Prioritising Family	51
3.5	Is a Watertight Separation of Public and Private Life Possible?	51
3.5.1	Argument 1 — Virtue Ethics (“We are what we repeatedly do”)	51
3.5.2	Argument 2 — Divergence Creates a Crisis of Credibility	52
3.5.3	Argument 3 — Higher Standards Required of Civil Servants	52

3.5.4	Where to Draw the Line: Do Public Officials Have Any Privacy?	53
3.6	Human Values	53
3.6.1	Meaning of Human Values	53
3.6.2	Controlling Emotions and Desires — Plato's Chariot Analogy	54
3.6.3	Types of Values: Terminal vs Instrumental	54
3.7	Inculcation of Values: Why Values Must Be Inculcated	55
3.7.1	The Tanker-Looting Illustration	55
3.7.2	Education Without Values → 'A Clever Devil'	55
3.7.3	Many Problems Are Societal, Not Merely Legal	56
3.8	Role of Family in Value Inculcation	56
3.8.1	Examples of Values Inculcated by Family	56
3.8.2	Values from Joint Families	57
3.8.3	How Families Inculcate Values (Mechanisms)	57
3.8.4	Critical Perspective — Why Families Fail to Inculcate Values (Contemporary Factors)	57
3.9	Role of Educational Institutions in Value Inculcation	58
3.9.1	Role of Teachers	58
3.9.2	Role of Curricular Subjects	59
3.9.3	Extracurricular Activities: Sports, Games & Debates	59
3.9.4	Pedagogy: Activity-Based Learning & the Flipped Classroom	60
3.9.5	Critical Perspective — Why Institutions Fail (Contemporary Factors)	60
3.10	Role of Society, Government & Media in Value Inculcation	61
3.10.1	Ethnocentrism & the Value of Exposure (Society)	61
3.10.2	Empathy Toward Systems and People	61
3.10.3	Role of Government	61
3.10.4	Role of Media (Positive)	62
3.10.5	Role of Media (Negative — Contemporary Factors)	62
3.11	Lessons from the Lives of Great Leaders — Mahatma Gandhi	62
3.11.1	Honesty & Integrity	62
3.11.2	Openness, Tolerance & a Learning Attitude	63
3.11.3	Non-Violence (Ahimsa)	63
3.11.4	Forgiveness	63
3.11.5	Swaraj (Self-Rule)	63
3.11.6	Talisman & Antyodaya	64
3.11.7	Solidarity — The Loincloth	64
3.11.8	Sarvodaya, Purity of Means & Trusteeship	64
3.12	Key Cross-Cutting Reminders	65
4	Gandhi's Seven Social Sins, Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Services	67
4.1	Lessons from Gandhiji: The Seven Social Sins	67
4.1.1	Wealth Without Work	67
4.1.2	Pleasure Without Conscience	67
4.1.3	Knowledge Without Character	68

4.1.4	Commerce (Business) Without Morality	68
4.1.5	Science Without Humanity	68
4.1.6	Religion Without Sacrifice	68
4.1.7	Politics Without Principle	69
4.1.8	Rights Without Responsibility (added by Arun Gandhi)	69
4.2	Focus on Controllables: A Note on the Aspirant's Attitude	69
4.3	Aptitude	70
4.3.1	Aptitude Is Not Monolithic — Its Components	70
4.3.2	Civil Services Aptitude	70
4.4	Attitude, and the Relationship between Aptitude & Attitude	71
4.4.1	What Is Attitude	71
4.4.2	Aptitude vs Attitude — Key Differences	72
4.4.3	How Attitude and Aptitude Complement Each Other	72
4.4.4	Learning Attitude: Adopt Values, Don't Become Others	73
4.5	Foundational Values for Civil Services: Objectivity	73
4.5.1	Background — Max Weber's Bureaucratic Model	73
4.5.2	What Objectivity Means	73
4.5.3	Relevance of Objectivity in Governance	74
4.5.4	Limitations of Objectivity	74
4.6	Integrity	75
4.6.1	Illustrations of Integrity	75
4.6.2	Types of Integrity	75
4.6.3	Integrity vs Honesty	76
4.6.4	Why Integrity Matters in Public Life	76
4.6.5	Integrity Pact	76
4.7	Non-Partisanship, Impartiality & Neutrality	77
4.7.1	Background — Permanent vs Temporary Executive	77
4.7.2	Non-Partisanship	77
4.7.3	Impartiality	77
4.7.4	Non-Partisanship vs Impartiality	78
4.7.5	Neutrality	78
4.7.6	Relevance & Violations	78
4.8	Tolerance	79
4.8.1	Why Tolerance Matters	79
4.9	Sympathy, Empathy & Compassion	80
4.9.1	The Three Distinguished	80
4.9.2	Why Empathy & Compassion Matter in Administration	80
4.9.3	Where Compassion Is Essential	81
4.10	Dedication to Public Service	81
4.10.1	Why Dedication Is Needed	81
4.10.2	Dedication as a 'Mother Value'	82
4.10.3	Significance	82
4.11	Key Cross-Cutting Reminders	82

5 Emotional Intelligence and Attitude	85
5.1 Recap: Foundational Values for Civil Services	85
5.1.1 Dedication to Public Service (Passionate Commitment)	85
5.1.2 Sympathy, Empathy and Compassion	85
5.1.3 Non-partisanship and Impartiality	86
5.2 Examples & PYQ Themes on Foundational Values	87
5.2.1 Objectivity without Compassion — the Mining Districts Case	87
5.2.2 PYQ Theme — Integrity and Knowledge	87
5.2.3 Impartiality vs. Positive Discrimination — a Caveat	88
5.3 Ready-to-Use Examples: Apathy, Compassion & Dedication	89
5.4 Emotional Intelligence	89
5.4.1 Opening Quote	89
5.4.2 Definition	90
5.4.3 Five Components of Emotional Intelligence	91
5.4.4 Case Study: The Bank Manager & the Digital Arrest	94
5.4.5 Case Study: Topography of Terror (Berlin)	95
5.4.6 More Examples of Emotional Intelligence (and its absence)	95
5.5 Trained Apathy & Functional Detachment	97
5.6 Using Emotions Positively (Emotions Working For You)	97
5.6.1 Rational vs. Non-rational (Extra-rational) Behaviour	98
5.6.2 Swachh Bharat Mission — Pride, Disgust, Love	98
5.6.3 Pictorial Warnings on Tobacco	99
5.7 Can Emotional Intelligence Be Learned?	99
5.7.1 Methods to Inculcate Emotional Intelligence	99
5.7.2 Emotional Intelligence Can Be Misused	100
5.8 Attitude: Meaning & Structure	101
5.8.1 What is Attitude?	101
5.8.2 Structure of Attitude — the CAB (ABC) Model	101
5.8.3 Components May Not Be in Congruence	102
5.9 Functions of Attitude	103
5.9.1 Knowledge Function	103
5.9.2 Utilitarian / Socially-Adjustive Function	104
5.9.3 Ego-Defensive Function	104
5.9.4 Value-Expressive Function	104
5.10 Attitude's Influence on Thought & Behaviour	104
5.10.1 Influence on Thought	105
5.10.2 Influence on Behaviour	105
5.11 Cognitive Dissonance	107
5.12 Formation of Attitude	108
5.12.1 Classical Conditioning (learning through association)	108
5.12.2 Operant Conditioning (reward and punishment)	108
5.12.3 Observational Learning, Culture, Media, Family	108

5.12.4 Values vs. Attitudes	109
5.12.5 Moral, Immoral and Amoral Attitudes	109
6 Attitude, Deontology and Utilitarianism	111
6.1 Attitude (continued)	111
6.1.1 Cognitive Dissonance	111
6.1.2 Political Attitude	112
6.1.3 Social Influence	114
6.1.4 Persuasion	115
6.1.5 Nudging	117
6.2 Normative Ethics & Deontology (Immanuel Kant)	118
6.2.1 Normative Ethics — The Ethical Standards	118
6.2.2 Case Study — SP Sunil (Applying the Standards)	119
6.2.3 Kant's Deontology — Goodwill	120
6.2.4 The Two Features of a Goodwill	120
6.2.5 The Moral Law & the Categorical Imperative	121
6.2.6 Categorical Imperative, Merits & Demerits of Kant	124
6.3 Teleological Ethics: Utilitarianism	125
6.3.1 Utilitarianism — The Core Idea	125
6.3.2 Jeremy Bentham — Quantitative Utilitarianism	125
6.3.3 John Stuart Mill — Qualitative Utilitarianism	126
6.3.4 Act Utilitarianism vs Rule Utilitarianism	126
6.3.5 Utilitarianism in Governance	127
6.3.6 Merits & Demerits of Utilitarianism	127
7 Ethical Egoism, Virtue Ethics, Weber & Rawls	129
7.1 Ethical Egoism	129
7.2 Virtue Ethics	130
7.3 Virtue Ethics: Socrates	131
7.4 Virtue Ethics: Plato	133
7.5 Virtue Ethics: Aristotle & the Golden Mean	135
7.6 Max Weber & Bureaucracy	137
7.7 John Rawls: Justice as Fairness	140
7.8 Rights, Natural Rights & Social Contract	142
7.9 Ethical Dilemma	144
7.10 Conflict of Interest	145
8 Institutions, Law, Conscience, Corporate Governance & Ethics in IR	149
8.1 Ethical Concerns & Dilemmas in Public and Private Institutions	149
8.1.1 Foundational Backdrop — The Social Contract	149
8.1.2 Public Administration vs Private Administration	149
8.1.3 Changing Values under Globalisation	152
8.1.4 Note — Conflict of Interest vs Ethical Dilemma	152

8.1.5	Ethical Imperative in Public Administration	153
8.1.6	Ethical Challenges in Public Administration	153
8.2	Law as a Source of Ethical Guidance	154
8.2.1	Importance of Law	154
8.2.2	Limitations of Law	155
8.3	Conscience as a Source of Ethical Guidance	156
8.3.1	What Conscience Is	156
8.3.2	How Conscience Becomes a Source of Guidance	157
8.3.3	Conscience Demands Personal Responsibility	157
8.3.4	Conscience vs Law	157
8.3.5	Can You Always Rely on Conscience? (Is it an Infallible Guide?)	158
8.3.6	UPSC PYQ — Max Weber on Bureaucratic Morality	158
8.3.7	Crisis of Conscience	159
8.4	Corporate Governance — Ethics in Private Institutions	160
8.4.1	Why We Study This Topic (The Core Argument)	160
8.4.2	What Corporate Governance Is	160
8.4.3	Obligations Towards Shareholders	160
8.4.4	Obligations Towards Consumers	161
8.4.5	Obligations Towards Employees	162
8.4.6	Obligations Towards Government / Regulators	162
8.4.7	Obligations Towards Society	163
8.4.8	Ethical Concerns in Corporate Governance (India)	164
8.4.9	Companies Act 2013 — Provisions for Ethical Governance	165
8.4.10	Issues / Limitations of CSR	166
8.5	Ethics in International Relations	166
8.5.1	Background — “There is No Place for Principles in Politics”	166
8.5.2	Why International Relations Are Different — The Analogy	167
8.5.3	Why Countries Should Be Ethical — The Arguments	167
8.5.4	Which Ethical Principles to Follow in IR	169
8.5.5	Ethical Concerns in IR (Current-Affairs Examples)	169
8.5.6	Ethical Issues in International Funding	169
8.6	Just War Theory	170
8.6.1	The Logic of Foreseeable Consequences	170
8.6.2	Principles Before War (Jus ad Bellum)	171
8.6.3	During War (Jus in Bello) & After War (Jus post Bellum)	171
8.6.4	Purpose & Exam Application	171
9	Service Delivery, Codes, Transparency, Accountability & Probity	173
9.1	Just War Theory — During War and After War	173
9.1.1	During War (Jus in Bello) — Principles	173
9.1.2	After War (Jus Post Bellum) — Principles	174
9.2	Quality of Service Delivery	174
9.2.1	Definition	174

9.2.2	Parameters of Quality of Service Delivery	174
9.2.3	Reasons for Poor Quality of Service Delivery	177
9.3	Code of Conduct and Code of Ethics	179
9.3.1	The Three-Tiered Framework (Second ARC Recommendation)	179
9.3.2	Understanding Code of Conduct	179
9.3.3	Understanding Code of Ethics	180
9.3.4	Relationship Between the Three Tiers	180
9.3.5	Code of Conduct is Application of Code of Ethics in Specific Situations	181
9.3.6	Limitations of Code of Conduct	181
9.3.7	Why Code of Ethics Is Important	182
9.4	Citizen Charter	183
9.4.1	Background and Context	183
9.4.2	Definition and Components	183
9.4.3	Case Studies	184
9.4.4	Purpose and Significance	184
9.4.5	Limitations of Citizen Charter	184
9.4.6	Measures to Improve (Second ARC Recommendations)	185
9.5	Work Culture	186
9.5.1	Definition	186
9.5.2	Dimensions of Work Culture	186
9.5.3	Positive Work Culture — Characteristics and Examples	186
9.5.4	Negative Work Culture — Characteristics and Examples	187
9.5.5	Determinants of Work Culture	187
9.6	Transparency and Accountability	188
9.6.1	Transparency	188
9.6.2	Accountability	188
9.6.3	Traditional Forms of Accountability	189
9.6.4	Limitations of Traditional Accountability	189
9.6.5	Social Accountability Mechanisms	190
9.7	Social Audit	190
9.7.1	Definition	190
9.7.2	Why Social Audit Is Needed	191
9.7.3	How Social Audit Works (MNAREGA Example)	191
9.7.4	Case Study: Meghalaya	191
9.7.5	Benefits of Social Audit	192
9.7.6	Limitations of Social Audit	192
9.8	Right to Information (RTI)	193
9.8.1	Overview	193
9.8.2	RTI as a Social Accountability Tool	193
9.8.3	Benefits of RTI	194
9.8.4	Limitations and Challenges of RTI Implementation	194
9.9	Probity in Governance	195
9.9.1	Probity vs. Integrity	196

9.9.2	Reasons for Declining Probity	196
9.9.3	Philosophical Basis of Probity in Governance	197
9.10	Utilization of Public Funds	198
9.10.1	Overview	198
9.10.2	Reasons for Under-Utilization of Public Funds	198
9.10.3	Reasons for Mis-Utilization of Public Funds	200
9.10.4	Measures for Better Utilization	200

Ethics and Human Interface

1.1 Values

1.1.1 Meaning of Values

When we say something is “valuable”, we mean that it is important to us. To call a pen or a phone valuable is to attach a degree of importance or significance to it — perhaps because it is costly, or because there is emotion attached to it.

KEY CONCEPT

- Values are the degree of importance and significance that we attach to something.
- As human beings we prefer different things, and each preference reflects a value.

EXAMPLE

- Raghukul (Ramayana): “Raghukul reet sada chali aayi, praan jaaye par vachan na jaaye” — one must uphold one’s promise even at the cost of one’s life. Upholding promises is therefore a core value of Raghukul, because that is what they find most important.
- Tribals find the forest valuable — not merely for economic livelihood, but as a way of life. They are culturally dependent on it, often believe their ancestors live in it, and derive immense solidarity from it. The forest is central to their entire existence.
- For Gandhiji, non-violence was supremely important. When the Chauri Chaura incident occurred, he withdrew the Non-Cooperation Movement because independence itself was not desirable to him at the cost of violence — non-violence was clearly the more preferable value.

1.1.2 Types of Values — Moral, Immoral and Amoral

A preference can carry a moral dimension, an immoral dimension, or no moral dimension at all. This gives three categories of values.

Moral values Moral values are those preferences that, by widely held standards, are considered right — for example honesty and loyalty. Satyavadi Harishchandra, who preferred truth above all, embodies a moral value.

Immoral values Immoral values are preferences generally regarded as wrong. A greedy person prefers greed above everything, so greed becomes that person’s value — an immoral one. For a rapist, lust becomes more important than human dignity, which is again an immoral value.

CRITICAL POINT

When we indulge in inhuman acts — the Madhya Pradesh incident of urinating on another person, imputing a person's limb as “justice”, bonded labour, manual scavenging, rape, or human trafficking — we fail to treat other human beings as human beings. In such actions we are bereft of human values.

Amoral values Amoral values are preferences that carry no connotation of righteousness or wrongness. Liking a particular singer, colour, clothing or music is an amoral preference — you cannot be called wrong for preferring blue, or for liking Arijit Singh.

EXAMPLE

Preferring the colour white over black is an amoral choice. But saying “I love white people and hate black people” is immoral, because it introduces race and denies the equal humanity of others.

KEY CONCEPT

Attitude, like values, can also be moral, immoral or amoral. An attitude that carries no connotation of right or wrong — such as one's attitude towards a pen — is an amoral attitude.

1.1.3 Relative Hierarchy of Values

A human being holds many values at once. You may value time spent with loved ones, your career ambition of becoming a civil servant, and your own health — all simultaneously, and all as part of a single value system.

EXAMPLE

Prelims is tomorrow, and your best friend arrives insisting on a party. You value your friend, and you also value becoming an IAS officer. Both are genuine values, and here they collide.

KEY CONCEPT

- Values have an internal, relative hierarchy — we prefer some over others.
- This hierarchy is contextual and dynamic; it keeps changing with circumstances.
- At present, becoming a civil servant may be the top priority, so that you are temporarily unable to give full time to health or to loved ones.

1.1.4 Ethical Dilemmas Arising from Value Conflict

An ethical dilemma occurs when you are unable to decide between two competing ethical claims — where both options are ethical, yet you cannot pursue both.

EXAMPLE

- Sunil, a young and dynamic SP, is posted in a district where illegal sand mining is rampant. When he acts against it, the mining mafia threatens to harm his family. On one side is his responsibility towards his family; on the other is his duty and integrity. Both are ethical values,

and the competing claims create a dilemma. Such dilemmas are resolved through ethical reasoning (utilitarianism and other frameworks, to be studied later).

- COVID warriors continued their duty knowing that anyone's life could be at risk. Their choice reflects selflessness and the public-service philosophy — upholding one's duty even at great personal cost.
- Bhishma Pitamah (Mahabharata) took an oath to serve Hastinapur faithfully and held to it because the oath was tied to his very identity; for him it was the most important thing.

QUICK REVISION

- Individuals hold multiple obligations and value systems at once.
- When their relative hierarchy is clear, we act; when it is not, a dilemma arises.
- Dilemmas are resolved by ethical reasoning, developed through case studies.

1.2 Collective Values

Values are not only individualistic; they are also collective. Great individuals — Daanvir Karna, Bhishma Pitamah, Satyavadi Harishchandra, and Gandhiji (non-violence, Satyagraha) — are known by the values they upheld throughout their lives, and those values guided their decision-making. But preferences held in common by a group are collective values.

1.2.1 Family Values

Families play a huge role in the inculcation of values, so many of a person's standards are shaped from childhood. Discipline can be a collective value of police or army families; respecting elders is a collective family value; and patriarchal families collectively hold patriarchal values.

1.2.2 Societal Values

Different societies hold different collective values, and these shape everyday behaviour.

Attribute	Urban society	Rural society
Dominant value	Individualism	Collectivism
Sense of belonging	Weaker; people think of themselves	Stronger; “our own people”
Response to a road accident	Fewer people stop to help	More likely to help — higher social capital

EXAMPLE

- Japanese society: discipline is a collective value — civic sense lets huge numbers cross intersections without a jam; cleanliness is another collective value.
- Okinawa community (Japan): many people average more than 100 years of age, and one

stated reason is the strong sense of belongingness in the community, which is treated as an extension of one's own life.

- Scandinavian / Nordic countries: trust is the collective value system — items left in a train or washroom remain safe. Trust-based societies see crime fall; privacy is also treated as very important there.

CRITICAL POINT

Suspicion-based societies rely on instruments like speed cameras on highways; trust-based societies need fewer such controls, and crime declines as a result.

Many social problems are driven by collective societal values rather than by government alone — dowry, corruption, air pollution, paper leaks, and the criminalisation of politics. Corruption, for instance, has a demand side rooted in society, not only a supply side in government.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

“Corruption is the manifestation of the failure of core values of society.” A major reason corruption persists is the failure of societal values — we glorify those who have prospered by wrong means, engage in hero-worship of criminals, and celebrate the wrong role models in films and popular culture.

EXAMPLE

Negative societal values in India: roughly 23% of girls are married before 18 years of age, showing that child marriage remains prevalent even though it is illegal; domestic violence, though ethically and legally wrong, is still normalised in places.

1.2.3 Constitutional Values

The Constitution too has a collective value system. It collectively prefers and attaches importance to justice, liberty, equality and fraternity, and to being sovereign, socialist, secular, democratic and republic.

KEY CONCEPT

- These constitutional values are moral values, collectively preferred by the Constitution.
- Taken together they constitute constitutional morality — the spirit of the Constitution, which lies much beyond its mere letters.

1.2.4 Organizational & Professional Values

Sphere	Collective value system	Consequence for work culture
Private sector	Profit-making, efficiency, confidentiality	Faster decision-making
Public sector	Public interest	Slower decisions — accountability, public money, elaborate checks and balances
Medical profession	Hippocratic oath — saving the patient's life	Duty to preserve life
ISRO	Frugality, innovation	Low-cost missions (Chandrayaan / Mangalyaan cheaper than a film budget)

Values thus operate at the level of the individual, the family, society, the Constitution, organizations, and professions. ISRO's frugality is even treated as a national value, just as an entrepreneur may stand for the value of entrepreneurship.

EXAMPLE

- Tribal societies hold collective values of egalitarianism, solidarity and contentment (santosh). "Tribe" means a group of people with a common characteristic; the belief that all members descend from a common ancestor produces a strong sense of solidarity.
- Communities may hold wildlife management as a collective value.
- Societies may collectively value materialism (consumerism) or spiritualism.

QUICK REVISION

- Values operate at individual, family, societal, constitutional, organizational and professional levels.
- Urban societies lean individualistic; rural and tribal societies lean collective (solidarity, egalitarianism).
- Collective societal values explain many public problems (corruption, dowry, pollution) and their solutions.
- Constitutional morality is the collective moral value system of the Constitution — its spirit beyond its letter.

1.3 Meaning of Ethics

Having understood values — the degree of preference and importance attached to something — we turn to ethics itself. When we judge a human behaviour as right or wrong, we do so against some standard. If we fail to perform our duty and call that behaviour wrong, then duty is functioning as the ethical standard.

KEY CONCEPT

- Ethics = the standards on the basis of which we evaluate human actions as right or wrong.
- For example, media ethics are the standards applied to the media — such as the requirement that information be verified before it is published.

1.3.1 Sources of Ethics

Ethical standards — the source of our judgment of right and wrong — are shaped by several factors.

- Religion: each religion prescribes principles. Jainism emphasises non-violence; Buddhism teaches the middle path and that desire is the root cause of sorrow; Hindu, Muslim and Christian traditions each give their own ethical principles.
- The Gita — Nishkaam Karma: act without attachment to the consequences or rewards; perform your duty as a duty, because it is the right thing to do.
- Culture: the culture we are born into tells us what is right and wrong — for example, the norms of the Bishnoi community, whose members would regard a violation of their conservation ethic as unethical.
- Law: law also prescribes standards of right and wrong.

Thus the ethical judgment of right and wrong is shaped by many factors together — culture, religion and law among them.

1.4 Ethics vs Morals

Both ethics and morals are standards that tell us what is right and what is wrong. The distinction lies in their source.

KEY CONCEPT

- Ethics = standards that are external to us — those prescribed to us by law, family, custom, culture or religion.
- Morals = standards that are intrinsic to us — our own personal judgment of what is right and wrong.

EXAMPLE

- If your family tells you “do not steal”, that is an ethical standard (externally prescribed). If you yourself also believe stealing is wrong, that is your moral standard. Here ethics and morals coincide.
- If your family tells you not to marry inter-caste but you believe such marriage is perfectly right, then your morals diverge from the externally prescribed ethical standard, and the two come into conflict.

Basis	Ethics	Morals
Source	External — prescribed to us	Internal — our own judgment
Subjectivity	More uniform / objective	More subjective; varies person to person
Enforcement	Usually backed by external sanctions (religious, social, professional, organizational)	Rely on internal guilt, shame and regret

CRITICAL POINT

Because ethical standards are externally applied, they tend to be relatively uniform for a group and come with sanctions — a professional body or organization can punish a breach. Moral standards, being intrinsic, are enforced only by one's own conscience.

A whistleblower who exposes wrongdoing despite the risk of being fired is typically driven by moral sanction — the inability to carry the guilt of staying silent while people are harmed.

1.4.1 When Ethics and Morals Conflict

Ethics and morals can go hand in hand when you believe in the standards prescribed to you; they conflict when your personal morality diverges from those external standards.

EXAMPLE

- A lawyer defends a client and secures a fair trial because professional ethics demand representation, even if the lawyer personally believes the client is guilty.
- A doctor is bound by medical ethics to save a patient's life — even a criminal's — regardless of personal feeling.
- A vegetarian appointed chairman of a fishery board faces conflict when professional ethics demand promoting fishing against a personal moral stance.
- A Christian may face conflict when religion (external ethics) holds abortion to be wrong, while her personal morality asserts bodily autonomy — for instance where the pregnancy resulted from rape.
- Untouchability was considered ethical by society under the purity–pollution principle, but reformers such as Dr B.R. Ambedkar knew intrinsically it could never be right and argued against it.
- A student's own morality may be against wearing the hijab while society or the government prescribes it — ethics and morals again collide.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Guru Nanak emphasised “kirat” — doing one's work honestly — and upheld the dignity of labour against the idea that certain occupations are polluting or menial. The notion of untouchability sprang precisely from the purity–pollution belief that some jobs were impure.

1.5 Ethics vs Law

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

The interface of ethics and law is one of the most important themes of the paper — a question on this theme appears almost every year.

Both ethics and law tell us what is the right thing to do. Law tells us not to indulge in corruption, not to take dowry, that domestic violence and triple talaq are wrong. Ethics tells us the same. The differences lie elsewhere.

Basis	Law	Ethics
How it is made	Follows a due procedure / due process	No corresponding due process; not every ethical standard becomes law
Subjectivity	More objective and uniform — all governed by the same law	More subjective — different societies hold different standards
Enforcement	Formal institutions — police, judiciary, prison	Lacks formal institutions of enforcement
Breadth	Narrower — minimum morality	Broader — maximum morality

KEY CONCEPT

Law is minimum morality; ethics is maximum morality. Not every ethical standard is legally enforced.

EXAMPLE

- Not all fundamental duties are legally enforced: not voting is generally regarded as unethical, yet a citizen cannot be punished for it.
- Marital rape is not illegal — one cannot be tried for it in court — yet it is unethical, because consent is absent.

1.5.1 Legal but Unethical

Because law is only minimum morality, many actions are perfectly legal yet remain unethical, since the actor is unaware of, or ignores, a higher set of ethical obligations.

- Emergency in India: declared legally and constitutionally, with all procedures followed, yet unethical because it violated the democratic spirit.
- Abuse of discretion: a Governor who sits indefinitely on a bill, a Speaker who misuses anti-defection powers to manufacture a government, or the passing of a bill as a money bill to bypass Rajya Sabha scrutiny — each is technically legal but grossly unethical and anti-democratic, because an elected government's mandate must be respected.
- Bulldozer justice: demolishing a house citing violation of construction norms is technically legal, but selective demolition of only one house while similar violations nearby are ignored

is grossly unethical. The Supreme Court has questioned exactly this selective application — “show me the man, I will show you the rule.”

- Surrogate advertisements: brands such as Kingfisher and Imperial Blue advertise “drinking water” or soda to bypass the ban on alcohol advertising — legal, but unethical.
- Road-accident compensation: tribunals compute compensation by factoring in the income the deceased was earning, effectively putting a price tag on human life. This is legal but unethical — it treats human beings merely as a means, not as an end in themselves, and implies one life is worth more than another.
- Parliamentary practice: fewer sitting days and referring bills to committees only rarely is legal but unethical, since it weakens parliamentary accountability.

DATA & FACTS

- In India, less than a fifth — around 20% — of bills are referred to a parliamentary committee.
- By contrast, in the UK bills are examined by committees of both Houses.
- Bureaucratic red-tapism: using rules as an instrument to harass individuals, with rules becoming ends in themselves, is legal but grossly unethical — it violates the dignity of the citizen.

EXAMPLE

- T.N. Seshan used the very same rules and powers of the Election Commission — powers that were in fact reduced when it became a multi-member commission — in a highly positive manner to enhance governance. The Supreme Court observed that the ECI’s history can be divided into a pre-Seshan and a post-Seshan phase. The lesson: a positive-minded officer uses the same rules to improve governance, while a negative-minded officer misuses them to harass citizens.
- PM’s moral appeals: violating a moral appeal (for example on giving up a subsidy) may be perfectly legal, yet unethical in the contemporary context.

1.5.2 *Illegal but Ethical*

The converse also exists: some actions are illegal yet ethical, often where the law itself is unethical.

- Civil disobedience: Gandhiji broke the salt law — illegal, but ethical, because the law itself was not ethical.
- Abortion: abortion is banned in several US states, so performing it there may be illegal, yet it can be ethical.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Unbanked Direct Blood Transfusion (UDBT): in India, civilians must source blood legally from recognised blood banks, and direct person-to-person transfusion is not permitted (though it is allowed for army personnel). Yet in remote areas and emergencies — road accidents, or heavy blood loss during childbirth that can be fatal — blood is screened for basic compatibility (blood group, STDs, hepatitis B) and transfused directly to save a life. This is illegal but ethical. The Drug

Technology Advisory Board (DTAB) was asked to allow it, but there is a countervailing concern about controlling the transmission of disease.

1.5.3 *Right vs Right*

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

“Ethics is knowing the difference between what you have a right to do and what is the right thing to do.” (PYQ.)

Here the “right to do” is your entitlement, while the “right thing to do” is the ethically correct action. The two can diverge.

EXAMPLE

- Students have every right to keep asking doubts, but constantly doing so is not the right thing, as it disrupts the pace of the class and everyone’s learning.
- You have the right not to help a road-accident victim — no one can force you — but helping is the right thing to do.
- A state government has the right to recover a farm loan, but during a drought that may not be the right thing to do, which is why farm-loan waivers are granted.
- The right to seek information under RTI can be misused by filing excessive requests to harass an office — an entitlement exercised in a way that is not the right thing to do.

1.6 Constitutional Morality

When one is caught between ethics and law, the guiding concept is constitutional morality.

KEY CONCEPT

Constitutional morality refers to the principles and values enshrined in the Constitution — not just the letter but the spirit of the Constitution; not just its literal interpretation but its underlying spirit.

EXAMPLE

- Maneka Gandhi case: earlier the test was merely “procedure established by law” — whether an action complied with the procedure. But the procedure itself may not be right, so the Court moved to the principles of natural justice and “due process of law” — the spirit of the Constitution.
- Article 21: its literal meaning is very narrow, yet the courts have expanded it enormously — to environment, housing and the right to privacy — by going by the spirit of the Constitution. The Sabarimala judgment is another instance of reasoning from spirit rather than letter.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- RTI Act: the provision that Public Information Officers must render “reasonable assistance” to applicants can be read narrowly (“the website is there, check it”) or, by an officer guided by constitutional morality, broadly — breaking linguistic and financial barriers and actively helping the applicant file the request.
- Article 19: imposing Section 144 merely to silence criticism would be following the letter, not the spirit, of “reasonable restriction”.

CRITICAL POINT

The letter of the Constitution is constitutional law; constitutional morality is the wider ethics — the spirit. Decision-making should be guided by the spirit, not merely the letter.

Constitutional morality is a collective responsibility of all stakeholders, not of government alone. Citizens uphold it by discharging their fundamental duties and the ideal of fraternity — avoiding hate speech and caste-based conflict; parents uphold it through their duties (Article 51A); and the State upholds it through its own conduct.

QUICK REVISION

- Constitutional morality = following the spirit, not merely the letter, of the Constitution.
- It is upheld collectively by citizens, families and the State.
- In any law–ethics interface answer, conclude that constitutional morality should guide decision-making — having the right to do something does not mean one should do it.

1.7 Determinants of Ethics**KEY CONCEPT**

- Determinants of ethics are the factors that help in both the formation and the evolution of ethical standards.
- Ethical standards do not remain static; they also evolve and change over time.

1.7.1 Institutional & Human Determinants

- Religion: different religions emerged across human history, each adding ethical standards — Buddhism (the middle path; desire as the root cause of sorrow) and Jainism (Anekantavada — multiple versions of truth). This is why questions ask how the teachings of Buddhism, Mahavira or Jainism remain relevant today: their ethical standards continue to guide humanity.
- Legislature: by passing laws it changes the meaning of right and wrong — online betting apps that were legal have been made illegal; triple talaq, once accepted, has been rendered unjust.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

India became the first country to legally mandate CSR through the Companies Act, 2013 — a

clear example of the legislature acting as a determinant of ethics.

- Executive and Judiciary: through orders and judgments they reshape our perspective on right and wrong. The Maneka Gandhi case shifted the norm from “procedure established by law” to “due process of law”; the Kesavananda Bharati case established that all parts of the Constitution can be amended except the basic structure.
- Individuals (self-reflection): Ashoka, after the Kalinga war, turned to peace and propagated it through the Ashokan pillars, changing society’s ethical outlook; Raja Ram Mohan Roy campaigned against Sati Pratha and thereby changed the ethical standards of society.
- Society — family and culture: the family and culture we are born into shape our standards. Cultural norms (as with the Bishnoi community) are hard to change because we are status-quoist by nature.
- Professional institutions: media ethics, engineering ethics and medical ethics each shape conduct within a profession.

1.7.2 *Technology as a Determinant*

Technology plays a huge role in reshaping ethical standards.

EXAMPLE

- AI and copyright — the Anthropic case: a US court ruled that training AI on books without permission amounted to fair use, because the model creates something substantially new (a new common good) rather than reproducing the original. However, the storage of pirated books in a library constituted copyright infringement, and the company was held liable for that. Thus the meaning of copyright is itself shifting because of technological innovation.
- The EU’s GDPR regime protects personal data as intrusive technology grows.
- The UK is moving to introduce laws against AI tools used to generate sexual-abuse images — new technology forcing new ethical and legal standards.

1.7.3 *Economic & Global Determinants*

- Economic models: the rise of the gig economy and informal work is changing older norms. Gujarat amended its Factories Act to allow women to work night shifts and longer hours — what was once considered just is reinterpreted as new economic models emerge.
- Globalization and multilateral frameworks: India moved from process patent to product patent after signing the TRIPS agreement. A process patent protects only the method of making a product (weaker protection); a product patent protects the product itself (stronger protection). Changing global norms on intellectual property made what was earlier just now unjust.
- Nagoya Protocol — Access and Benefit Sharing: benefits must be shared with the community whose resources are used (detailed treatment belongs to environment, not ethics).
- Thinkers: during the French Revolution, when atrocities were justified in the name of religion, Voltaire said that God lives in the human heart and not in churches — changing people’s thinking and ethical standards. Revolutions use literature, media and the press to spread new ideas such as humanism.

1.7.4 Evolution of Norms — The Concept of Justice

The clearest illustration of evolving ethical standards is the concept of justice, which has moved from retribution to rehabilitation.

Aspect	Earlier understanding	Present understanding
Aim of justice	Retribution — punishment-oriented	Rehabilitation and reformation
Treatment of offenders	Imputing a limb was seen as justice	Rejected — even dreaded criminals have human rights, a fair trial and dignity
Guiding code	IPC — Indian Penal Code (penalty)	BNS — Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (nyaya / complete justice, attitude change)

CRITICAL POINT

The same action — mutilating a criminal — was considered just in the past but is unjust today, because our understanding of justice has evolved to include human rights. Even a dreaded leader's body is buried as per norms; everyone deserves a fair trial and protection of dignity. This shift is reflected in community service as a form of punishment under the new code.

Similar evolution is visible elsewhere: the expansion of human rights and the recognition of the right to privacy under Article 21 (driven partly by intrusive technology, hence GDPR); and the recognition of LGBT rights — once considered unethical, now just — as our understanding of gender and sexual orientation has evolved.

1.7.5 Changing Context Must Be Under Constant Scrutiny

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

“What was just some time back may turn out to be unjust.” Changing context should therefore be kept under constant scrutiny.

EXAMPLE

- Copyright standards must be re-examined as technology changes, or they lag behind reality.
- Early maturity — Juvenile Justice Act: earlier no person below 18 could be tried as an adult even for a heinous crime; recognising that maturity may be attained before the biological age of 18, the law now allows a juvenile to be tried as an adult in heinous cases, so that such offenders do not go scot-free — otherwise it would be a travesty of justice.
- Romeo-Juliet clause — POCSO Act: since there is no concept of consensual sex where one partner is a minor, genuine relationships can be caught by the law, and the provision is misused by families to target the boy. Courts have observed that changing context must be understood to prevent a miscarriage of justice.
- Facial tattooing: tribal girls once received facial tattoos to appear unattractive and avoid

sexual exploitation by landlords and others during and before British rule; with that context gone, the standard around the custom changes.

- Officials performed the last rites of Baswaraju — reflecting the evolution of the value of human dignity.

QUICK REVISION

- Determinants are all the factors that form and evolve ethical standards.
- Institutions (religion, legislature, executive, judiciary, professions), individuals, society and culture all contribute.
- Technology, economic models, globalization and thinkers are key contemporary determinants.
- Norms evolve — justice from retribution to rehabilitation, expansion of human rights and privacy — so changing context must be scrutinised constantly.

Consequences of Ethics and Applied Ethics

2.1 Consequences of Ethics

Consequences are one of the most effective ways to make people understand the importance of any particular thing — including ethics. Warning labels on cigarette packs, a teacher warning students that they will fail if they do not practise answer writing, religious traditions warning of divine punishment — all these are appeals to consequences. The same logic applies to ethics: why should one be ethical? Because of the consequences of being ethical (and of not being ethical).

Consequences operate at multiple levels: individual, organisational, societal, and national/global.

2.1.1 Why Individuals Should Be Ethical

Survival Being ethical is important for our very biological survival. Formal institutions of the state — police, judiciary, and the military — will eliminate those who are grossly unethical. Terrorists and extremists are killed because they have crossed the minimum threshold of ethical acceptability for society. Drug and alcohol addiction destroy physical health; unethical use of one's own body is, therefore, ultimately harmful to one's survival.

EXAMPLE

Drug addiction and alcohol addiction impair physical health — a person who is addicted is not being dutiful towards himself. If you indulge in heinous crimes, society will not allow you to survive; formal institutions will eliminate you.

Psychological Well-Being Even when unethical behaviour goes unpunished externally, it exacts a psychological price. Conscience generates guilt, regret and shame. A person who has committed corruption, for instance, may profit materially, but deep down they know what they have done — and long-term psychological peace is impossible without ethical conduct. Choosing not to discharge one's duty may feel comfortable in the short term, but will not produce happiness in the long run.

KEY CONCEPT

Psychological well-being requires that we examine our conduct. An unexamined life eventually produces dissatisfaction even if material success is achieved.

Quality of Interpersonal Relationships Human beings are social animals; the quality of our relationships is a major determinant of the quality of our life. Ethics — especially honesty and trustworthiness — is the foundation of good relationships. The classic illustration is the story of

“The Boy Who Cried Wolf”: habitual lying destroys credibility, and when the wolf actually comes, no one trusts him. The consequence is isolation and helplessness.

DATA & FACTS

- Rising divorce rates and the breakdown of family structures are partly consequences of the erosion of trust in intimate relationships.
- Trust breakdown in relationships, sometimes labelled as the “Blue Drum Syndrome”, is a consequence of declining ethical conduct in personal life.

Professional Success and Fulfilment Ethics enables professional success in two distinct ways: instrumental success (promotion, credibility, leadership) and intrinsic fulfilment (deriving meaning and satisfaction from work). When you are honest, duty-bound, and committed, your profession becomes a source of meaning.

EXAMPLE

- “Missile Man” Dr A.P.J. Abdul Kalam — the depth of his commitment to his duty made science his greatest source of fulfilment; his career and character became inseparable.
- A ranker from 2013 (Pawan Singh Rana, rank 249) who came from a very humble background in Bihar; when such students succeed, it is the outcome of commitment to purpose and duty. The satisfaction on seeing a student succeed is itself an example of how a profession becomes a source of fulfilment when one is duty-bound.

Ethics is connected to professional growth in concrete economic terms as well: ethical conduct builds the credibility needed to receive better opportunities, command respect, attract cheaper credit, and earn trust that leads to leadership.

KEY CONCEPT

Nishkaam Karma (Bhagavad Gita): do your duty without attachment to the fruits. When work is done with this spirit, it becomes a source of meaning rather than merely a means to an end.

Leadership and Credibility Respect cannot be commanded; it must be earned. Great leaders — Mahatma Gandhi, Swami Vivekananda, Ramakrishna Paramahansa, Subhash Chandra Bose, Bhagat Singh — earned respect through ethical conduct. This is true at every level: a manager who is committed and ethical over years becomes the person the organization can rely on, the one who gets promoted, the one whose team follows with genuine commitment.

Living a Purposeful Life — Going Beyond Animalistic Existence Human beings are higher-order animals. A tiger that kills a human is never judged as wrong; but a human being who kills another is judged — because human beings are endowed with higher cognitive faculties that allow us to distinguish right from wrong. Ethics calls on us to use those faculties; it lifts us beyond mere animalistic existence to a life with purpose.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- “Life is a long journey between human being and being human.” — UPSC topic. All of us are

born human beings; to live a life worthy of being called human, we must be ethical.

- “It is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied.” (J.S. Mill.) A pig cannot distinguish between higher-quality and lower-quality pleasures; a human being, by contrast, has an ethical compass that enables the choice of higher pleasures even at the cost of dissatisfaction. A rapist, a cheater, a paper-leaker behaves more like a pig — gratifying a lower impulse.
- “The unexamined life is not worth living.” (Socrates.) Ethics compels introspection; introspection makes life purposeful.

EXAMPLE

- Valmiki (Ramayana): once a dacoit (Ratnakar), he was robbing people to feed his family. Naradmuni asked him whether his family would share in the punishment for the crimes he committed to feed them. They refused. This made him realise the consequences of his unexamined life, and he transformed. The same introspective journey changed his life completely.
- King Ashoka: after the Kalinga War, introspection transformed him into “Ashoka the Great” — he propagated peace through the Ashokan Pillars.
- Prince Siddhartha became Gautam Buddha through the same process: examining the reality of suffering led to transformation.
- Narendra Nath Datta became Swami Vivekananda.
- Meer Jafar, Dola Rai — examples of those who chose betrayal; history’s memory of them illustrates the legacy consequences of unethical choices.

KEY CONCEPT

- Ethics helps us in realising our potential — what Socrates called Eudaimonia: the fulfilment of higher-order needs. As a civil services aspirant, you will never realise your potential if you do not examine and improve your conduct.
- Ethics allows us to create a legacy that outlasts our lives.

QUICK REVISION

Individuals should be ethical for: (1) survival, (2) physical well-being, (3) psychological well-being, (4) quality of interpersonal relationships, (5) professional success and credibility, (6) leadership, (7) purposeful life / Eudaimonia, (8) creating legacy.

2.1.2 Why Organisations Should Be Ethical

The same reasoning extends to organisations, both private and public. The consequences of organisational ethics (and its absence) operate in several dimensions.

- Brand value and consumer trust: an unethical organisation loses brand value and the trust of consumers. Without trust, word-of-mouth collapses, marketing costs rise, and revenue falls.
- Work culture, talent retention and motivation: discrimination on the basis of caste, religion

or gender in an organisation destroys morale and motivation. People will not want to work hard if meritocracy is absent. Conversely, an organisation that promotes employee well-being, mental health, and innovation — for example, where thoughtful failures are not punished — attracts the best talent and drives productivity.

- Efficiency and sustainability: corruption within an organisation creates severe inefficiency. As Rajiv Gandhi noted, when 1 rupee is spent, only 16 paise reaches the intended beneficiary. Blue Smart cab case — the founder misappropriated investor funds to buy a personal flat worth Rs. 100 crore; the company is now shutting down. Satyam scam — the company colluded with its auditors to falsify accounts and show inflated profits; the deception unravelled.

CRITICAL POINT

“You can fool some of the people some of the time, but not all the people all the time.” Unethical behaviour in organisations ultimately surfaces and causes catastrophic collapse.

- Good governance tools: JAM trinity (Jan Dhan, Aadhaar, Mobile) and the Government e-Marketplace (GeM) portal for tendering are examples of technology deployed to make procurement transparent and curb corruption — ensuring fair price discovery.
- Accountability and role modelling: when employees are held accountable and leadership models ethical behaviour, motivation is high, there is strong teamwork, and the organisation commands credibility.

2.1.3 Why Society Should Be Ethical

- Tolerance: tolerance means respecting difference, even if you do not accept it. Without tolerance, science and art cannot grow — Galileo’s heliocentric theory was condemned because of religious intolerance for a different scientific opinion. Censorship and intolerance stifle scientific temper, innovation, and artistic expression. Mob lynching and communal violence are direct consequences of the absence of tolerance in society.
- Social harmony and fraternity: harmony means that different communities, castes, and groups can co-exist. Without it, divisions grow, leading to conflict and collective harm.
- Social mobility: in an ascriptive society — where what you achieve is decided by the identity you are born with (caste, gender, religion) — mobility is very low. No matter how talented a person is, they cannot move out of the occupation assigned by birth. Ethics demands fairness and equal opportunity; without it, talented people are wasted.

EXAMPLE

Women: many talented women quit their careers because they bear a disproportionate share of household work — physical mobility itself is restricted for women in many contexts. If women cricketers face structural disadvantages from childhood (training camps full of boys, poor infrastructure), the resulting performance gap cannot be attributed simply to lower ability. We must look beyond the objective measure to the structural inequity behind it. If 100 men and 100 women have equal average IQ, but men are given 10 times more opportunity to develop skills, the outcome will falsely appear meritocratic.

- Rule of law: mob lynching is what happens when people lose faith in rule of law and take justice

into their own hands. If people are not ethical enough to believe in and follow institutions, rule of law collapses.

- Innovation: intolerance and censorship suppress thought, which suppresses innovation.
- Cultural foundation: art and culture grow only in an environment of freedom and tolerance. Censorship damages cultural production.
- Sustainable development: Bhutan collectively measures Gross National Happiness rather than only GDP — a societal ethical choice to value well-being over mere growth.
- Public health: open defecation, poor waste management, air pollution, and malnutrition in women due to patriarchal food-distribution norms are all public-health consequences of societal ethical failures.
- Social capital: social capital is the network of relationships and mutual trust in a society. Where social capital is high — as in a village community where the entire neighbourhood participates in a wedding, or the custom of Kanyadaan where even uninvited people contribute — the community can collectively face adversity. Distrust and individualism erode social capital; trust-based societies need fewer formal enforcement mechanisms, have lower crime, and show greater co-operative capacity.
- Trust in institutions: when government and public institutions are unethical, they lose legitimacy. Citizens withdraw trust, common goods are not provided, and the state loses its reason for existence.

QUICK REVISION

- Societal ethics produces: tolerance, social harmony, social mobility, rule of law, innovation, cultural growth, sustainability, public health, social capital, and trust in institutions.
- Conversely, unethical societies exhibit mob lynching, communal violence, gender and caste discrimination, corruption, and declining social capital.

2.2 Dimensions of Ethics

Ethics has both a theoretical dimension and an applied/practical dimension. The theoretical dimension deals with the foundational philosophical standards and frameworks; the applied dimension is the application of those ethical principles in specific professional or social domains.

2.2.1 Normative (Theoretical) Dimension

A norm is a prescription of behaviour — a guideline about what one is supposed to do. Normative ethics is therefore prescriptive ethics: it tells us what ethical standards we should follow. Just as different family members give different advice about what to do, different schools of thought within normative ethics prescribe different standards.

KEY CONCEPT

The three major normative frameworks are: (1) Deontological ethics, (2) Teleological ethics, and (3) Virtue ethics.

Deontological Ethics Focus: means and duty. An action is ethical if the means used are right and if one is doing one's duty — regardless of the consequences. The rightness of an action lies in the action itself, not in its outcomes.

EXAMPLE

- If you cheat in an exam to clear it, deontology says the action is wrong — because the means (cheating) are impure, even though the outcome (clearing the exam) may be desirable.
- Poonam Pandey case — she faked her own death to raise awareness about cervical cancer. A deontologist says: the action was wrong because she lied. Means matter more than ends; you cannot do the right thing through the wrong means.

Teleological Ethics (Consequentialism) Focus: consequences and ends. An action is ethical if its consequences are good. Means are secondary; what matters is whether the outcome is right.

EXAMPLE

- Poonam Pandey case — a teleologist says: the action was right, because it raised awareness about cervical cancer, no one died, and the ends (public health awareness) were good.
- “I didn't know my food had sugar in it” — teleological ethics says you should be mindful of consequences; ignorance of consequences is not an excuse because you are responsible for them.

Virtue Ethics Focus: character of the individual. An action is ethical if it is performed by a person of good character, and if that action contributes to the development of good character. It asks not “did the action produce the right outcome?” or “were the means right?” but “what kind of person are you becoming through this action?”

KEY CONCEPT

- Virtues are positive character traits — honesty, loyalty, compassion, discipline, courage. Vices are negative character traits — greed, cowardice, dishonesty. Virtue ethics demands that we maximise our virtues and minimise our vices.
- “We are what we repeatedly do.” Virtue ethics focuses on character formation through habit. Mind your habits, not just isolated actions.

Framework	Focus	Core question	Key keyword
Deontology	Duty / means	Were the means right?	Right duty; pure means
Teleology / Consequential- ism	Consequences / ends	Were the consequences right?	Good outcome; welfare maximisation
Virtue Ethics	Character	What kind of person am I becoming?	Virtues and character formation

2.2.2 Applied (Practical) Dimension

Applied ethics is the application of ethical principles to specific domains. In every particular context, certain ethical standards become more or less important. The applied dimension asks: given these theoretical frameworks, which principles should guide decision-making in this specific area?

Applied ethics includes: environmental ethics, technology ethics, media ethics, bioethics, sports ethics, professional ethics (medical, legal, engineering), and administrative ethics. Each is discussed in the sections below.

2.3 Ethical Relativism and Ethical Absolutism

Basis	Ethical Relativism	Ethical Absolutism
Core claim	Ethical standards are contingent upon circumstances, time, and place	Ethical standards are absolute — applicable universally, irrespective of circumstance, time, or place
Implication	Right and wrong vary across societies and across time	Certain standards are universally binding on all human beings

2.3.1 Ethical Relativism

Ethical relativism holds that ethical standards are not absolute but contextual — they differ from society to society and from era to era. What is considered ethical in one time or place may be considered unethical in another.

EXAMPLE

- Eating beef is widely acceptable in Western societies but not ethical in the Indian context; McDonald's does not serve beef in India but does in the USA.
- Dress norms vary — clothes considered decent in one society may be regarded as indecent in another.

- Polygamy is practised in certain societies as a culturally sanctioned norm.
- Certain tribal communities do not wear clothing; judging them by mainstream urban standards would be imposing one culture's values on another.
- EWS reservation did not exist initially; as ethical understandings of economic fairness evolved, it was introduced.
- CSR was not legally mandatory before the Companies Act, 2013 — but evolved into a mandatory ethical obligation.
- The Juvenile Justice Act originally did not allow any juvenile below 18 to be tried as an adult even for heinous crimes; ethical standards evolved to allow it for juveniles aged 16–18 who have attained early maturity.
- Naturist communities (those who prefer to live without clothing) operate on a different but internally coherent set of norms.

Why Ethical Relativism Matters — Avoiding Ethnocentrism and Cultural Imperialism Ethnocentrism means judging another culture through the lens of one's own ethical standards — treating one's own culture as the benchmark. The danger is imposing one culture's values on others, which is called cultural imperialism.

EXAMPLE

- Colonial powers justified their colonialism as the “White Man's Burden” — the supposed duty to “civilise” the colonised peoples. This is classic cultural imperialism: imposing one's own ethical framework as universal and superior.
- Anthropologist Margaret Mead's study of Samoan society — she found that sexual norms were far more liberal there than in mainstream American society. The correct approach is to understand, not to impose one's own standards.

Ethical relativism is the intellectual defence against both ethnocentrism and cultural imperialism. We should not judge others' ethical standards through the lens of what we consider right and wrong, and we should not impose our standards on them in the name of ethical superiority.

Standardisation Due to ICT and Globalisation Information and communication technologies (ICT), the internet, and advocacy groups are increasingly standardising ethical norms across societies. Practices once considered culturally acceptable are being questioned in the light of evolved universal standards.

EXAMPLE

- Triple talaq — once considered ethically acceptable in one community, now rendered unjust by law.
- Sabarimala — the exclusion of women from a sacred space was challenged and changed.
- Sati Pratha — abolished through social reform and legislation.
- Shikari Utsav in West Bengal — certain communities celebrate this traditional hunting festival; but in the evolved context of wildlife conservation, this practice is being questioned.

- Opening of temple sacred spaces to all sections of society.

Merits and Demerits of Ethical Relativism

Merits	Demerits
Promotes tolerance of cultural diversity	Can lead to moral nihilism if taken to an extreme — if every standard is relative, then nothing can be criticised
Avoids ethnocentrism and cultural imperialism	May actually promote intolerance: e.g. Taliban-style practices justified as “our culture”
Allows ethical standards to evolve to suit changing needs of the time	Undermines moral progress — social reformers could not have challenged Sati Pratha if all standards were relative
Respects context in applying universal principles (e.g. CBDR in climate)	There are some universal standards that cannot be relativised (dignity, justice, fairness)

CRITICAL POINT

The biggest problem with extreme ethical relativism is moral nihilism: if everyone is right by their own standards (the person who says “I am right, the world is dissatisfied with even God”), then there are no standards left at all. Taliban will say “this is our culture”; Kasab may believe he was doing the right thing; a person who throws acid can claim justification in personal grievance. Once you allow each person or society to define ethics for themselves without any external standard, you cannot condemn anything. This is the fundamental demerit.

2.3.2 Ethical Absolutism

Ethical absolutism holds that certain ethical standards are absolute — they apply universally, irrespective of cultural context, time, or place. Dignity, justice, and fairness are examples of such standards. Wherever human beings are, they should be accorded basic dignity.

EXAMPLE

Imagine two workers A and B in any society anywhere in the world: both are of equal ability, work equally long, produce equal output — but one is paid X and the other 100X. In every society, the underpaid worker will experience a sense of unfairness. This universality of the sense of injustice is what ethical absolutists argue for — fairness and justice are absolute standards.

2.3.3 Reconciling Relativism and Absolutism

In practice, both absolute and relative ethical standards coexist — just as, in the Indian Constitution, certain parts (the basic structure) cannot be changed while other parts can be.

KEY CONCEPT

- Universal principles (dignity, justice, fairness) are absolute and must be respected everywhere.
- Application of those principles must be contextual and local.
- “Common But Differentiated Responsibility” (CBDR) in climate change: sustainability is a universal principle, but its application differs — developed countries have greater responsibility than developing countries because of their historical emissions.
- Juvenile Justice Act: justice is an absolute principle, but its application to a juvenile must account for local context (early maturity, heinous crime) — otherwise there will be a travesty of justice.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

UPSC question (POCSO Act case): a 13-year-old girl was found to have “married” a 25-year-old man; under POCSO there is no concept of consensual sex when one party is a minor. The man was held guilty. However, an expert panel found the victim remained committed to the accused and faced hardship from police, society, and the legal system. The Supreme Court, exercising Article 142 powers, withheld sentencing and directed the West Bengal government to ensure her welfare — because pronouncing punishment would create even greater hardship for the family. This illustrates: letter demands punishment; spirit and context demand a more sensitive application of justice. Universal principle (protect children) must be applied contextually (avoid compounding victim’s suffering).

QUICK REVISION

- Ethical relativism: standards are contingent on context, time, society. Merits: tolerance, diversity, evolution of norms. Demerits: moral nihilism, undermines moral progress.
- Ethical absolutism: certain standards (dignity, justice, fairness) are universal and non-negotiable.
- Best approach: believe in universal principles; apply them locally and contextually. CBDR is the model.

2.4 Environmental Ethics (Applied Ethics)

Applied ethics is the application of ethical principles to specific domains. Environmental ethics applies them to our relationship with the natural environment. In every environmental issue, certain ethical principles become especially important and should guide decision-making.

2.4.1 *Shallow Ecology vs Deep Ecology*

Basis	Shallow Ecology	Deep Ecology
Core view	Environment is important only insofar as it benefits humans; it has no intrinsic value of its own	Environment has intrinsic worth — irrespective of its contribution to human welfare
Decision-making perspective	Anthropocentrism: human-centric decision-making	Ecocentrism: decision-making from the perspective of the entire ecosystem
Example	Solve air pollution because it harms our health	Protect a forest because the forest itself has worth, not just because we derive timber or tourism from it

CRITICAL POINT

Anthropocentrism — greed-driven, human-centric decision-making — has driven climate change, declining soil fertility, falling groundwater levels, and deforestation. These are the consequences of always asking “what’s in it for us?” without considering the entire ecosystem.

2.4.2 *Ecocentrism*

Ecocentrism holds that decision-making about the environment should be done not just from the perspective of human beings but from the perspective of the entire ecosystem — all its biotic (humans, animals, plants) and abiotic (soil, rock, water) components and the relationships among them.

EXAMPLE

- Declaring a species as “vermin” (to be killed) is a decision that must be evaluated not just from the perspective of human convenience but from the perspective of the ecosystem as a whole. That species may play a critical role in the food chain or ecosystem stability.
- AI-enabled cameras in Shimla for tiger reserves: detecting poaching automatically is an example of technology deployed from an ecocentric perspective — protecting the ecosystem.
- E-pass systems in Ooty and Kodaikanal regulating tourist activity in ecologically sensitive areas.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

“Forests precede civilisations and deserts follow them.” Forests provide food, fodder, timber and a host of ecosystem services that sustain civilisations. When humans destroy forests out of greed, they ultimately convert fertile land to desert. This is why ecocentrism, not anthropocentrism, must guide our decisions.

2.4.3 Key Principles of Environmental Ethics

- **Stewardship:** we hold the environment in trust. “We do not inherit the environment from our ancestors; we borrow it from future generations.” (Gandhiji.) As trustee of something borrowed, you take care of it, not destroy it. This is our obligation towards future generations.
- **Justice and equity:** Polluter Pays Principle — each entity that pollutes should pay the cost of the pollution. Common But Differentiated Responsibility (CBDR) — all nations are responsible for environmental sustainability, but developed nations bear more responsibility because of their historical emissions. Justice to future generations is also demanded.
- **Precautionary Principle:** when the consequences of a technology are not fully known, err on the side of caution. Do not deploy until the risks are assessed. This is why decisions about GM crops are slow — the precautionary principle demands caution in the face of uncertainty.
- **Global perspective:** environmental decisions have global significance. Stubble burning in Punjab creates smog in Delhi; US withdrawal from the Paris Climate Deal affects the entire world. We must transcend narrow perspectives and think globally.
- **Pacifism and peace:** wars and conflicts cause massive environmental degradation — missiles, explosions, displacement. Peace is a precondition for environmental protection.
- **Rights:** animal rights are part of environmental ethics. Animals too have rights and should not be subjected to cruelty or extinction.
- **Duties — 4R:** Reduce, Reuse, Recycle, and Refuse (control consumerism). Citizens’ duty to manage waste and minimise consumption.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR): companies are responsible for taking back their electronic and plastic waste into the recycling system. This is an application of accountability and stewardship in environmental policy.

QUICK REVISION

- Shallow ecology = anthropocentrism = human-centric. Deep ecology = ecocentrism = ecosystem-centric.
- Key principles: stewardship, justice/equity (Polluter Pays, CBDR), precautionary principle, global perspective, pacifism, animal rights, 4R duties.
- Apply these principles in all environmental case studies, section-A answers, and essays.

2.5 Technology Ethics (Applied Ethics)

Technology ethics is the set of ethical principles that guide the development, deployment, and use of technology. Just as “what are ethics?” can be answered as “standards that guide decision-making about right and wrong”, technology ethics = the standards that guide our decision-making in the context of technology.

CRITICAL POINT

This is one of the most likely areas for a UPSC Mains question this year, especially on AI and deepfake. Prepare this section thoroughly.

2.5.1 Key Principles of Technology Ethics

Privacy Technology, especially digital technology, poses grave threats to privacy. End-to-end encryption on messaging apps like WhatsApp is a privacy-protection mechanism. Online transactions must be secured. The GDPR in the European Union is the most significant privacy-protection framework globally, arising directly from the intrusive capability of modern technology.

EXAMPLE

Cybercriminals impersonating bank employees and extracting OTPs lead to accounts being emptied. Security protocols and informed consent about data use are privacy-protection tools.

Transparency Whenever technology is deployed to collect or use data, people must be told what that data will be used for. Data must only be used for the purpose for which it was collected. Any app or service that accesses your data must be transparent about how it will be used.

Accountability Those who develop and deploy technology must be accountable for how it is used and misused. Technology companies are more powerful than individual users because they have proprietary knowledge of their own technology, creating an asymmetry that must be checked by accountability.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- WhatsApp messaging limits: WhatsApp took responsibility by limiting forwards to 5 recipients to curb viral spread of fake news. This is an example of a technology company taking accountability for the social consequences of its platform.
- Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) in plastic and e-waste rules: companies must take back their products and recycle them — accountability for the environmental consequences of their technology.
- DiDi (Chinese ride-hailing app): fined \$600 million for sending user data to outside the country, violating transparency and data sovereignty norms.

Fairness — Especially Critical for AI AI algorithms are trained by feeding large datasets. If the training data is biased, the algorithm will be biased, and decisions made by that AI will perpetuate or amplify existing biases.

EXAMPLE

- PM Modi's comment at an AI meet: if you prompt an AI to generate an image of a person writing with the left hand, the AI was generating an image of a person writing with the right hand — because the training data overwhelmingly contained right-handed writers. The algorithm was biased.
- Amazon's AI hiring platform: the platform was trained on resumes of existing employees

(who were predominantly male) and began systematically rejecting female candidates. The keyword “cricket” is more common in male resumes (since more males play cricket in India); the algorithm chose it as a positive indicator, further biasing towards men. Amazon shut the platform down.

If AI is used in decision-making — hiring, loan approval, bail decisions, medical diagnosis — algorithmic bias can cause profound injustice. Fairness in AI requires diverse and representative training data, regular audits, and human oversight.

Beneficence The primary intention of any technology should be to benefit humanity. Technology must be developed and deployed for the public good.

EXAMPLE

- AI-enabled CCTV cameras to monitor board examinations in Karnataka — curbing malpractice.
- AI-enabled cameras in Shimla tiger reserves — automatically alerting rangers when poaching activity is detected.
- “Nudge” letters sent by tax authorities to taxpayers: using data non-intrusively to nudge taxpayers into revising and updating their returns, generating Rs. 11,000 crore in tax revenue over four years. This is beneficent use of technology that guided and enabled rather than coerced.

Non-Maleficence “If you cannot do good, at least do not do harm.” When a technology developer is not sure of the consequences of their technology, they should refrain from deploying it, or deploy it cautiously under the precautionary principle.

EXAMPLE

Driverless cars in Indian road conditions: the unpredictability of Indian traffic, pedestrians, and infrastructure means that deploying driverless technology without adequate safeguards could cause serious harm. Non-maleficence demands caution.

Informed Consent Before any technology is used on people — particularly in medical or data contexts — people must be fully informed and must give their consent. This is what “informed consent” means: consent that is given with full knowledge of what is being agreed to.

EXAMPLE

Clinical trials for new drugs: participants must be fully informed about risks and must consent before participating — informed consent in medical technology.

Sustainability Technology must be used sustainably, not in ways that deplete resources or damage the environment for short-term gain.

EXAMPLE

- Green Revolution — groundwater pumps gave farmers access to irrigation, but farmers began growing rice in areas ecologically unsuited for it (Punjab), depleting groundwater at an unsustainable rate.

- Indiscriminate use of urea (nitrogenous fertiliser) has disrupted N-P-K ratios in soil, reducing fertility over time. Sustainable technology use would have maintained the balance.
- Sex-determination technology (ultrasound) — intended for medical diagnosis but used for sex-selective abortions, leading to a skewed sex ratio. The technology is not inherently bad; the unsustainable and unethical use of it is the problem.

Respect for Human Autonomy Technology is a tool and should remain a servant of human beings, not become their master. Technology should support and expand human choices, not manipulate or override them.

KEY CONCEPT

“Science and technology is not a panacea for growth and security of the nation.” Technology is only an instrument in human hands. Whether it creates problems or solves them depends on how humans use it: sustainably or unsustainably, transparently or opaquely, fairly or unfairly, accountably or unaccountably.

2.5.2 Challenges of Technology in Administration

Technology is increasingly deployed to deliver public services and fight corruption. But there are significant ethical challenges in this reliance.

- Digital divide: 94% of men vs. 74% of women in Haryana have access to mobile phones (20% gap). 63% of elderly people do not know how to use the internet. If all services are delivered digitally, these groups are excluded.
- Biometric failure: Aadhaar-based biometric authentication fails for manual labourers and the elderly whose fingerprints are worn or degraded. The PSE Committee flagged high failure rates of Aadhaar authentication. When biometrics fail, ration is denied — people who are already vulnerable can go without food.
- Algorithmic bias: as discussed, biased algorithms can entrench existing injustices.
- Empathy deficit: AI-driven administration lacks the compassion and empathy of human decision-making, which can be critical in sensitive cases.
- Accountability gap: when an AI makes a wrong decision, who is responsible — the algorithm, the company, or the officer who relied on it?
- Malfunction: technology can malfunction; over-reliance creates fragility.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

UPSC question theme: “Use of technology in governance: positive and negative ethical dimensions.” Positive: AI cameras in exam halls, nudge letters for tax compliance, GeM portal for transparent procurement. Negative: digital divide excluding vulnerable groups, biometric failures denying rations, algorithmic bias, empathy deficit.

QUICK REVISION

- Technology ethics principles: privacy, transparency, accountability, fairness (esp. for AI),

beneficence, non-maleficence, informed consent, sustainability, respect for autonomy.

- Challenges in administration: digital divide, biometric failure, algorithmic bias, empathy deficit, accountability gap, malfunction.
- Technology is an instrument — outcome depends on how humans use it.

2.6 Media Ethics (Applied Ethics)

Media ethics are the standards that media organisations and journalists should uphold in the collection, processing, and transmission of information, whether through print, electronic, or digital channels.

2.6.1 Key Principles of Media Ethics

Accuracy / Verification Media must verify information before transmitting it. Sharing unverified information can cause panic, social unrest, or injustice.

EXAMPLE

- Poonam Pandey case: media published the fake news of her death without verification, which was later revealed to be a stunt. Though her goal was to raise awareness about cervical cancer, the initial reporting demonstrates the danger of unverified information.
- Operation Sindoor: the government had to issue a press advisory asking media not to post about live movement of army troops. Common sense and national security demand that such restraint is the right thing to do, even though media might argue they have the freedom to report. Freedom of expression with reasonable restrictions.

Freedom with Reasonable Restrictions Media has freedom of speech and expression, but that freedom comes with reasonable restrictions — particularly on grounds of national security, sovereignty, public order, and the dignity of individuals. You may have the right to publish something, but it may not be the right thing to do.

KEY CONCEPT

“You may have a right to do something, but it may not be the right thing to do.” — right vs right interface.

Independence and Autonomy Media acts as the fourth pillar of democracy. This role requires independence from government and corporate power. Media that is not independent cannot hold power accountable.

EXAMPLE

- Sedition law / UAPA used to threaten journalists: when the state uses legal action as a tool to silence criticism, it threatens media independence.
- Government using print media advertisements as a reward (to compliant media) or withholding them as punishment (from critical media).

- Corporate takeover of media houses: when a single corporate entity controls multiple media houses, the wrongdoings of that corporate will not be reported — again threatening independence.

Impartiality and Fairness Media must be impartial in its coverage and fair to all those it reports on. When media makes up its mind before hearing all sides, it prejudices cases.

EXAMPLE

- Media trials in cases like Rhea Chakravarti or Arushi Darwar: media had already decided who the villain was before any court judgment. This is a gross failure of fairness and goes against the principle of presumption of innocence.
- Right of reply: if you are writing critically about a minister or any person, you must give them the opportunity to present their own perspective. This is a requirement of fairness.

Humanity / Compassion Coverage should be conducted with basic human compassion. People in trauma or grief deserve personal space and dignity, even if they are public figures.

EXAMPLE

When Sushant Singh Rajput died, media arrived at his family's home and pushed microphones into his grieving father's face to ask "How do you feel?" People should be allowed to grieve in personal space. Coverage must be done with compassion, not just to chase TRP.

Do Not Incite Hatred Media must not inflame hatred on grounds of nationality, religion, caste, community, or gender.

EXAMPLE

Sudarshan TV — UPSC Jihad programme: the channel ran a programme claiming to expose a "conspiracy" of Muslim candidates in the civil services. The Supreme Court found it to be communal propaganda. TRAI took action. This is a clear case of inciting hatred on grounds of religion under the guise of news.

Public Interest over Sensationalism Media should prioritise stories that matter to the public — NEET irregularities, policy failures, corruption — rather than sensationalist content or celebrity gossip. Clickbait thumbnails and TRP-driven content are not serving public interest.

Similarly, media must be able to distinguish facts from opinions. Presenting conjecture or personal interpretation as verified fact is a serious ethical violation. Social media amplifies this problem: anonymity allows people to say anything without accountability.

QUICK REVISION

- Media ethics principles: accuracy/verification, freedom with reasonable restrictions, independence & autonomy, impartiality/fairness, humanity/compassion, no incitement of hatred, public interest over sensationalism.
- Distinguish: facts (verified, objective) vs. opinions (conjecture, interpretation).

- Negative examples: media trials (Rhea Chakravarti), Sudarshan TV communal propaganda, unverified Poonam Pandey death story, reporter pushing mic at grieving father.

2.7 Ethics in Public and Private Relationships

2.7.1 *Distinction Between Public and Private Relationship*

Basis	Private Relationship	Public Relationship
Scope	Relationships with family members and friends	All other interactions — as a citizen, professional, or public official (Delhi Metro, traffic, cricket, public office)
Essence	Love, human emotion, personal attachment	Societal/collective interest and public welfare
Primary source of ethical standards	Traditions, customs, family norms, cultural practices	Laws, rules, regulations, professional codes
Nature of enforcement	Informal, forgiving — driven by love and emotion	Formal — police, judiciary, professional bodies
Key ethical obligation	Loyalty, care, forgiveness, emotional support	Selflessness, impartiality, accountability, public interest

2.7.2 *Role of Traditions in Private Relationship Ethics*

Our understanding of how to behave towards parents, spouses, siblings, and friends is mostly shaped by family norms, customs, and traditions — not by formal law.

EXAMPLE

- Marriage vows / Saptapadi (Hindu wedding) or the equivalent in other faiths — these formalise the ethical obligations between spouses: how a husband should treat a wife and vice versa.
- Rakshabandhan: formalises the obligation of siblings to protect and support each other.
- Shraddha Paksha / ancestor rituals: obligations to pay respect to ancestors — an ethical obligation within the family extended even beyond life.

2.7.3 *Why Private Relationships Are More Informal*

Private relationships are governed by love and emotion. Because love is the basis, forgiveness is more readily available; mistakes are tolerated; the informal standard is high but the enforcement is soft. By contrast, public relationships are governed by collective interest — and the consequence of ethical failures in public life can affect many people, sometimes fatally.

EXAMPLE

A civil servant watching a TV series during office hours is the same as a lazy student. But the consequence is not limited to the officer alone — the people dependent on that public service suffer. A soldier must prioritise duty even at the cost of personal pleasure or personal safety — because lives depend on it.

CRITICAL POINT

In public relationships, the ethical obligation is to dissolve individual interest into public interest. Public servants are expected to follow a higher set of ethical standards precisely because the consequences of their conduct affect large numbers of people who are dependent on them.

2.7.4 Consequences in the Context of Public vs Private

When a student fails to study, the immediate consequence is personal. But when a public servant fails to do their duty, it compounds into systemic harm — delayed projects, denied services, lives lost. This is why the ethical standard expected in public office is significantly higher than in private life, and why public servants are required to be selfless even at personal cost.

QUICK REVISION

- Private relationship ethics: governed by traditions, family norms, customs; enforcement is informal and driven by love.
- Public relationship ethics: governed by law, rules, professional codes; enforcement is formal.
- Public office demands selflessness, impartiality, and prioritisation of public interest above personal interest.
- The higher the consequence of ethical failure for others, the higher the ethical standard required of the actor.

Human Values and Value Inculcation

3.1 Recap: Technology Ethics, Media Ethics & Public vs Private Relationships

3.1.1 Technology Ethics

Technology ethics are the standards we are supposed to follow when we are developing, deploying, or using technology.

- While developing technology, we should be mindful not to violate people's privacy.
- We should be transparent about how the technology is developed and how it is used.
- We should hold ourselves accountable and responsible for the negative consequences of the technology we develop.
- Other principles to be followed: beneficence, non-maleficence, and fairness.

KEY CONCEPT

- Technology ethics = the standards to follow when developing, deploying or using technology.
- Core commitments: protect privacy, maintain transparency, uphold accountability for negative consequences, and observe beneficence, non-maleficence and fairness.

3.1.2 Media Ethics

Media ethics are the principles that media houses should uphold. Media is essentially the medium to transmit information; therefore, information should be verified first before it is broadcast.

- Fairness and accuracy of information is very important in the context of media ethics.
- Independence is very important because media houses play the role of the fourth pillar of democracy — they should be able to hold government accountable.
- Accountability will not work out if media is not really independent and autonomous.

Ways in which media's autonomy is threatened

- Government at times misuses its authority — e.g., filing of fake UAPA cases or sedition cases against media.
- Print media advertisement is misused as a coercive policy (advertising used as leverage over media houses).

CRITICAL POINT

- Media = fourth pillar of democracy; its accountability role collapses without genuine independence and autonomy.
- Threats to autonomy: fake UAPA / sedition cases, and misuse of government advertising as a lever of control.

3.1.3 Ethics in Public vs Private Relationships

These are the standards we are supposed to follow when dealing with public and private relationships. The essence of the two differs fundamentally.

Nature and essence

- Private relationship: its essence is essentially about human emotions and love. Enforcement of ethical standards is rather informal.
- Public relationship: its essence lies in public good / societal good. Societal good and societal interest become more important than our own individual interest.

Source of ethical standards

- In private relationships, ethical standards are mostly sourced from traditions and customs.
- Example: festivals and wedding vows. Across all religions, wedding vows exist — these vows are nothing but traditions influencing our understanding of our ethical obligation towards our partner and spouse.

Why higher ethical obligations apply in public life When we are discharging a public duty or acting as a public servant, the ethical obligations upon us are higher than when we are only private citizens. This is because our actions have huge ramifications on public interest — the consequences will be huge if you are a public servant and you are not duty-bound.

COMPARISON

- Private relationship: essence = emotions & love; standards informal; sourced from traditions & customs.
- Public relationship: essence = public/societal good; higher obligations because actions have huge ramifications on public interest.

3.2 Ethical Standards in Public Relationships (Nolan Committee Principles)

The Nolan Committee highlighted certain principles that we are supposed to follow in our public relationships. These are largely the Nolan Committee recommendations.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- The Nolan Committee laid down principles of public life, including selflessness, integrity, objectivity, accountability, openness (transparency), and honesty.
- Objectivity, accountability, openness, integrity and honesty will be discussed in detail under

'Foundational Values for Civil Services'.

3.2.1 *Selflessness*

When you are in a public relationship, something else becomes more important than our own individuality — and that is why selflessness is very important, especially in public relationships.

- Example — COVID warriors: It is not that they did not have family or friends to love, nor that they did not love their own life; still they discharged their duty because something is more important — their duty — and that is expected when you are in public life.
- Example — soldiers: they sacrifice their life for the nation because something else is more important than their own life.

3.2.2 *Integrity*

Integrity is basically following moral principles even when no one is watching.

- Example — traffic light: If you jump a red light at night you will not be fined because there is no one to catch you and no one to hold you accountable. If you still do not cross, you are being integral — you are following the traffic light even when no one is watching.
- Great leaders are integral in that they follow principles even when no one is watching. In public life, it is important that we become integral.

3.2.3 *Dignity and Compassion*

In public life and public relationships, it is important that we treat each other as human beings with a lot of dignity and compassion.

- At times our biases enter the picture, and because of those biases class differences operate. All such practices are basically unethical, because every human being deserves dignity.
- Compassion means feeling others' pain (as felt during Corona). Examples of compassion: Mother Teresa, Swami Vivekananda, Gandhiji.

3.2.4 *Leadership*

In public life it is expected of us that we take leadership — we should take initiative and not just leave things to others.

QUICK REVISION

- Public-life ethical standards (Nolan): Selflessness (COVID warriors, soldiers), Integrity (moral principles even when no one is watching), Dignity & Compassion (every human deserves dignity; compassion = feeling others' pain), Leadership (take initiative).
- Also to be covered later: objectivity, accountability, openness/transparency, honesty.

3.3 Ethical Standards in Private Relationships

3.3.1 Love and Fidelity

- Love: it is expected that there is an element of love in private relationships — enjoying time with family and friends.
- Fidelity (loyalty): fidelity becomes an expected ethical standard in private relationships. We judge people on the basis of whether there is loyalty or not.

3.3.2 Responsibility

In a family, all of us have responsibilities, and these responsibilities come with our role.

- A mother is expected to be responsible; if she neglects her child (e.g., when the child meets an accident), we call her irresponsible because responsibility is expected.
- A father who is an alcoholic and mistreats his wife is called irresponsible because responsibility is expected. Ethics tells you what is expected of you.
- Fundamental Duties also speak of responsibility: parents have a responsibility towards their children.
- Children's responsibility towards parents: a viral video showed a boy abandoning his elderly parents at a location while the parents clung to his feet begging him not to leave — the boy is being irresponsible, because responsibility is expected of children too (you must take care of your elderly parents).
- An elder sibling has responsibility towards younger siblings. Responsibility is an important part of family and relationships, and it comes with your role.

CRITICAL POINT

- Because official/public duty and private responsibility can both make demands on you, they sometimes clash — this is the source of ethical dilemmas in case studies.
- When solving a case study, do NOT pick only one side. Find the golden mean / middle path that addresses BOTH moral alternatives. Going to only one side is not a good answer.

EXAMPLE

- Sunil case (recurring case study): Sunil is a young, dynamic SP/IPS officer posted in a district infamous for illegal sand mining. He starts taking action against the sand mafia. The mafia threatens to kill him and his family. Sunil is also a spouse and a father, so private relationship creates certain responsibilities.
- A moral/ethical dilemma means you have two moral alternatives — duty to the public vs. responsibility to family. Do not build a one-sided path (e.g., 'duty is important, so ignore family'); the answer must address both dimensions.

3.3.3 Dignity in Private Relationships

Dignity is important in relationships. A husband should not treat his wife as his property, and vice versa; equality matters.

- Illustration of failure of dignity: a case in Agra where a woman reported her husband missing,

cried and made a scene, but had in fact killed her husband and buried him — an extreme breakdown of the dignity and trust a private relationship demands.

- Absolutism of dignity: irrespective of background or culture, every human being deserves some dignity. Ultimately, all of us are human beings.
- Compassion is also essential — without compassion there is no real relationship; love means at least having compassion.

3.3.4 *Traditions & Customs and Rule of Law*

- Traditions and customs govern family relationships — they tell us what is expected of us (e.g., Raksha Bandhan customs), and we are supposed to follow them.
- Rule of Law also applies in private relationships. Law governs private relationships too.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Laws applicable to private life: Domestic Violence Act, Dowry Prohibition Act (dowry occurs between families), Prevention of Atrocities against SC/ST Act (you cannot use casteist remarks against any person from SC/ST community even if they are your friend).
- Uniform Civil Code is being brought in various places and will govern private life; the ban on Triple Talaq (which was between spouses, a private relationship) shows law reaching into private life.
- Our private relationship is governed not just by traditions and customs but also by Rule of Law.

3.3.5 *Commonalities and Differences between Public & Private Standards*

If we compare the two sets of standards, we find both commonalities and differences.

Commonalities — and why they exist

- Dignity and compassion appear in both; accountability appears in both (from rule of law in private life, and as a public-life value).
- Reason for commonality: ultimately, whether private or public life, human beings are at the centre. We should treat every human being with dignity.
- To protect that dignity, there is law: the Domestic Violence Act, Dowry Act, and Prevention of Atrocities Act all protect a person's dignity. Thus dignity, self-respect, individuality and liberty are all guarded by law.

Differences — and why they exist

- Traditional customs guide private life but cannot heavily guide public servants. If every place followed its own customs, uniformity of application of law could not be achieved — so customs should not guide public conduct much.

COMPARISON

- Common to both: dignity, compassion, accountability — because human beings are at the centre of both, and law exists to protect that dignity.

- Different: traditions & customs guide private life but must not heavily guide public servants, as that would defeat uniformity of application of law.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Anticipated question (this year or next): the importance of ethical standards in private-life relationships — why ethics in private relationships is all the more important in contemporary times.

3.4 Why Ethics in Private Relationships Matters More Today

Family and marriage structures are breaking down: spouses are killing each other; children are dumping elderly parents here and there and not discharging their duty. People are becoming more and more individualistic and are not understanding the responsibilities that come with relationships. In this context, ethics in private relationships becomes more important in today's time.

3.4.1 Core Reasons

- Rising individualism and materialism: relationships are increasingly reduced to transactions — treating human beings merely as a means. A relationship is maintained only as long as there is self-interest; when it becomes a matter of 'business' / self-interest, it becomes difficult, which is why ethics in private relationships is even more relevant today.

EXAMPLE

- Gleeden app: an app on which people can register to sustain extra-marital relationships, offering anonymity and protection of identity. Reportedly a majority of its users are women, and a large share are from Bengaluru; extra-marital relationships are said to have become much more common and normalized in Bengaluru. The app saw record registrations. Its growth highlights how loyalty and related values are not being followed in relationships — marriage is losing context.
- Videos have surfaced of children abandoning or even beating their elderly parents — evidence of forgetting responsibilities towards family members.

3.4.2 The Concept of Pitr-rin (Debt to Parents / Ancestors)

Especially in the Gen-Z context, many believe their achievements are entirely the product of their own hard work. When this happens, one becomes ungrateful to the people who played a huge role in one's upbringing — namely, parents.

- Pitr-rin is traditionally misunderstood as merely about having a son; it is bigger than that.
- We tend to think whatever we achieved in life is because of our own hard work, and we discount or take for granted what our parents contributed — from this arises a lack of the sense of responsibility towards them.
- As a result, we make decisions keeping only ourselves in mind, forgetting that other people played a huge role in getting us where we are.

KEY CONCEPT

- Pitr-rin: the debt we owe to parents/ancestors. Its larger purpose is that we should not live purely individualistically. When we raise a child, much of what we do is done out of sheer love and responsibility, without calculation.
- The debt to parents can never be fully repaid; but it is honoured by taking pain upon ourselves in doing something for others — not merely for our own people.

3.4.3 The Fragility of Life — Lesson on Prioritising Family

A profound line: you can actually count the number of days you will spend with your sister (or family). Life is very fragile, so ‘line dropping’ — pausing our ambition to spend time with family — is very important. We should not postpone the time we have for parents and siblings, because that time is finite.

- Beyond duty, creating good memories with parents gives huge satisfaction.
- The least one can do is be honest with one’s preparation and one’s responsibilities toward parents.

CRITICAL POINT

Do not postpone what you should never postpone — time with parents and siblings. Ambition should not crowd out relationships, because life is fragile and shared time is limited.

QUICK REVISION

Why ethics in private relationships matters more today: breakdown of marriage & family structures; neglected children and neglected elderly; rising individualism & materialism; treating humans merely as a means (Gleeden app); loss of the sense of Pitr-rin; and the fragility of life demanding we prioritise finite time with family. When you write the answer, highlight all these dimensions: elderly, husband, wife, children, neglected children, neglected elderly, breakdown of marriage structure.

3.5 Is a Watertight Separation of Public and Private Life Possible?

A debate on which a question may be asked. In UP, a public servant having an extra-marital affair was suspended once authorities came to know. Some argue he should be judged only on his public-life conduct, not his private life, and that there should be different ethical standards for public and private life. The core question: Is it possible to have a watertight compartment between public and private life? The answer is NO.

3.5.1 Argument 1 — Virtue Ethics (‘We are what we repeatedly do’)

In virtue ethics, whatever you do habitually becomes part of your character. If someone beats his wife regularly in private life, the character being built is one of sheer disrespect for women in general.

- Persistent unethical behaviour in private life (e.g., domestic violence) will eventually lead to

unethical conduct in public life.

- **Consequence:** an IPS officer with such a character will not be able to faithfully enforce the Domestic Violence Act — i.e., poor implementation of the Domestic Violence Act.
- **Real illustration:** a senior IPS officer in MP was beating his own wife — one can imagine his commitment to enforcing the Domestic Violence Act in public life. Ultimately you are the same person in both lives.

3.5.2 *Argument 2 — Divergence Creates a Crisis of Credibility*

A lot of divergence between public and private life creates a crisis of credibility. Because a public servant is a role model, people look up to and follow them; large deviance between preaching and practice erodes credibility and harms the common good.

- **Keshab Chandra Sen** (Bengal social-religious reform movement): got his daughter married very young (at ~13) despite his public advocacy against child marriage — and thereby lost credibility.
- **Various religious gurus / Babas:** accused of doing things in private life that go against what they preach in public — leading to a crisis of credibility.
- **Gandhiji and the jaggery story:** a woman brought her child to Gandhiji because the child ate too much jaggery; Gandhiji asked her to return after two weeks. He first gave up jaggery himself, then advised the child — because when you preach something, it is important that you purify your own character first.

3.5.3 *Argument 3 — Higher Standards Required of Civil Servants*

The Code of Conduct for civil servants requires higher ethical standards: one should not do anything, even in private life, that is ‘unbecoming of a civil servant’.

- ‘Unbecoming of a civil servant’ means behaviour expected of a civil servant must be maintained; you should not do anything even in your private life that is unbecoming of the office.
- **Positive model — Lal Bahadur Shastri:** when the country faced difficulty (drought, etc.), he first started skipping a meal himself in his own private life before asking others to fast — showing that people follow only when leaders start with their own conduct.
- **Additional illustrations:** AP suspended an IPS officer for unauthorised foreign visits; the MP IPS case; and ‘imagine Rs. 200 crore for dowry’ — what example does that set for the youth? A private affair can have huge consequences on public life.

KEY CONCEPT

Watertight separation between public and private life is NOT possible, because (1) virtue ethics — we are what we repeatedly do; (2) large divergence creates a crisis of credibility; and (3) civil servants are held to higher standards and must avoid conduct ‘unbecoming’ of the office.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- 2023: ‘Corruption is the manifestation of the failure of core values in the society.’ — you can never eradicate corruption without solving the problem of values in society.

- Related theme: whether public servants should be judged on private conduct — build the answer using virtue ethics, crisis of credibility, and the code of conduct.

3.5.4 *Where to Draw the Line: Do Public Officials Have Any Privacy?*

If we cannot separate the two, does it mean civil servants have no right to privacy — that every aspect of private life should be scrutinised, especially in the age of social media? The answer is NO — private life does exist. The line is drawn by impact on public duty.

Two contrasting illustrations

- Not to be scrutinised: if posted where alcohol is not illegal, having a drink with a friend after office is private conduct that does not affect duty.
- To be scrutinised: drinking all night and reaching office hungover — because it now impairs the discharge of public duty.

CRITICAL POINT

- The principle: to the extent private life influences the discharge of public duty, it should be scrutinised.
- Examples that **MUST** be scrutinised because they bear on public responsibility: whether an official is taking dowry; gambling to the point of bankruptcy (which increases proneness to corruption). Conduct with no bearing on duty remains genuinely private.

QUICK REVISION

Two big exam themes: (1) Why ethics is required in private relationships — given rising individualism, materialism and family breakdown. (2) Whether a watertight separation exists between public & private life (No), and if not, whether any privacy remains (Yes — only conduct that influences public duty is legitimately scrutinised).

3.6 Human Values

Earlier we discussed certain human actions and asked whether they qualify as ‘human’ actions. Acts such as manual scavenging, bonded labour, one person urinating on another (an MP incident), and slavery are inhuman actions — because when interacting with the other person, we are not considering them as a human being.

3.6.1 *Meaning of Human Values*

KEY CONCEPT

- Human values are those values that guide people to take into account the human element — the fact that the other person is human — when interacting with each other.
- Human dignity is a very important, absolute value.

3.6.2 Controlling Emotions and Desires — Plato's Chariot Analogy

Controlling your desires is a human value. If a person is driven by desires, they behave more like an animal. Plato's analogy: you (the charioteer / soul) are drawing a chariot with two horses — one horse is emotions and the other is desires; both drive you.

- When desires drive you: people commit rape and indulge in greed.
- When emotions drive you: emotions like anger lead to mob lynching, honour killing, or throwing acid on a girl when a proposal is rejected.
- As human beings, it is expected of us that we control both horses — emotions and desires. Losing control is a loss of humanity.
- We should be fair to each other, because all of us are human beings.

CRITICAL POINT

Life is a long journey between 'being human' and 'being humane'. Not every human action reflects humanity — humanity is about what we ought to be.

3.6.3 Types of Values: Terminal vs Instrumental

Values are of two types.

Aspect	Terminal Values	Instrumental Values
Meaning	End-goal values (the 'ends')	Means / values that are your chosen ways of behaving
Examples	Inner peace, happiness, equality, family security, national security, freedom, goals	Responsibility, self-control, honesty, tolerance
Role	The destination we are pursuing	The behaviour we adopt to reach that destination

- Terminal values are the ends — e.g., inner peace, happiness, equality, family security, national security, freedom/goals, tolerance of different perspectives.
- Instrumental values are the means / chosen behaviours — e.g., doing our work with responsibility, exercising self-control.

QUICK REVISION

Human values take the human element into account when we interact. Human dignity is an absolute value. Controlling emotions & desires (Plato's chariot) is central. Values split into terminal (ends: inner peace, happiness, equality, security, freedom) and instrumental (means: responsibility, self-control, honesty, tolerance).

3.7 Incultation of Values: Why Values Must Be Incultated

Any society wants us to behave well and conduct ourselves rightly, and for that it makes laws — government makes laws. But can good behaviour be ensured by law alone? No, it cannot.

- Despite laws, corruption still happens; despite laws, dowry still happens. Law alone is insufficient.

3.7.1 *The Tanker-Looting Illustration*

EXAMPLE

- After an accident, people looted the overturned tanker. The government did not ask anyone to loot it — yet people did. We usually blame corruption on the government and forget that we (society) also have a role.
- Personal account: after the speaker's own accident, the ambulance attendant who dropped him at the hospital asked whether he could take the goods from the wrecked car; and when the car was later recovered from the accident site, the speaker, the extra tyre, and other fittings had been stolen — even though everyone knew it was an accident-damaged vehicle.

The lesson: most people are against corruption not out of principle but because they lack the opportunity; the moment they get the chance, they may do it. Humans can behave like 'vultures'. If we want a country without corruption, it must come from society — law alone will not help.

- P. Sainath, 'Everybody Loves a Good Drought' — the title captures how, during a drought, relief money brings joy because relief money reaches private pockets; corruption is also a societal problem, not just a government problem.
- Lokpal debate (UPSC asked): a national Lokpal / stronger bill alone will not solve corruption if it is collusive corruption — where those with money to bribe escape. The root cause is societal values.

3.7.2 *Education Without Values → 'A Clever Devil'*

Government can make good laws and provide documents, but ultimately we have to use them well. Education provided without values will make a person a 'more clever devil'.

CRITICAL POINT

Education without values makes a person a more clever devil: they will misuse acquired skills, and the consequences of that misuse are far greater than if they had not been educated at all (e.g., a doctor who becomes a drug prescriber; skilled people launching cyber-attacks).

- On any topic — women, corruption, etc. — your suggestions will not be complete without moral dimensions; behind all these problems lies a problem of morality.
- On demand-supply and corruption: even if demand is high and supply is low, that does not entitle anyone to do corruption. Corruption exists because we lower our moral guard — there is always a choice (you can earn food through effort rather than by snatching).

3.7.3 *Many Problems Are Societal, Not Merely Legal*

- Conductor assaulted for not speaking in Marathi — a societal problem, not only a legal one.
- Fake cardiologist booked over patient deaths — someone falsely posing as a heart specialist and even operating on hearts; the audacity shows the level of moral failure (societal problem).
- Constitutional morality is not a natural sentiment — it has to be cultivated, precisely because our socialised instincts are not automatically constitutional.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

2023: 'Corruption is the manifestation of the failure of core values in the society.' You will never be able to eradicate corruption without solving the problem of values in society.

QUICK REVISION

Why inculcate values: law alone cannot ensure good conduct (corruption, dowry persist despite law; the tanker-looting shows society's own role). Most oppose corruption only for lack of opportunity. Education without values = a clever devil. Many problems (Marathi-assault, fake cardiologist, corruption) are societal, not merely legal. Constitutional morality must be cultivated.

3.8 Role of Family in Value Inculcation

Family, education institutions, and society all play a huge role in inculcating values. We begin with the family, illustrated through great examples that are useful in both answers and essays.

3.8.1 *Examples of Values Inculcated by Family*

- Ratan Tata — Altruism & Philanthropy: his altruism and philanthropy came from the Tata family, which historically had a legacy of philanthropy and helping people.
- Nelson Mandela — Forgiveness & Reconciliation: known for forgiveness. Belonging to a political family, he saw people come daily to the local/village council (panchayat) to resolve their differences through discussion and reconciliation. This early exposure to village councils taught him to build society by reconciliation, not revenge. He said that if he had not forgiven, he would still be in prison — because holding onto the past keeps you imprisoned in it.
- B. R. Ambedkar — Education as empowerment: his father, a Subedar in the army, insisted on educating his children despite social rules against Dalits getting educated. Ambedkar learnt the importance of education as a tool of empowerment — reflected later in the architecture of the Constitution.
- A. P. J. Abdul Kalam — Simplicity & Tolerance: learnt simplicity from his boatman father, and tolerance from teachers of different faiths who welcomed him (a Muslim) — which is why he later became the 'People's President'.
- Martin Luther King Jr. — Speaking against racism: his father was a pastor/religious authority who spoke against racism in his sermons; from there, King's value of fighting against racism was instilled.
- Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj — role of Jijabai: Jijabai's role shaped his rise and values.
- Lord Ram — Upholding promises: learnt to uphold promises from his family; his father

honoured his word even at great cost, and Ram fulfilled his promise even at the cost of exile.

3.8.2 Values from Joint Families

- A joint family inculcates cooperation, religious values, responsibility, compassion, discipline, and respecting elders.

QUICK REVISION

Family examples (keep 6–8 ready for answers/essays): Ratan Tata (altruism/philanthropy), Nelson Mandela (forgiveness/reconciliation via village councils), B. R. Ambedkar (education as empowerment), A. P. J. Abdul Kalam (simplicity & tolerance), M. L. King Jr. (against racism), Shivaji & Jijabai, Lord Ram (upholding promises). Joint families add cooperation, discipline, responsibility, respecting elders.

3.8.3 How Families Inculcate Values (Mechanisms)

Child-rearing practices How a child is reared has huge consequences for character development.

EXAMPLE

- Ruth Benedict — ‘The Chrysanthemum and the Sword’: Americans were astonished that Japanese soldiers were disciplined yet ruthless. Benedict studied Japanese culture: a newborn is treated like a flower (chrysanthemum) with tenderness and care, but as the child grows, heavy discipline is imposed — even toiletry practices are regulated, and emotional expression is suppressed. The child becomes disciplined but ruthless, because their own emotions were never understood.
- Serial killers often become so because of a traumatic past — trauma from childhood scars the character. Contrast: authoritarian vs democratic upbringing.

Other mechanisms

- Observation learning: a child learns by watching — e.g., patriarchy and smoking are learnt by observation.
- Storytelling: stories with a moral lesson — Ramayana, Mahabharata, Panchatantra, the rabbit and the tortoise.
- Operant conditioning: reward–punishment mechanism. Good behaviour (hard work, good marks) is rewarded, teaching desirability, which becomes a preference and then a value; wrong acts (stealing, lying) are punished, teaching what not to do.
- Role modelling: children learn a lot from parents, who become their role models.

3.8.4 Critical Perspective — Why Families Fail to Inculcate Values (Contemporary Factors)

- Parents are not great role models: they indulge in unethical acts (e.g., jumping traffic signals) in front of their children (observation learning of the wrong kind).
- Breakdown of the family / joint-family system. Parenting is a selfless duty, but at times parents take career to such a level that this is compromised.
- Fast-paced life and working parents who may not be emotionally available for the child.

- Social media & online games: at a very young age children are exposed to inappropriate content (some countries have even banned social media for under-16s). Even 'good' content on social media does not develop emotional intelligence, because you are not interacting with a real human being (missing non-verbal communication). It also reduces human interaction. Examples: the Blue Whale game; the Netflix series 'Adolescence'.
- Parents undermining ethics directly: e.g., paying for leaked exam papers — emphasising 'marks over morality' and 'career over character'.

CRITICAL POINT

- Cognitive atrophy from phones: parents hand children phones to reduce their own burden; ~90% of the adult-size brain develops in the first two years, and heavy phone exposure harms this development — a growing crisis in cognitive ability.
- Key phrases for answers: 'Marks over morality', 'Career over character', emphasis on career over character.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

UPSC (2017 & 2022-type, near copy-paste): a question on the role of family (parents) and teachers in value inculcation. A good answer must include contemporary factors to make it analytical, not merely positive.

3.9 Role of Educational Institutions in Value Inculcation

3.9.1 Role of Teachers

Teachers play a huge role. Traditionally many teachers focused on rote learning ('rattification'), which limited genuine understanding. A conceptually-oriented teacher who explains why an operation is invalid — rather than only giving the solution — transforms students. Such teachers act as agents of transformation.

- Pedagogy is very important: the subject is not merely about transferring information; students should 'live' and feel the subject. Teachers shape the character of the student through their teaching, behaviour, and conduct.
- Professor H. C. Verma (awarded Padma Shri): his book 'Concepts of Physics' helped countless students understand complex concepts and pursue science careers; he inculcated scientific temper and inspired dream careers through role modelling.
- Anne Sullivan & Helen Keller: Sullivan taught a child with hearing and visual impairment — showing the empathy and pedagogy required to reach such a student. Teachers stimulate critical thinking, objectivity and other values, and mentor students throughout their journey.

KEY CONCEPT

Teaching carries responsibility far beyond examinations: through pedagogy, behaviour and role modelling, teachers inculcate values and can transform a student's entire perspective and life.

- More teacher-mentor examples: Ramakrishna Paramahansa & Swami Vivekananda; Samarth

Guru Ramdas & Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj; Chanakya (Kautilya) & Chandragupta Maurya.

3.9.2 *Role of Curricular Subjects*

History — lessons, not just facts

- Justice cannot be kept by force: force may create an absence of tension but not genuine, long-lasting peace. The Treaty of Versailles, imposed by force rather than justice, helped create the Second World War.
- Tolerance — Akbar vs Aurangzeb: Akbar forged a large empire through a tolerant approach (e.g., Din-i-Ilahi). Aurangzeb, with an intolerant approach — discriminating between Shias and Sunnis and imposing Jizya — could not forge a lasting empire. Under intolerance an empire may survive out of fear, but people do not connect from the heart; after his death, the Mughal empire crumbled.

Science — explaining, questioning, predicting

- Science explains phenomena (tides, eclipses) that were once attributed to Rahu and Ketu; it not only explains but predicts them — enabling cyclone management in Odisha and drastically reducing deaths.
- Superstition example: a snake-bitten child in UP was tied and floated down the Ganga instead of being taken for treatment, and died — ignorance because the phenomenon was not understood scientifically.
- Scientific temper / critical thinking theme (very important this year): ‘A doubter is a true soldier of science’ (the doubter questions); ‘Visionary decision-making happens at the intersection of intuition and logic’ (logic = questioning); ‘History is a series of victories of the scientific man over the romantic man’; ‘Thinking is like a game that does not begin unless there is an opposition.’
- Personal chilli illustration: an itching sensation from chilli oil, relieved by soap (fat/carbon counteracting the oil) — science makes us look into and understand things rather than take them at face value.

Environment

- Studying environment — climate change, global warming, groundwater depletion — teaches the importance of environmental conservation.

3.9.3 *Extracurricular Activities: Sports, Games & Debates*

Sports and games are a very important — and under-used — source of ethics, so they are worth quoting for a distinct answer or essay.

- Facing failure: we cannot win all the time; a key life skill is how we face failure. Sports teach us to digest failures and bounce back, which builds character.
- Sportsmanship: respecting and appreciating others’ tremendous effort, even in defeat.
- Teamwork & selflessness: putting the team’s interest above individual ego — a student who, as captain, set aside individual defences for the team learnt selflessness (linked to public duty). Graeme Smith batting with a broken hand in a Test to save his team is an instance of putting

the team above oneself.

- Administration using sport: the Mewat Kabaddi league was used to change attitudes and fight drug addiction — sport can influence people's lives.
- Debates: engaging in debate makes you more tolerant and accepting of others' opinions and respectful of liberty — you realise your opinion may not be the best.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Essay theme (recent): 'The most valuable lessons in life are learned through bitter experiences.' Use sport, e.g., the 2023 World Cup final loss — allowing expectations to rule our head and trying to control what is not in our control means we may not give our best.

3.9.4 Pedagogy: Activity-Based Learning & the Flipped Classroom

- Activity-based learning (observed in Norway): students solve problems together through projects — a higher form of learning than lecture-only teaching.
- Flipped classroom: in a traditional classroom, lectures come first and homework after; in a flipped classroom, you study a topic on your own (e.g., recorded video) beforehand and then solve problems together through activity in class.

3.9.5 Critical Perspective — Why Institutions Fail (Contemporary Factors)

- Unethical conduct by teachers/institutions: e.g., discrimination by caste — making students sit separately during the mid-day meal — inculcates inequality; sexual abuse; and other unethical acts.
- Commercialisation, commodification & privatisation of education.
- Over-emphasis on marks and exam performance.
- Neglect of extracurricular activities — missing out on the values sports and games inculcate.
- Commercialisation of curriculum; neglect of the psychological well-being of students; students indulging in bullying, slang and ragging.
- Lack of teacher training / pedagogical bankruptcy — emphasis on rote learning.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Positive institutional interventions (usable examples): the Malayalam movie 'Sthanarthi Sreekuttan'-inspired semi-circular seating layout in Kerala schools to avoid labelling of 'back-benchers'; the sugar board displaying sugar content to make students health-conscious; NCERT emphasis on traditional games and cultural activities (kabaddi, yoga) to impart teamwork, agility and other values.
- Activity/project-based learning gap: most Indian institutions are 'teaching institutions' relying on lectures; project- and activity-based learning could impart more values and knowledge — a missed opportunity, alongside the prominent neglect of extracurricular activities.

QUICK REVISION

Educational institutions inculcate values via teachers (pedagogy, role modelling — H. C. Verma,

Anne Sullivan), curricular subjects (History → tolerance/justice: Versailles, Akbar vs Aurangzeb; Science → question–explain–predict, scientific temper; Environment → conservation), and extracurriculars (sports → failure, sportsmanship, teamwork, selflessness; debates → tolerance). Better pedagogy = activity-based learning & flipped classroom. Failures: caste discrimination, commercialisation, marks-obsession, neglect of extracurriculars, weak teacher training.

3.10 Role of Society, Government & Media in Value Incultation

Value incultation in society is contingent not just on family and educational institutions; government, media, and religious leaders all play a huge role.

3.10.1 *Ethnocentrism & the Value of Exposure (Society)*

EXAMPLE

- The ‘frog-in-the-well’ realisation: raised in a traditional vegetarian Brahmin family in Rajasthan, the speaker once judged non-vegetarians as ‘wrong people’. At IIT Kharagpur, through a seniors’ ‘personality program’ (remembering each person’s name, department and place), he came to know roommates and messmates from Bengal (fond of fish), Hyderabad (mutton), and Meghalaya. He realised that had he been born in Calcutta, Hyderabad or Meghalaya, he too would eat those foods.
- Insight: dietary practices are shaped by the culture into which we are born — a culture we do not choose. Without exposure to diversity, we become ethnocentric and judge others by our own standards. This is why ‘morality is not a natural sentiment’ — it is shaped by socialisation. Educational institutions are great places to enlarge our thinking.

3.10.2 *Empathy Toward Systems and People*

When operating at a small scale you can ensure things are done well; but as part of a larger nation/system you realise it is not humanly possible to do everything perfectly. Hence we should extend empathy — assume good intentions and recognise limitations — rather than only understanding our own problems and not the other’s perspective.

3.10.3 *Role of Government*

Government mostly inculcates values through a reward–punishment approach, plus attitudinal change and awareness.

- Rewarding ethical conduct: e.g., civilian awards signal that a behaviour is appreciable.
- Punishing unethical conduct through laws: e.g., Domestic Violence Act, anti-corruption law.
- Striving for attitudinal change and building awareness.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Incentivising behaviour: government announcing a Rs. 1 crore incentive for a ‘Maoist-free panchayat’ — using incentives to shape conduct.

3.10.4 Role of Media (Positive)

- Shaping public opinion & spreading awareness: e.g., coverage of the Mooknayak-type / ‘money-per’ incident sensitises us (we did not go to Manipur, yet media sensitised us — ‘what the eyes do not see, the heart does not grieve about’).
- Solidarity & cooperation: e.g., appeals to donate during Punjab floods.
- Reinforcement of shared values & traditions: e.g., 26th January parade celebrating unity in diversity.
- Promoting tolerance: e.g., debates and discussions; popularisation of South Indian movies in North India.
- Inculcating scientific temper: e.g., media advisories to farmers for scientific agriculture.
- Eradicating stereotypes: e.g., the movie ‘Pink’ — ‘No means no’.
- Upholding justice & accountability: e.g., coverage of scams (2G), the NEET / paper-leak issue — holding government accountable.

3.10.5 Role of Media (Negative — Contemporary Factors)

- Objectification & commodification of women: how women are portrayed in songs and movies shapes understanding (e.g., a Haryanvi song for which the singer later apologised).
- Echo-chamber effect: strengthening one’s existing prejudices; fake news gets reinforced when you lack alternative perspectives.
- Biased media coverage & the algorithm problem — undermining objectivity and critical thinking.
- Prioritising sensationalism over public interest: pursuing sensational stories over the public interest. What is popular may not be right — popularity is not the metric of righteousness.
- Loss of media autonomy due to corporate takeover; glorification of crime and criminal syndicates — glorifying something that goes against rule of law.

QUICK REVISION

Society enlarges thinking and counters ethnocentrism through exposure (frog-in-the-well). Government inculcates values via rewards (civilian awards), punishment (laws), and awareness/incentives (Rs. 1 crore for Maoist-free panchayat). Media positives: sensitising, solidarity, shared values (Republic Day), tolerance, scientific temper, breaking stereotypes (‘Pink’), accountability (2G, NEET). Media negatives: objectification of women, echo chambers, bias/algorithms, sensationalism, glorification of crime, loss of autonomy.

3.11 Lessons from the Lives of Great Leaders — Mahatma Gandhi

3.11.1 Honesty & Integrity

- Paying for his grandchildren’s stay: when Gandhiji’s grandchildren came to stay with him in the ashram, he deposited fees for their stay because the ashram was run from public funds — a great example of honesty and integrity.
- Expelling his sister over untouchability: Gandhiji invited Dudabhai (a Harijan teacher) to

live in the ashram; when his sister refused to eat with Dudabhai, Gandhiji acted against the discriminatory refusal — a great example of honesty and integrity in upholding equality over custom.

3.11.2 *Openness, Tolerance & a Learning Attitude*

Gandhiji used to say we should keep our mind open like we keep the windows of our house open, so that sunlight and wind can come in — similarly, we should keep our mind open so we can learn from others.

KEY CONCEPT

- Gandhiji said he learned non-violence (Ahimsa) from his wife: he had always tried to make her bend to his wishes; she would firmly refuse yet patiently bear the hardship he inflicted. Her peaceful opposition opened his eyes, made him ashamed, and rid him of the notion that it was his birthright to rule over her.
- Lesson — openness, tolerance and a learning attitude: even a great person admits his mistakes; great people own them.

3.11.3 *Non-Violence (Ahimsa)*

- Non-violence is not only refraining from harming others through action, but also through our thoughts and words. Use this whenever you criticise hate speech, abuse or violence in case studies.
- Withdrawal of the Non-Cooperation Movement after the Chauri Chaura incident — a powerful example of Gandhiji's commitment to non-violence.

3.11.4 *Forgiveness*

Forgiveness is a big enough theme to become a standalone question — and whenever you write on forgiveness, always name two persons: Gandhiji and Nelson Mandela.

- 'Hate the sin, not the sinner' did not mean people should not be punished — Gandhiji even punished himself (fasting) when he felt he had done wrong. He was not against punishment; he was against bitterness. Punishment should be for rehabilitation and reform, not out of hatred (just as parents scold to correct, hating the mistake and not the child).
- Mandela: 'If I had not forgiven them, I would still be in prison.' If we do not forgive, we remain imprisoned in grudges and keep reliving the wrong. Forgiveness liberates the one who forgives — you forgive first for yourself.

3.11.5 *Swaraj (Self-Rule)*

- Swaraj literally means self-rule / rule over oneself. The greatest self-rule is ruling over oneself — regulating oneself. Mention Swaraj whenever you write on emotional intelligence or on controlling desires.

3.11.6 *Talisman & Antyodaya*

KEY CONCEPT

- Gandhiji's Talisman: whenever you are in doubt during decision-making, think of the poorest and most vulnerable ('last-mile') person and ask how your action affects them — take into account the most vulnerable (Antyodaya).
- Antyodaya = feeling others' pain AND doing something to remove it. Example: during the lockdown, government did not sufficiently anticipate the hardship of migrants — the Talisman perspective would have centred the most vulnerable.

3.11.7 *Solidarity — The Loincloth*

- Adopting the loincloth: originally a barrister who wore full clothes, Gandhiji, while travelling by train in South India, urged people wearing foreign clothes to switch to khadi; they replied that khadi was too costly and they could not afford it. Realising the poor could not afford khadi, and to show solidarity with their pain, he changed his own lifestyle and began wearing the loincloth — a profound act of solidarity, feeling and sharing the pain of others.

3.11.8 *Sarvodaya, Purity of Means & Trusteeship*

- Sarvodaya = upliftment / rise of all ('sabhi ka uday'). Gandhiji spoke for everyone — farmers, Dalits, women — linked to inclusive growth.
- Purity of means: the means must be pure — illustrated by the withdrawal of the Non-Cooperation Movement after Chauri Chaura.

KEY CONCEPT

- Trusteeship: if you have resources beyond your genuine need (e.g., you need Rs. 100 to survive but have Rs. 1,000), the extra is not yours — you hold it as a trustee on society's trust.
- Application — Bhoodan movement: after independence, most land lay with zamindars/landlords; Vinoba Bhave appealed to those with excess land to donate it. Bhoodan reflects the trusteeship principle.
- Relevance today: trusteeship matters amid rising inequality (the top 1% holding vast wealth) and unsustainability — regarding the environment, we hold all resources as trustees of future generations, so trusteeship underpins environmental conservation. (Also links to CSR.)

QUICK REVISION

Gandhian values for answers/essays: Honesty & Integrity (ashram fees; expelling sister over untouchability); Openness/Tolerance/Learning (mind like open windows; learnt Ahimsa from his wife); Non-Violence (withdrawal of NCM after Chauri Chaura); Forgiveness ('hate the sin not the sinner'; with Mandela); Swaraj (self-rule → emotional intelligence); Talisman & Antyodaya (last-mile person); Solidarity (loincloth); Sarvodaya (upliftment of all); Purity of Means; Trusteeship (Bhoodan; inequality; environment; CSR).

3.12 Key Cross-Cutting Reminders

- Not all values are ethical values. Ethics is about standards; values are broader. (Code of ethics vs code of conduct will be covered separately.)
- Case studies & dilemmas: when public duty and private responsibility clash, resolve via the golden mean that addresses both moral alternatives, not one side alone.
- Make answers analytical: on family/education/society/government/media, always pair positive roles with contemporary factors (why values are not being inculcated) to lift the answer beyond a purely positive account.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

High-probability themes to prepare: (1) role of family, teachers & society in value incultation (UPSC 2017/2022); (2) 'Corruption is the manifestation of the failure of core values in society' (2023); (3) 'Most valuable lessons are learned through bitter experiences' (essay); (4) forgiveness as a standalone value (Gandhi + Mandela); (5) ethics in private relationships & the limits of scrutinising a public servant's private life.

Gandhi's Seven Social Sins, Aptitude and Foundational Values for Civil Services

4.1 Lessons from Gandhiji: The Seven Social Sins

Gandhiji's entire life is about upholding values — from him we can learn honesty, integrity, justice, and the Talisman (whenever we make a decision, we should think of the last-mile person, i.e., Antyodaya, and uphold social justice). Alongside these, the Seven Social Sins capture common mistakes society makes when it takes ethics for granted.

KEY CONCEPT

The Seven Social Sins are a checklist of what goes wrong when we divorce an activity from its underlying ethical anchor. An eighth sin — 'Rights without Responsibility' — was added later by Gandhiji's grandson, Arun Gandhi.

4.1.1 *Wealth Without Work*

When we hold a narrow perception of the good life, we think we should simply be wealthy even through unethical or immoral means. Gandhiji argued that acquiring wealth without working towards it is a sin.

- Every instance of corruption is essentially 'wealth without work' — robbery, corruption, scams, and disproportionate rewards relative to one's actual work.
- Kantian dimension: the question is not merely whether an act makes you happy, but whether you become worthy of that happiness. If you buy a doctor's degree without earning it, you are not worthy of being a doctor even if you carry the title — and you would then be treating patients you are not competent to treat.
- In case studies: references where you are promoted or rewarded after doing something slightly wrong are also 'wealth without work' — you are not worthy of that success. It is a form of corruption.

4.1.2 *Pleasure Without Conscience*

This means mindlessly pursuing pleasure after one's conscience (antaratma) has died. All incidents of rape are examples of pleasure without conscience — deriving pleasure from such acts means the inner conscience is dead.

EXAMPLE

- Sri Ganganagar (Rajasthan) case: a 13-year-old girl was gang-raped multiple times by 32 men — an extreme illustration of pleasure without conscience.
- Other forms: gambling addiction; alcoholism (distinct from merely drinking — addiction where you drink even against medical advice); and mindless consumerism (buying things at the mall simply because they seem nice).
- Key distinction — the student anecdote: a friend who failed Mains in his first attempt refused a drink offered by another friend on results day, saying he would not let failure drive him to alcohol. If he drinks because he is unhappy today, tomorrow it will be over a girlfriend, then a wife — the problem is not that you drink, but that you consciously drink to escape. That is pleasure without conscience (addiction).

4.1.3 Knowledge Without Character

A very important theme in ethics — the same idea as ‘education without values makes a man a more clever devil.’ If you lack values, ethics, and morality, whatever skill or knowledge you possess will be misused.

- Public-servant stakes: when you become a DM or SP and act wrongly, the consequences are huge — lakhs of people may be harmed if you fail to act timely. Knowledgeable but characterless people misuse their intellect.
- Illustrations of intellect misused: the promoters behind large scams; the promoters of BluSmart cabs — intellect present, character absent.

4.1.4 Commerce (Business) Without Morality

Commerce without morality is a sin. In corporate case studies it appears as mindless profit-making that violates consumer rights.

- Pursuing profit while violating consumer rights is the classic form of commerce without morality.

4.1.5 Science Without Humanity

On the same line as knowledge without character: science empowers us to do many things, but if it is bereft of humanity (without *maanviya samvedna* — human sensibility), its use becomes a sin.

- Examples of science misused: nuclear energy weaponised; biological weapons; designer babies; misuse of ultrasound to detect and abort female foetuses; and links to climate change, global warming, and species extinction.
- This connects to technology ethics — technology should not be misused and should be used sustainably.

4.1.6 Religion Without Sacrifice

Gandhiji is not referring to animal sacrifice or rituals. Every religion focuses on purification of the self — the essence of religion is that our character should be purified.

- The 'sacrifice' meant is the sacrifice of our vices: anger, revenge, and mindless bodily pleasures. Following religion merely for the sake of ritual, without shedding vices, is the sin.
- Collective well-being: ultimately all religions ask how we should contribute to our collective well-being and to society — hence humanity is the biggest religion of them all.

KEY CONCEPT

Vivekananda's teaching captures the essence: 'Service to humanity is a thousand times better than a thousand heads bowing in prayer'; 'There is Shiva in every jiva.' Understanding this bigger perspective makes one a better Hindu, Muslim, or Christian.

4.1.7 *Politics Without Principle*

Politics is about people and people's interest. In the context of rising criminalisation of politics and misuse of governance and constitutional offices, it is important to uphold principle in politics.

4.1.8 *Rights Without Responsibility (added by Arun Gandhi)*

This eighth sin is a very important interface for ethics: rights and responsibilities go hand in hand.

- To enjoy the right to a clean environment, you must discharge your duty as a conscious citizen; to enjoy the right to clean, pothole-free roads, you must discharge your duty of paying taxes.
- We forget our responsibilities: we are very aware of our rights and entitlements (e.g., as consumers or students) but not conscious of our corresponding responsibilities.
- Doctor–patient illustration: a patient's rights come with the responsibility of following the regimen the doctor prescribes.

CRITICAL POINT

The recurring one-line test of ethics: you may have the right to do something, but it may not be the right thing to do. Ethics is the difference between what you have the right to do versus what is the right thing to do.

QUICK REVISION

Gandhi's Seven (+1) Social Sins: (1) Wealth without Work, (2) Pleasure without Conscience, (3) Knowledge without Character, (4) Commerce without Morality, (5) Science without Humanity, (6) Religion without Sacrifice, (7) Politics without Principle, (8) Rights without Responsibility (added by Arun Gandhi).

4.2 Focus on Controllables: A Note on the Aspirant's Attitude

A recurring digression that doubles as an attitude lesson. Many aspirants, after a setback, keep shifting goalposts (e.g., switching from UPSC to State PCS on the assumption that it is easier) instead of focusing on becoming a better student — but State PCS is also a competitive examination.

- The pattern: 80–90% of the time such switchers fail to qualify State PCS as well, because the focus is on shifting goalposts rather than on becoming better. Unless you become a good aspirant, you will not qualify any exam.

- Blaming the exam: a large number of students blame UPSC (calling it ‘unfair’) rather than working on themselves. Cursing UPSC will not improve your fate.

CRITICAL POINT

- Focus on the controllables — PYQ solving, revision, tests, introspection — because roughly 20–25% is luck and outside your control. What is in your hands is your own preparation and attitude.
- This exam is an ‘exam of margins’: even half a mark lost across many questions adds up (the gap between rank ~125 and ~140 can be a handful of marks), so the right attitude is to introspect and minimise mistakes.

4.3 Aptitude

Aptitude is about potential, not present skill. Just as the ‘capacity’ of a bottle (say 250 ml) or a room (say 200 students) states its potential and not what it currently holds, aptitude is our inherent capacity to acquire a skill through appropriate training — it may not reflect present skill or attribute.

KEY CONCEPT

Aptitude = inherent capacity to acquire a skill through appropriate training. It always speaks of potential — what we can do if trained — not of present performance.

4.3.1 *Aptitude Is Not Monolithic — Its Components*

- Linguistic aptitude: some people pick up languages quickly.
- Physical / bodily aptitude: some have a build suited to particular tasks. (Somatotypes from anthropology — endomorph, mesomorph, ectomorph — illustrate how body type suits different activities; e.g., a lower centre of mass helps in weightlifting.)
- Spatial aptitude: some can visualise objects well and make great architects.
- Emotional aptitude: some are intellectually sharp at problem-solving yet cannot relate to others’ emotions — they lack emotional aptitude and cannot feel others’ pain.
- Intellectual aptitude: problem-solving and analytical capacity (linked to IQ).
- Talent ≠ guaranteed success: having potential does not guarantee marks or success; potential must be realised.

4.3.2 *Civil Services Aptitude*

A good civil servant needs a combination of physical, emotional, moral, and intellectual aptitude. One can exist without the others, but ideally all should be strong. Effective (prudent) decision-making must be legal, ethical, AND effective.

EXAMPLE

- Helping a lady across the road: you show your emotional side (and, since the act is legal and ethical, a moral side), but you may not be showing intellectual problem-solving. Merely being

legal and ethical is not the same as being effective/prudent.

- Anil Swaroop's point: a good decision should not only be legal and ethical, but also politically feasible, administratively feasible, and acceptable to people — which is one reason government decision-making is slow.

Physical, Emotional, Moral & Intellectual aptitude — how they interact

- Too emotional → lacking emotional intelligence; too intellectual with no emotion → a legal-but-unethical, rules-as-ends approach; you need objectivity balanced with emotional and moral aptitude.
- Illustration: a police officer saving a Muslim man from an angry mob in Ramnagar shows intellectual, emotional, and moral aptitude together.

QUICK REVISION

Aptitude = inherent capacity to acquire a skill through appropriate training (potential, not present skill). Types: linguistic, physical/bodily, spatial, emotional, intellectual. Civil-services aptitude blends physical + emotional + moral + intellectual aptitude; prudent decision-making is legal + ethical + effective (and, per Anil Swaroop, politically & administratively feasible and publicly acceptable).

4.4 Attitude, and the Relationship between Aptitude & Attitude

4.4.1 What Is Attitude

KEY CONCEPT

Attitude = a predisposition or tendency to behave in a certain way towards an 'attitudinal object'. Attitude is always a relational term — it is always with respect to something (a person, animal, ideology, thing, food, etc.).

- Examples of attitude as predisposition: a racist's tendency to discriminate against black people; a patriarch's discriminatory tendency towards women; a pessimist's tendency to run away from problems; and differing individual reactions to a snake (fear, indifference, fascination, or disgust).

4.4.2 Aptitude vs Attitude — Key Differences

Aspect	Aptitude	Attitude
Meaning	Inherent capacity to acquire a skill through appropriate training	Predisposition / tendency to behave a certain way towards an object
Nature	Can be physical as well as mental	Always psychological / mental
Focus	Potential to learn or perform	Direction and disposition of behaviour
Value-charge	Neutral potential	Neither inherently good nor bad — depends on which attitude

4.4.3 How Attitude and Aptitude Complement Each Other

Aptitude without attitude is directionless

- Talented but poor attitude: highly talented players like Vinod Kambli and Prithvi Shaw did not achieve commensurate success because of poor attitude ('now we have arrived, no need to work hard'). Potential is never realised if not backed by a corresponding attitude.
- Adapting attitude: the right attitude is to adapt to new challenges (e.g., a changed Prelims paper) rather than blame UPSC — 'UPSC may be flawed, but abusing UPSC will not improve my fate.' Talent will always be beaten by hard-working people with a good, positive attitude if the talented stop working.

Attitude can compensate for a lack of aptitude

- Cricket illustration: a limping batsman with damaged legs (poor physical aptitude for the game at that moment) still performed through sheer will — will compensates for lack of aptitude via extra hard work.
- Kiran Bedi at Tihar: prison postings were traditionally seen as punishment postings (less glamour than an SP role), yet through her sheer attitude she transformed Tihar Prison with meditation and reform initiatives — attitude overcame an 'unfavourable' posting.
- National-scale examples: a nuclear-bombed nation rebuilding, or India achieving technological progress despite resource constraints — sheer attitude/will compensating for lack of resources (aptitude).

CRITICAL POINT

Attitude without aptitude is risky: with only attitude (and no aptitude), one may be misguided and can potentially do unethical work; noble intentions with weak execution result when aptitude is absent. So attitude cannot fully substitute for aptitude — both matter, but attitude gives direction and can compensate significantly.

4.4.4 Learning Attitude: Adopt Values, Don't Become Others

Two guiding statements: 'A human being can alter his life by altering his attitude' (a favourite of virtue ethics), and 'Learn everything that is good from others, but bring it in your own way — do not become others.'

- Virat Kohli example: we can learn discipline from him (e.g., his fitness transformation) without needing to become cricketers — we lack the aptitude/ambition to be cricketers, but we can inculcate the value in our own way.
- Constitution analogy: India borrowed features from many constitutions without becoming the UK or USA — adopt the good, adapt it, don't copy wholesale.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

'The greater discovery of my generation is that a human being can alter his life by altering his attitude' — a question that spans both attitude and aptitude. The core takeaway: you can transform your life by changing your attitude; at the least, commit a different mistake rather than the same one repeatedly.

QUICK REVISION

Attitude = predisposition to act towards an attitudinal object; always relational, always psychological. Aptitude without attitude = directionless (Kambli, Prithvi Shaw); attitude can compensate for lack of aptitude (limping batsman, Kiran Bedi at Tihar, resource-poor nations). But attitude alone (no aptitude) risks misguided/unethical action. Learn good from others in your own way — don't become others (Virat Kohli; the borrowed Constitution).

4.5 Foundational Values for Civil Services: Objectivity

4.5.1 Background — Max Weber's Bureaucratic Model

Before Max Weber, in the era of kings and queens, administration ran on either traditional authority (obeying because the ruler is the former king's son) or charismatic authority (obeying because of the ruler's charisma). Because emotions ruled, administration became subjective — nepotism and the spoils system prevailed, merit was ignored, and administration was inefficient and corrupt.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Max Weber proposed a bureaucratic model based on legal-rational authority: authority is accepted because it is derived from law, and decision-making is objective (fact-based). This mechanises administration for efficient, impartial implementation of rules.

4.5.2 What Objectivity Means

- Fact-based decision-making: decisions are made on the basis of facts, not personal emotions or preferences.
- Value-neutral: there should be no personal preference or personal value; facts are facts.
- Impersonal: it should not matter who is holding a post — e.g., it should not matter which officer conducts your exam; any post-holder must run it identically. The bureaucrat's job is

to implement rules and regulations ‘ruthlessly’ — meaning without bias or personal value, impersonally and value-neutrally.

- Rationality: rational decision-making means exploring alternatives, doing a cost–benefit analysis of each, and choosing the most optimal option (e.g., deciding the best alignment for a road between two villages).

4.5.3 *Relevance of Objectivity in Governance*

- Implementing government policies: e.g., disbursing Mudra Yojana loans by eligibility and need verification, not favouritism.
- Welfare schemes & tenders: objectivity when dealing with multiple interest groups (e.g., transparent tender processes, GeM portal).
- Rule of law: filing charge sheets based on evidence.
- Social reform: fighting prejudice and superstition by providing facts — e.g., IEC (Information, Education, Communication) campaigns such as ‘tobacco causes cancer.’
- HR / work culture: transfers, postings, and promotions based on merit and performance facts — otherwise the morale of other officers suffers.
- Credibility & legitimacy: without objectivity there is favouritism, nepotism, and corruption, and government loses legitimacy and public trust; objectivity is also vital in tribunals.

4.5.4 *Limitations of Objectivity*

Over-reliance on objectivity can make administration mechanical and apathetic — rules become ends in themselves.

- Rules becoming ends in themselves: e.g., a PDS officer turning away an old lady for lack of a document, ignoring the constitutional obligation of a welfare state.
- Facts may not capture emotions: e.g., the Niyamgiri case — the Dongria Kondh tribe’s belief that their ancestors/deity reside in the hills cannot be weighed as a ‘fact’ against bauxite extraction. Objectivity cannot capture such emotional/sacred weightage.
- Counterproductive in emergencies/disasters: overly relying on procedure can go against public interest during a disaster.
- Facts may not be available: e.g., COVID-19 was a novel virus with limited known facts — decisions had to rely on experience and intuition (e.g., use of Remdesivir, plasma therapy amid limited evidence and crisis).
- Need for vision/intuition: the personal example of consulting three doctors for a parent’s heart condition who diverged in opinion — since facts alone rarely converge, decisions ultimately require intuition and experience.
- Confirmation bias: with too many facts, we cherry-pick those suiting our narrative (‘torture the data until it confesses’), so biases prevent full rationality.
- Suppression of creativity & innovation: impersonal, rules-bound, precedent-following administration suppresses innovation — e.g., an official who says ‘we have no funds’ gives a legal reply, whereas going beyond facts to innovate (crowdfunding, a personal value) actually solves the problem; excessive fact-binding creates tunnel vision and mechanical approaches.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

‘Visionary decision-making happens at the intersection of logic and intuition.’ Logic alone (facts) and intuition alone are each insufficient — conviction often comes from intuition, direction from logic.

QUICK REVISION

Objectivity = fact-based, value-neutral, impersonal, rational (alternatives + cost-benefit → optimal) decision-making; rooted in Weber’s legal-rational authority (vs traditional/charismatic).
 Relevance: policy delivery, tenders, rule of law, social reform (IEC), merit-based HR, legitimacy.
 Limitations: rules-as-ends & apathy (PDS old lady), can’t capture emotions (Niyamgiri), bad in emergencies, facts unavailable (COVID), needs vision/intuition, confirmation bias, suppresses innovation.

4.6 Integrity

‘Integral’ implies wholeness of character. Integrity means consistently following moral principles even when no one is watching.

KEY CONCEPT

- Integrity reflects wholeness of character — following moral principles consistently, even when no one is watching.
- ‘Ships do not sink because of the water around them; ships sink because of the water that gets into them.’ Likewise, our character does not sink because of the wrongdoing around us — it sinks when wrongdoing enters us, i.e., when there is a hole in the character.

4.6.1 Illustrations of Integrity

- Traffic light at midnight: stopping at a red light at 12 a.m. with no police, CCTV, or other car present shows integrity — following the moral/traffic law even when unwatched.
- Dr. Manmohan Singh (1991 reforms): after the devaluation of the rupee, the dollars he held rose in relative value; the extra value gained, he deposited into the Prime Minister’s Relief Fund — no one asked him to, yet he did. This is integrity (and avoidance of conflict of interest).
- Gandhiji (recap): paying for his grandchildren’s stay at the ashram, and expelling his sister over untouchability — both examples of integrity, done without anyone compelling him.

4.6.2 Types of Integrity

- Data integrity: data used in decision-making must be untampered and complete/inclusive — e.g., algorithmic bias when a system trained only on right-handed writers fails to recognise left-handed writing; non-inclusive data reflects a lack of data integrity.
- Information integrity: maintaining information free of distortion or error.
- Intellectual integrity: being honest and faithful to one’s intellect — the intellect’s job is to question, probe, and pursue truth (e.g., refusing to drink visibly dirty water because the intellect questions it). It means not accepting claims at face value and systematically being

critical of truth-claims, analysing evidence, rather than acting on prejudice (e.g., beliefs that a race is 'superior' or that women 'cannot do better' violate intellectual integrity).

4.6.3 Integrity vs Honesty

Aspect	Honesty	Integrity
Meaning	Truthfulness — telling the truth	Consistently following moral principles, even when unwatched
Example	Confessing 'I committed a murder' is honest. . .	. . . but not necessarily integral (the act itself breaches principle)
Relation	May exist without integrity	Wholesomeness of character; broader than honesty

EXAMPLE

- Mahabharata — Yudhishtira: 'Ashwatthama is dead — but the elephant, not the man.' He deliberately lowered his voice on 'not the man' so it was not heard. This is technically honesty but not integrity — a truth used to deceive.
- Whistle-blower illustrations: Satyendra Dubey exposed corruption/adulteration (e.g., sub-standard oil at a petrol pump) despite threats to his life — following moral principles even at personal risk is the essence of intellectual and moral integrity.

4.6.4 Why Integrity Matters in Public Life

- Public trust: if you do not follow moral principles consistently, people will not trust you (the shepherd-boy / 'cried wolf' logic — one lie and people stop believing you). Integrity maintains public trust and enables ethical decision-making.
- T. N. Seshan (former CEC): worked under political pressure, strictly enforced the Model Code of Conduct, and was pivotal in making the Electoral Photo Identity Card (EPIC / voter ID) a reality despite opposition — an example of ethical decision-making under pressure.
- Benefits: consistent good conduct raises credibility and trust, reduces corruption, improves accountability and transparency, boosts public engagement, and reduces conflicts of interest (e.g., Dr. Manmohan Singh's PM Relief Fund deposit).

4.6.5 Integrity Pact

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Integrity Pact: a collaborative agreement designed to enhance transparency and accountability in significant public-sector procurement. Prospective vendors/bidders and the public institution commit not to resort to corrupt practices (no bribery, no undue influence) at any stage of the contract. A useful, exam-ready suggestion for reducing corruption.

QUICK REVISION

Integrity = wholeness of character; following moral principles even when unwatched ('ships sink from water that gets in'). Examples: traffic light, Manmohan Singh's PM Relief Fund deposit, Gandhiji. Types: data, information, intellectual integrity. Integrity $\neq$ honesty (Yudhishtira: honest but not integral). Importance: public trust (Seshan/EPIC), less corruption, more transparency. Tool: Integrity Pact in public procurement.

4.7 Non-Partisanship, Impartiality & Neutrality

4.7.1 Background — Permanent vs Temporary Executive

Civil servants are (more or less) permanent, whereas political executives are temporary — elected for five years and may or may not return. The schemes a new government designs are implemented by the same bureaucrats recruited under a previous regime, so the political executive must be able to trust that civil servants will faithfully and objectively execute the government of the day's decisions.

4.7.2 Non-Partisanship

KEY CONCEPT

- Non-Partisanship = not aligning oneself with any political party or ideology while making decisions. Whichever regime recruited a civil servant, they must implement the decisions of the government of the day faithfully and objectively.
- It is a NEGATIVE concept — it bars any association/alignment with political parties.
- Why it matters: as a permanent executive, you advise temporary political executives (who may be first-time office-holders and lack administrative expertise); they must be able to trust that your advice and your implementation are fair and objective, regardless of which regime recruited you. Also called political neutrality.

4.7.3 Impartiality

KEY CONCEPT

Impartiality = when interacting with different people, not discriminating between them on the basis of race, caste, sex, religion, etc. It is a POSITIVE concept — it does not bar engagement; it only bars discrimination during engagement.

4.7.4 *Non-Partisanship vs Impartiality*

Aspect	Non-Partisanship	Impartiality
Core idea	No alignment with any political party/ideology	No discrimination between people while engaging them
Concept type	Negative concept (bars association)	Positive concept (bars discrimination, not engagement)
Orientation	About relationship with political parties	About fair, unbiased treatment of all people
Nature	A stance of no-association	Action-oriented, equal treatment of all

EXAMPLE

Election Commission illustration: if an ECI helps party A in State A and party B in State B, it is IMPARTIAL (treating parties equally, not discriminating) but it is VIOLATING non-partisanship (it should have no association with any party at all). This shows the two are distinct.

4.7.5 *Neutrality*

Neutrality overlaps with objectivity: it means having no personal values in decision-making — deciding on facts alone, favouring no political party or ideology. A politically partisan Election Commission favouring a party would undermine democracy, which is why neutrality and non-partisanship matter.

4.7.6 *Relevance & Violations*

- Objectivity promotes impartiality: deciding by facts (interviews, tenders, charge sheets on evidence) prevents favouritism; impartiality upholds rule of law, fair scheme delivery, public trust, efficiency, social harmony, and government legitimacy.
- Violations of non-partisanship: civil servants resigning and immediately contesting elections (no ‘cooling-off’ period) raises public doubt; post-retirement benefits linked to contesting on a party ticket; and frequent political transfers/postings signalling that the political executive does not trust the bureaucrat’s non-partisanship (as seen around elections in West Bengal and Kerala).

CRITICAL POINT

A cooling-off period matters: when a civil servant resigns and contests elections the very next day, people will always doubt the neutrality of their earlier service. Suspicion itself damages the value.

QUICK REVISION

Non-Partisanship (negative concept) = no alignment with any political party; the permanent executive must be trusted by the temporary political executive. Impartiality (positive concept)

= no discrimination by race/caste/sex/religion while engaging all. Neutrality = no personal values, decide on facts (overlaps objectivity). ECI example distinguishes impartiality from non-partisanship. Violations: instant resign-and-contest (no cooling-off), party-ticket post-retirement, political transfers.

4.8 Tolerance

KEY CONCEPT

Tolerance = a permissive attitude towards opinions, practices, and behaviour different from ours — the capacity to accept and respect differences, diversity, and opposing viewpoints even amid disagreement or disapproval. Acceptance here means acknowledging that the difference exists and giving it space and respect, not necessarily adopting the practice oneself.

4.8.1 Why Tolerance Matters

- For liberty & freedom of expression: you cannot exercise freedom of expression without tolerance — even if you disagree, the other person has the right to speak.
- For social harmony: lack of tolerance breeds hate, hate crimes, communal riots, and caste-based violence; when we fail to understand and accept others' diversity, hate creeps in.
- For rule of law: bias against a community leads to disproportionate policing/jailing of that group; rule of law requires impartiality, which requires tolerance.
- Especially in a diverse country: 'kos-kos par badle paani, chaar kos par baani' — water changes every short distance and language every few miles. Imposing one's own language on others (as in some Karnataka/Maharashtra incidents where people were attacked over language) reflects intolerance. Linguistic, ethnic, and religious violence are all products of intolerance.

EXAMPLE

- Personal illustration: the teacher (a vegetarian) once held a poor view of non-vegetarians; exposure at IIT Kharagpur changed this. Today his close friends are all non-vegetarian and they eat together — tolerance is accepting different practices, not necessarily following them.
- Positive examples: Republic Day parade celebrating unity in diversity; Golden Temple langar where all eat together; the whole nation supporting the Indian cricket team irrespective of language/religion/region; nationwide prayers for the Chandrayaan mission. Negative examples: mob lynching, honour killing — products of a lack of tolerance.

CRITICAL POINT

Tolerance does not mean tolerating a genuinely wrong act — it means accepting legitimate differences (of language, dress, food, faith, opinion), not condoning wrongdoing.

QUICK REVISION

Tolerance = permissive attitude towards, and acceptance/respect of, legitimate differences even

amid disagreement (not adoption of the practice). Needed for liberty & free expression, social harmony (against hate crimes, communal/caste violence), and rule of law (impartiality). Vital in a diverse India ('kos-kos par badle paani'). Positive examples: Republic Day parade, Golden Temple langar, cricket-team support, Chandrayaan prayers. It does not mean tolerating wrongdoing.

4.9 Sympathy, Empathy & Compassion

4.9.1 *The Three Distinguished*

Concept	What it involves	Illustration
Sympathy	Operates mostly at the COGNITIVE level — you register another's suffering ('I understand you are in pain') but do not necessarily feel it	Feeling pity for a person who is struggling
Empathy	Not just cognitive — you FEEL the pain of the other, putting your feet in their shoes	Crying with a close friend over their breakup
Compassion	Empathy PLUS ACTION — feeling the pain and actively acting to reduce it	Feeling the friend's pain and then actually helping them

KEY CONCEPT

Sympathy = registering suffering at the cognitive level (pity). Empathy = feeling the other's pain (walking in their shoes). Compassion = empathy + action to alleviate the suffering. Great souls — Mother Teresa, Gandhiji, saints — feel and act on others' pain.

- Related terms — apathy & antipathy: apathy = lack of interest in another's pain ('let them die, it does not concern me'); antipathy = strong dislike or hostility towards someone. These sit at the negative end of the spectrum of responses to another's suffering; compassion (paropkar/altruism) sits at the positive end.

4.9.2 *Why Empathy & Compassion Matter in Administration*

Traditional Weberian bureaucracy — 'decide on facts and facts alone, not emotions' — tends to become apathetic and rule-bound. Compassion is the corrective.

- Rule-bound approach hurting the vulnerable: in the caste-census / lineage-proof exercise, people were asked to establish parental lineage — but those raised in orphanages or foster care cannot prove lineage. Over-emphasis on such rules goes against empathy and compassion.
- Tribal / bank-KYC case (recap): officials looked only at objective facts ('show the caste certificate') and lacked empathy and compassion — they neither felt the person's difficulty nor acted to help resolve it.
- Apathetic administration: after a paper leak, merely re-conducting the exam ignores the pain suffered by many families — administration at times becomes apathetic to others' pain.

- PDS officer & the old lady (recap): turning away an old lady with no document, ignoring the welfare-state obligation — compassion, Antyodaya, and the Talisman (think of the last-mile person) are needed here.

4.9.3 Where Compassion Is Essential

- Social justice: the majority of people displaced by developmental projects since independence are tribals, who often did not receive commensurate benefits — a compassion deficit. Demolitions of slums without notice similarly lack empathy.
- Welfare state: empathy lets us understand others' suffering and act with kindness; it also underpins selflessness (firefighters, soldiers, doctors, COVID warriors).
- Dealing with victims: when victims approach you, you must feel their pain rather than deflect them ('not my jurisdiction, go elsewhere'). Compassion also makes you non-judgmental.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Compassion-linked examples (usable in answers): One Nation One Ration Card (for migrants); Swachh Bharat Mission / toilet in every home; Ayushman Bharat and legal aid; passive euthanasia (recognising the right to die with dignity); Operation Ganga (Ukraine evacuation); Poshan Abhiyaan; pink booths and cooling booths in summer; India's 'Vaccine Maitri'. Many welfare measures can be cited as examples of compassion.

QUICK REVISION

Sympathy (cognitive registering/pity) → Empathy (feeling the pain) → Compassion (feeling + action to reduce it). Negative end: apathy (no interest) and antipathy (hostility). Weberian, rule-bound administration turns apathetic (lineage proof, tribal KYC, PDS old lady, paper-leak families), so compassion is the corrective — vital for social justice (tribal displacement), the welfare state, and victim-facing work. Examples: ONORC, Swachh Bharat, Ayushman Bharat, passive euthanasia, Operation Ganga, Vaccine Maitri.

4.10 Dedication to Public Service

KEY CONCEPT

Dedication to public service = passionate commitment and devotion to serving the public interest — going the extra mile, not merely doing routine 10-to-5 compliance. When work becomes worship and civil service becomes a vocation and a way of life, that is dedication.

4.10.1 Why Dedication Is Needed

- Because we are a welfare state: the state exists to help others; going a step further to deliver help (e.g., carrying out vaccination in remote areas rather than stopping at easy targets) is dedication.
- Challenging circumstances: Central Armed Police Forces in Naxal areas work in harsh conditions — at times dying of malaria rather than bullets — guarding us; overcoming such challenges requires deep motivation and passionate commitment.

- Problem-solving: IAS Divya Mittal helped bring drinking water for the first time since independence to a village in Mirzapur; and Ansaram Peram (crowdfunding) built ~100 km of road — dedication drives the innovation that solves problems where funds or facilities are lacking.

4.10.2 *Dedication as a ‘Mother Value’*

Dedication draws on empathy, compassion, and impartiality together, so it overlaps with the values already covered — whatever we do to project the public interest culminates in dedication to public service.

- Disaster management: going a step ahead to enhance service delivery during a crisis — e.g., helicopter rescues during the Punjab floods — exemplifies dedication.
- Timely delivery of government projects: counter to the reputation of government projects being slow, the Delhi Metro’s first phase was delivered ahead of its original deadline — a great example (associated with E. Sreedharan) of passionate commitment to timely delivery.

4.10.3 *Significance*

- Promotes good governance, enhances public trust, and improves public service delivery (e.g., Direct Benefit Transfer). Examples used under compassion can also serve as examples of dedication.

QUICK REVISION

Dedication to public service = passionate commitment to the public interest, going the extra mile (work as worship, service as vocation). Needed for the welfare state (remote-area vaccination), challenging circumstances (CAPF in Naxal areas), and problem-solving (IAS Divya Mittal’s water project; crowdfunded roads). A ‘mother value’ drawing on empathy, compassion & impartiality; seen in disaster management (Punjab flood rescues) and timely delivery (Delhi Metro / E. Sreedharan). Significance: good governance, public trust, better service delivery (DBT).

4.11 Key Cross-Cutting Reminders

- Objectivity vs compassion is the central tension: Weberian objectivity prevents nepotism and corruption but, over-applied, becomes mechanical and apathetic. Good administration balances objectivity with empathy, compassion, and dedication.
- Distinguish the look-alike values precisely: non-partisanship (negative, about parties) vs impartiality (positive, about non-discrimination); honesty vs integrity; sympathy vs empathy vs compassion; aptitude (capacity) vs attitude (predisposition).
- The ethics one-liner: ethics is the difference between what you have the right to do and what is the right thing to do.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

High-probability themes: (1) Gandhi’s Seven Social Sins (esp. ‘Science without Humanity’ and ‘Religion without Sacrifice’); (2) attitude vs aptitude and ‘altering life by altering attitude’; (3) ‘Visionary decision-making at the intersection of logic and intuition’ (limits of objectivity);

(4) distinguishing non-partisanship, impartiality and neutrality; (5) empathy/compassion in administration; (6) integrity (with the Integrity Pact as a value-addition).

Emotional Intelligence and Attitude

5.1 Recap: Foundational Values for Civil Services

The previous class dealt with the foundational values for civil services. This session opens by revising those ideas before moving into fresh examples and new topics.

5.1.1 *Dedication to Public Service (Passionate Commitment)*

Dedication to public service is very important, and it is essentially a passionate commitment. Passionate commitment means going beyond doing the minimum. That is what dedication to public service means.

KEY CONCEPT

- Passionate commitment = going beyond doing the minimum required of the role.
- This is the essence of “dedication to public service”.

5.1.2 *Sympathy, Empathy and Compassion*

These are three different things, and they were distinguished carefully:

- Sympathy: operates mostly at the cognitive level — you merely understand that the other person is in difficulty. You feel some pity or “daya” (mercy) towards them.
- Empathy: you actually feel the pain of others — you experience their pain yourself.
- Compassion: this is when empathy is accompanied by a desire to alleviate the problems of others. There is a desire to make an effort to reduce the other person’s pain.

Of course, compassion is the biggest of the three, because it carries the desire to actually try to reduce the other person’s pain. That is what administration should look for.

COMPARISON

- Sympathy → cognitive understanding + pity (“daya”).
- Empathy → you feel the other’s pain.
- Compassion → empathy + desire to elevate/alleviate the other’s problems (the highest).

Various examples were discussed for how administration should be empathetic and compassionate.

Weberian Bureaucracy — the contrast This was discussed especially in the context of Weberian bureaucracy. Weber asked bureaucracy to be objective only and rational only. Weberian bureau-

cracy was supposed to be value-neutral — that is, taking decisions on the basis of facts and facts alone, and not focusing on emotions in decision-making.

KEY CONCEPT

- Weberian bureaucracy = value-neutral: decisions on facts alone, not emotions.
- It was meant to be strictly objective and rational.

5.1.3 Non-partisanship and Impartiality

Non-partisanship Non-partisanship means that we will not align with any political party or ideology. It is important for bureaucrats not to align with a political party or ideologies, because bureaucrats are the permanent executive. On the other hand, political executives are temporary in nature — they keep coming and going, because governments can change.

Governments can change even during the tenure in which these bureaucrats were recruited. When you become an IAS officer, you will serve the Government of India for roughly 25–35 years, and it is not certain which government will remain in power over that period.

It is important that every new government formed at the central level should be able to trust the advice of the civil servant, because civil servants come with expertise and a lot of experience. They should give this advice both in policy-making and in policy implementation. When advice is given to ministers, ministers should not feel that the officer is a “Congress person” or a “BJP person”. They should believe in the objectivity of the advice, and should also trust the civil servant with the implementation of their policies. For example, in implementing “Make in India”, it is bureaucrats who are the first implementers. That is why it becomes very important that administrators can be trusted. For policy formulation, for objective advice, and for implementation of framed policies, non-partisanship is essential.

CRITICAL POINT

- Non-partisanship is a NEGATIVE concept: it bars any association with any political party or ideology.
- Rationale: bureaucrats are the permanent executive; political executives are temporary.
- Needed for (a) objective policy advice, and (b) faithful implementation across changing governments.

If transfers, postings and promotions begin to happen on a partisan basis — on the basis of alignment with a political party — then who will work hard? What will be the motivation and morale of the civil services? Additionally, citizens will lose faith in the administration if there is no non-partisanship, because they will feel the officer is “a BJP person” or “a Congress person” or “a party person”. When you start behaving as a stooge of a political party rather than as a bureaucrat following constitutional morality, people lose faith in the administration.

EXAMPLE

Land acquisition and conflict resolution were given as cases where non-partisanship becomes very important, so that the administrator can be trusted by the people.

Impartiality Impartiality means that whenever you are engaging with anyone, you should not discriminate amongst them — for example, on the basis of race, caste, sex, religion, etc. Impartiality is a positive concept, because it is not barring your association with anyone; it is in fact asking that whenever you interact with anyone, you should not discriminate amongst them.

COMPARISON

- Non-partisanship = negative concept: bars association with any political party.
- Impartiality = positive concept: does not bar association with anyone; instead demands non-discrimination during any interaction.

A simple example: as the Election Commission of India, if I have two states or two political parties before me and I am not impartial, I would favour one. Impartiality is more of a positive concept — you remain impartial across political parties, saying in effect, “I am not here to take sides.”

QUICK REVISION

- Passionate commitment = beyond the minimum.
- Sympathy (cognitive/pity) < Empathy (feel the pain) < Compassion (feel + desire to alleviate).
- Weberian bureaucracy = value-neutral, facts alone.
- Non-partisanship = negative concept (no party alignment); Impartiality = positive concept (no discrimination).

5.2 Examples & PYQ Themes on Foundational Values

New examples and past-year-question (PYQ) themes were introduced, showing where UPSC frames questions.

5.2.1 Objectivity without Compassion — the Mining Districts Case

Over half of the one lakh crore rupees collected for the welfare of the mining districts was not spent. Funds are often diverted to activities that are not directly linked to the welfare of the mining district. If you do not know what to do, then why collect so much for the welfare of the worker? This is objectivity but without compassion — and in this context empathy and compassion become much more important.

DATA & FACTS

- Over half of Rs. 1 lakh crore collected for welfare of mining districts was not spent.
- Funds often diverted to activities not directly linked to mining-district welfare.
- Illustrates objectivity WITHOUT compassion.

5.2.2 PYQ Theme — Integrity and Knowledge

Quotation-based theme: “Integrity without knowledge is weak and useless, but knowledge without integrity is dangerous and dreadful.” When we talk about integrity we are really talking about two

important axes: one is integrity, and another is knowledge. This is exactly the place where UPSC frames questions.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- PYQ theme: “Integrity without knowledge is weak and useless, but knowledge without integrity is dangerous and dreadful.”
- Also: “In looking for people to hire, you look for three qualities: integrity, intelligence and energy. If they do not have the first, the other two will kill you.”
- Also: “Why should impartiality and non-partisanship be considered as foundational values, especially in the socio-political context?”

Integrity without knowledge (weak & useless) Consider a surgeon who has integrity but lacks skill, versus a highly skilled surgeon whose success rate is very poor. The example given: a surgeon who is not competent — around 90% of patients die and only about 10% survive the operation. The point is that mere integrity plus incompetence is useless. If doctors are incompetent, if teachers are incompetent, the students suffer. So integrity without knowledge is weak and useless — for a public servant, competence matters because decisions have consequences for the public.

Knowledge without integrity (dangerous & dreadful) On the other dimension, knowledge without integrity is dangerous and dreadful. As noted in the inculcation of values: “knowledge without values makes a man a more clever devil.” If a person has knowledge but no integrity/values, that knowledge only makes him a more clever devil — a sin. This is why the theme repeats: integrity without knowledge is weak and useless, while knowledge without integrity is dreadful and dangerous.

CRITICAL POINT

- Integrity + no competence → weak & useless (e.g., surgeon with 90% mortality).
- Competence + no integrity → “clever devil”; dangerous & dreadful.
- Both axes are required in a public servant.

5.2.3 Impartiality vs. Positive Discrimination — a Caveat

If impartiality is followed absolutely, it can itself become a source of trouble. Where there is inequality in society, positive discrimination is required — it should favour the weaker sections. Generalists also make this point: wherever there is inequality in society, positive discrimination should be there to favour weaker sections. So absolutely following impartiality (treating everyone identically regardless of disadvantage) is problematic; some positive discrimination (that is, “positive partiality”) is justified.

CRITICAL POINT

- Absolute impartiality can be harmful where society is unequal.
- Positive discrimination in favour of weaker sections is a justified “positive partiality”.

5.3 Ready-to-Use Examples: Apathy, Compassion & Dedication

Several current examples were provided that can be used directly in answers.

Examples of Apathy / Lack of Compassion

- Sewer deaths: 90% of the sewer-death workers had no safety gear. If 90% of deaths involved no safety gear at all, this shows apathy and a lack of compassion. This study was done by the ministry itself — a social audit commission by the Union Government — which found that 90% of sewer deaths involved no safety gear. (Note it briefly.)
- Forced evictions: People were forcibly evicted from forest land without settlement of their rights under the FRA (Forest Rights Act). The NAPM pointed out this eviction “without settlement of their rights”. This is an example of apathy — of how working apathetically goes against social justice.

DATA & FACTS

- 90% of sewer-death workers had NO safety gear (social audit commission study by the Union Government).
- Forest-dwellers forcibly evicted from forest land WITHOUT settlement of their rights under the FRA (raised by NAPM).

Examples of Compassion & Dedication to Public Service

- Transgender clinic: India’s first clinic for transgender persons reopened in Hyderabad — a very good example of compassion and dedication, as the first clinic for transgender people.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- India’s first clinic for transgender persons — reopened in Hyderabad (compassion + dedication).
- FRA (Forest Rights Act) invoked re: settlement of forest-dwellers’ rights before eviction.

QUICK REVISION

- Apathy examples: sewer deaths (90% no safety gear); forced forest evictions without FRA settlement.
- Compassion/dedication example: India’s first transgender clinic (Hyderabad).
- Objectivity-without-compassion example: unspent mining-district welfare funds.

5.4 Emotional Intelligence

5.4.1 Opening Quote

“Anyone can become angry — that is easy. But to be angry with the right person, to the right degree, at the right time, for the right purpose, and in the right way — that is not easy.” The quote conveys that it is easy to be angry; all of us experience emotions. What is important is that emotions come out before the right person, to the right degree, and in the right way. This is what

emotional intelligence is.

KEY CONCEPT

- Quote: anger is easy; but anger with the right person, degree, time, purpose and way is hard.
- That difficulty is exactly what emotional intelligence addresses.

We all feel emotions, and emotions are a source of energy for us. But how do we regulate those emotions? We should not be driven by emotions. If we are driven by emotion — for instance if anger keeps rising — then in anger a person might even commit a hate crime or hurt someone. That is absolutely wrong. You should not be driven by emotions; emotions should not drive you — you should regulate them. That is emotional intelligence.

CRITICAL POINT

- Do NOT be driven by emotions (being driven by anger can lead to hate crimes/violence).
- Emotions should be regulated, not allowed to drive behaviour.

5.4.2 Definition

Emotional intelligence is the ability to interpret, understand and manage one's own emotions and the emotions of others.

It is an “ability” — so it can be misused Look carefully at the definition. First, it is an ability. If it is an ability, it means it can also be misused. Any ability can be misused. For example, a technological ability to read everyone's WhatsApp chats could be used positively (in a security context) or negatively (threatening someone's privacy). The point is that any ability can be misused.

Therefore, if a person is emotionally intelligent, that by itself does not make him a moral person. This links to the “moral attitude” idea taught earlier under civil-services attitude: even if you are emotionally intelligent, you will not necessarily use it morally. (The misuse dimension is taken up in detail at the end of the topic.)

CRITICAL POINT

- Emotional intelligence is an ABILITY → it can be misused.
- Being emotionally intelligent does NOT by itself make a person moral.

Interpret/understand + manage = Recognition + Regulation “Interpret and understand” means recognition — we should be able to recognize, interpret and understand our emotions. “Manage” means regulation — we should be able to control them. Recognition is the first step: if I am getting angry, I should first recognize that I am getting angry; without recognizing it I cannot work on it. Then comes regulation — controlling it. And this applies not only to our own emotions but also to the emotions of others, because the definition covers “one's emotions and emotions of others”.

KEY CONCEPT

- Two dimensions: Recognition and Regulation.

- Recognition = self-awareness (own emotions) + social awareness (others' emotions).
- Regulation = self-management (own emotions) + relationship management (others' emotions).

5.4.3 Five Components of Emotional Intelligence

Human beings feel emotions — anger, frustration, grief — and much of this is driven by self-motivation. From this flow the five major components of emotional intelligence.

Component	What it means
Self-awareness	Awareness of your own emotions (e.g., recognizing “I am getting angry”). Built by habitual introspection and meditation.
Social awareness	Recognizing and understanding the emotions of others.
Self-regulation	Managing and controlling your own emotions (e.g., anger management).
Social regulation	Relationship management — influencing/regulating others' emotions; managing relationships.
Motivation	The self-motivation that ultimately drives regulation of emotions and delayed gratification.

Why self-awareness matters Until we have awareness about ourselves, how will we control our emotions? Meditation simply asks you to focus on yourself — this is what the Buddha did. So self-awareness is very important; it is the first step to processing and regulating emotions.

Why social awareness matters The second step is social awareness — understanding the emotions of others — because if I do not understand the other's situation, how will I do relationship management? Several examples illustrate this:

Tribals — two approaches and the golden mean There were two choices for dealing with tribals. One is the “museum-species approach” — leaving tribals as they are, like specimens kept untouched in a museum, saying in effect “keep living in the forest.” The other extreme is full assimilation, where the tribal's own culture, language and traditions are lost as they adopt the mainstream language and culture. The Nehruvian Panchsheel — the Tribal Panchsheel policy — is the golden mean between these two approaches: not isolation, and not forced assimilation, but “I should help them while keeping their culture, language, etc. intact.” This became possible because of better awareness.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Nehruvian / Tribal Panchsheel: the golden mean between the “museum-species” (isolation) approach and forced assimilation.
- Principle: help tribals develop while keeping their culture and language intact — enabled by better social awareness.

Naxalism — security vs. development, and SAMADHAN Naxalism can be seen purely as a law-and-order problem (send in security forces, a security-oriented approach) or through a “development-deficit” and humanitarian lens. Better social awareness is needed to diagnose the problem correctly. The SAMADHAN approach is a combination of both — it became possible with better social awareness. Without better social awareness, a problem cannot be diagnosed correctly.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- SAMADHAN: the Government’s strategy against Naxalism — a combination of the security approach and the development-deficit/humanitarian approach.
- Correct diagnosis of Naxalism requires better social awareness.

Swachh Bharat — building toilets is not enough Merely building toilets does not automatically bring cleanliness or reduce open defecation. Why not? Because of poor social awareness. Correct social awareness recognizes that Swachh Bharat Mission requires behavioural change, not just infrastructure. In all these problems, without better social awareness we cannot solve the problem — which shows the importance of emotional intelligence.

EXAMPLE

- Toilets built $\neq$ cleanliness achieved, unless behaviour changes — requires social awareness.
- Beti Bachao Beti Padhao → change attitude towards the girl child.
- Swachh Bharat → not just build toilets but change behaviour (“use them too”).

Non-verbal communication and power distance Social awareness is also important because many times a person cannot state their problem in words. In a live class, the teacher reads students’ faces to judge whether they have understood — this is non-verbal communication, which is impossible without social awareness. An officer must read facial expressions and body language to understand how much difficulty the other person is facing. This matters because there is a lot of power distance between officers and the people; officers must themselves have social awareness to better regulate their behaviour.

KEY CONCEPT

- Non-verbal communication (reading faces, expressions) depends on social awareness.
- Large power distance between officers and people makes officers’ social awareness essential.

Self-regulation Self-regulation means managing and regulating your own emotions. The Buddha’s example: he was surrounded by disciples, and a person on the way spat on him; through his self-regulated, calm reaction the person was humbled (“paani-paani ho gaya”) and converted to become his disciple. That is self-regulation — managing and regulating your emotion.

Nelson Mandela’s forgiveness is another example. When Mandela came out of jail, he too had to practise self-regulation, because anger is natural when injustice has been done to you. “Forgiveness is a tribute of the strong; the weak cannot forgive.” To forgive, your heart has to be a little bigger — you must be able to digest your anger.

Also: “Anger and prejudice are enemies of correct understanding” (a UPSC-relevant line). If we

are angry, our understanding is not as good; the mind, when agitated or angry, does not reflect things clearly. So anger and intolerance are enemies of correct understanding.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- “Anger and intolerance are enemies of correct understanding.” (quotation theme)
- Self-regulation examples: the Buddha (spat upon, calm response); Nelson Mandela’s forgiveness; “forgiveness is a tribute of the strong”.

Social regulation (Relationship management) Social regulation is relationship management — managing others’ emotions, giving people full attention. When someone is experiencing grief, how do I manage my relationship with that person? This is where the IQ-versus-EQ discussion becomes relevant.

IQ vs. EQ Traditionally we relied heavily on IQ (intelligence quotient) — the belief that if you have high IQ you will be successful. But in real life, emotional quotient (EQ) has a very big role. There are many people who are intellectually sound with good IQ, but when placed in a team or asked to lead one, they cannot manage people, because they lack EQ. EQ is your ability to understand others’ emotions and regulate emotions.

IQ (Intelligence Quotient)	EQ (Emotional Quotient)
Reasoning, problem-solving, cognitive ability.	Emotional skills — understanding and managing emotions of self and others.
Traditionally over-relied upon.	Crucial for leadership, team management and relationship management.
Measured by conventional IQ tests.	About making emotions “work for you rather than against you”.

For leadership, EQ is essential. A person with high IQ but poor EQ cannot deliver their best as a team leader. Respect is commanded by following EQ: leaders like Gandhiji became great leaders because they had EQ — people relate to you when you understand their pain and emotions, and only then do you command respect. A leader’s big task is to hold a vision and a goal; the leader’s goal becomes the followers’ goal only when the leader convinces them. Gandhiji’s goal was Swaraj/independence, and he made everyone understand why we all should follow it. Without EQ you cannot persuade others; “1 + 1 = 11” — the synergy — comes only with EQ. For a civil servant (IAS/IFS), EQ is very important for relationship management.

EXAMPLE

- Leadership examples of EQ: Gandhiji (persuaded masses towards Swaraj); a leader’s goal becomes followers’ goal only through EQ.
- High IQ + poor EQ → cannot lead a team effectively.

Motivation & the Marshmallow Test To manage emotions, you ultimately need to be motivated. The Marshmallow Test (a US university experiment): children were seated at a table with a simple

rule — they could leave anytime and get one marshmallow, but if they waited (about an hour) they would get two marshmallows. Some children ate the one marshmallow immediately; others delayed. On studying the group, those who were able to delay their gratification turned out to be much more successful in life, because they were motivated enough to delay gratification.

Delayed gratification means you are motivated enough to postpone immediate satisfaction for a bigger reward — the fun of a party today can be set aside because “I want to become an IAS or a public servant, so I delay this gratification and take some pain now.” Many people leave a job or a bigger campus-placement package to prepare for something bigger — that too is delaying gratification. Motivation is what enables you to regulate your emotions and delay gratification. Even a bureaucrat must delay gratification and motivate — working for what is right rather than merely for postings and promotions.

DATA & FACTS

Marshmallow Test (US university): 1 marshmallow now vs. 2 if you wait ~1 hour. Children who delayed gratification were much more successful later — due to motivation.

KEY CONCEPT

- Motivation → enables delayed gratification → enables emotional regulation.
- Applies to civil servants: work for what is right, not merely for postings/promotions.

5.4.4 Case Study: The Bank Manager & the Digital Arrest

A person (the victim) repeatedly came to a bank wanting to withdraw large sums. The whole case was one of “digital arrest” — a scam. This is a great example of emotional intelligence:

- Social awareness: No one told the bank manager that the customer was under digital arrest; the manager herself understood, from the customer’s behaviour, that she was in trouble.
- Self-regulation: When the manager intervened, the customer replied that she should “mind her own business.” Anyone would be angered by such a reply, but the manager regulated her emotions.
- Compassion & relationship management: The manager still pursued the matter and spoke with her, ultimately saving her from losing about Rs. 79 lakh.

As written up: the victim returned to dissolve another savings worth Rs. 30 lakh; this time the manager refused to transmit any money unless someone from the family arrived. By this time the victim was agitated and scared, and on the steps of the bank was pleading with someone on the phone. The manager, watching her movements on CCTV, walked out and took the phone. The person on the other end claimed to be the victim’s brother-in-law; when asked the sister’s name he fell silent, and on continued probing, disconnected the call.

EXAMPLE

- Bank manager (digital-arrest case): social awareness (sensed trouble unaided) + self-regulation (“mind your own business” reply) + compassion + relationship management.

- Outcome: saved the victim ~Rs. 79 lakh; caught the scam via CCTV and probing the caller.
- Shows the power of non-verbal communication and proactiveness.

5.4.5 Case Study: Topography of Terror (Berlin)

The “Topography of Terror” and the “Memorial to the Murdered Jews of Europe” are in Berlin. In the museum there are many letters displayed, which visitors are asked to read (not merely watch). At a site where the police headquarters once stood, officials discussed how to kill Jews on an “industrial scale.” The reasoning recorded there was that if Jews were killed one by one with guns, the killers would suffer negative mental-health consequences — so a method was devised to kill people on an industrial scale, since they intended to kill lakhs of people.

One method recorded: prisoners were placed in the windowless storage area of a vehicle, and during the journey to a nearby forest, engine exhaust fumes were pumped into that sealed area; the prisoners inside died an agonizing death, and their bodies were buried in mass graves in the forest. Visitors, on reading these accounts, feel the pain of others. On leaving the “Topography of Terror,” visitors encounter reflective questions asking them to introspect, making them aware of historical blunders and prompting an apologetic reckoning.

EXAMPLE

- Topography of Terror / Memorial to the Murdered Jews of Europe (Berlin): museums sensitize visitors, building social awareness.
- Nazis planned killing on an “industrial scale” partly to spare killers’ mental health — a chilling case of misused rationality.
- Museums use historical example to sensitize people (build EI) about victims’ plight.

KEY CONCEPT

You need emotional intelligence to experience compassion — EI is the ability that lets you feel others’ pain; compassion and empathy follow from it.

5.4.6 More Examples of Emotional Intelligence (and its absence)

Lack of emotional intelligence

- BLO overburdening: State governments were not empathetic to their own workforce; instead of deploying fresh staff to ease each BLO’s workload, the burden was left on them, and many BLOs committed suicide because they were overburdened. The Supreme Court remarked on this. A lack of emotional intelligence.
- Officials slapping citizens: A person coming out of a Covid queue was slapped; in a Rajasthan petrol-pump incident an SDM reportedly slapped an attendant. These show bureaucrats unable to manage their emotions.

Presence of emotional intelligence

- Chadotaru tradition (Banaskantha): The Banaskantha Police Station initiated a meticulous process of reconciliation to ensure a peaceful homecoming for families who had had to leave

their village. The police understood the community's tradition (Chadotaru), regulated emotions, and corrected a historical error — bringing 29 (and separately 21) tribal families back. A great example of emotional intelligence (social awareness + relationship management).

- Ganguly's leadership: Players like Yuvraj Singh and Harbhajan Singh said they "could die for a captain like Ganguly." Virender Sehwag, Harbhajan and Yuvraj say Ganguly backed them fully. Leadership means backing your people and understanding their emotions, so a new player does not feel anxiety about being dropped after one failure — anxiety harms performance.
- Rahul Dravid's press conferences: When India lost the 2023 World Cup final, Rahul Dravid came and took the press conference; when India won the 2024 T20 World Cup, Rohit Sharma took the press conference. Dravid took the blame in defeat — a great example of leadership and EI, because he knew what the players were going through.
- Sangi Express (bike ambulance): IAS officer Awanish Sharan (Chhattisgarh) started a bike ambulance named "Sangi Express" because in remote areas regular ambulances could not reach and were costly. This low-cost two-wheeler ambulance reduced medical costs. Example of EI + innovation + compassion.
- SDM carrying the injured: When a couple lay bleeding on the road, an SDM took them to hospital — by car and even on a passer-by's bike — understanding and trying to elevate their pain. An example of EI and compassion.
- Osmanabad Collector: The Osmanabad Collector sat on the ground floor to meet a person with a disability (a person with different ability) who could not sit on a chair. The visitor did not ask the officer to sit on the ground; the Collector did it on his own to understand and hear them. An example of EI.
- PM waiting at the airport: The PM waiting at the airport for some time before an exam to avoid causing traffic — an example of EI and compassion (anticipating others' pain).
- Liquor ban in religious cities (MP): Liquor ban in 19 religious cities in Madhya Pradesh (under select gram panchayats) so that people's religious sentiments are not hurt — an example of social awareness / respecting cultural traditions.

EXAMPLE

- EI present: Chadotaru reconciliation (Banaskantha Police); Ganguly & Dravid leadership; Sangi Express bike ambulance (Awanish Sharan); Osmanabad Collector; PM waiting at airport; MP liquor ban in 19 religious cities.
- EI absent: BLOs overburdened (suicides; SC remarked); officials slapping citizens (Covid queue, Rajasthan petrol pump).

KEY CONCEPT

All examples of compassion/empathy can also be used as examples of emotional intelligence — they are interchangeable (e.g., Kiran Bedi's Tihar Jail reforms understanding prisoners' plight; welfare schemes).

QUICK REVISION

- EI = ability to interpret, understand & manage one's own and others' emotions (Recognition + Regulation).
- 5 components: self-awareness, social awareness, self-regulation, social regulation (relationship management), motivation.
- Being an ability, EI can be MISUSED and does not by itself make one moral.
- Golden-mean policy examples: Tribal Panchsheel; SAMADHAN (Naxalism).

5.5 Trained Apathy & Functional Detachment

This topic addresses whether too much sensitivity can itself be a problem. A public servant conducting a press conference on a very sensitive matter while grinning (“Poem case: cop caught grinning during media briefing, video sparks fury online”) is not in alignment with what is expected — showing why emotional intelligence is important.

Consider a doctor who deals with patients all day, each going through some problem. Of course the doctor should be sensitive; but if that sensitivity goes to the extent that the doctor breaks down and cries for every cancer patient, imagine the emotional toll. Similarly, imagine people working in a mortuary. There is a functional perspective to apathy: a certain apathy/detachment helps them do their work properly. The point is not that one should become apathetic, but that too much sensitivity towards emotions can also be harmful, because you are doing stressful work all day.

When you become a DM or SP, many people will come to you with requests and problems; you should be sensitive, but if you become emotional every time and, say, cry along with everyone, your own mental health will suffer. This is why a certain element of detachment is necessary. Emotional intelligence means controlling your emotions — being emotional is not the same as being emotionally intelligent. As the quote says, anyone can be angry, but to be angry with the right degree, measure, person and time is difficult. We should feel emotions but keep our own emotions in check, and not become excessively emotional, because that creates problems.

KEY CONCEPT

- “Trained apathy” / functional detachment: a measured detachment helps professionals (doctors, mortuary staff, DMs/SPs) function amid constant stress.
- Being emotional $\neq$ being emotionally intelligent; EI = keeping one's own emotions in check.

CRITICAL POINT

Too much sensitivity can harm the officer's own mental health — a certain element of detachment is necessary.

5.6 Using Emotions Positively (Emotions Working For You)

Emotional intelligence is about making emotions work for us rather than against us. “How's the Josh?” is an example of elevating emotions and channelling them in the right way. The key case

study is the use of non-rational motives to change attitudes.

5.6.1 *Rational vs. Non-rational (Extra-rational) Behaviour*

If we assume every human being is a rational human being (one who thinks logically and objectively), then giving them new information should make them act on it. But behaviour is not always guided by rational variables. For example, a smoker has been told “smoking causes cancer,” yet still smokes — that behaviour is not rational. This means actual behaviour is determined by extra-rational / non-rational factors too, i.e., emotions (for instance, addiction). Similarly, open defecation is not addressed merely by logically explaining the diseases it causes, because human beings do not always operate logically; they operate emotionally too. This is why emotions are used to change people’s attitudes.

KEY CONCEPT

- Actual behaviour is driven by extra-rational (non-rational) factors — emotions — not logic alone.
- Logical motive (e.g., “I won’t smoke because it causes cancer”) vs. non-rational motive (smoking despite knowing).

5.6.2 *Swachh Bharat Mission — Pride, Disgust, Love*

Swachh Bharat Mission used three important non-rational motives — pride, disgust and love — to change attitudes.

Disgust In workshops, a facilitator would drop a dead fly into a glass of water, take it out, and offer the water to drink. Naturally no one drinks it, because an element of disgust is present. The facilitators used this to explain that when a fly sits on human faeces and then lands on food, people still eat that food. Advertisements show this pictorially to evoke disgust, because people are not reasoning logically about disease — the disgust emotion is used to change attitudes.

Pride Big celebrities were involved in Swachh Bharat Mission, wielding brooms, to convey that cleaning work is something to take pride in. If even prominent people are cleaning their surroundings, ordinary citizens can take pride in doing the same. Celebrities posted videos of cleaning their neighbourhoods to evoke pride.

Love Marriages were reportedly cancelled where the groom’s house had no toilet — invoking the element of love: if you truly love your future wife/daughter-in-law, you would build a toilet. Where there is a lack of toilets, women going outside for defecation face greater risk of crime and safety problems; so the love element (“care for your daughters’ and daughters-in-law’s safety”) was invoked to encourage toilet construction.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Swachh Bharat Mission used three non-rational motives — PRIDE, DISGUST, LOVE — to drive attitudinal change.
- Disgust: dead-fly-in-water demonstration; pride: celebrities with brooms; love: no-toilet marriage cancellations & women’s safety.

5.6.3 Pictorial Warnings on Tobacco

On tobacco products, the text “smoking causes cancer” is information addressed to logic. But the graphic photo is added to evoke your emotions. A significant portion — reportedly around 40% — of the pack should carry the warning, precisely to evoke emotions. Both this and the Swachh Bharat case are strong case studies of “using emotions for you rather than against you.” (The film character Mukesh, shown in Indian cinema anti-tobacco clips, is a familiar reference.)

DATA & FACTS

- Pictorial warnings must cover a significant portion (reportedly ~40%) of tobacco packaging to evoke emotion.
- Text warning = information (logic); graphic image = emotional appeal.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- PYQ theme: “Emotional intelligence is the ability to make your emotions work for you instead of against you. Do you agree with this view?”
- PYQ theme: “Apart from intellectual competency and moral qualities, empathy and compassion are vital attributes. . . that help the civil servant tackle crucial issues.”

QUICK REVISION

- Positive use of emotions: SBM (pride, disgust, love); tobacco pictorial warnings (~40%).
- Negative examples: officials slapping citizens; the “grinning cop” press conference.
- Behaviour is driven by extra-rational factors → attitudes are changed via emotions.

5.7 Can Emotional Intelligence Be Learned?

Yes — emotional intelligence can be learned and inculcated. There are many methods and programmes, because the key components of EI (understanding and regulating one’s emotions) can be developed.

5.7.1 Methods to Inculcate Emotional Intelligence

- Training programmes / workshops / sensitivity training: Many courses include sensitivity training to sensitize people about others’ situations and problems.
- Role playing: For example, an actor preparing to play a transgender role spends many days meeting transgender persons to enter that role and understand their perspective. Role-playing exercises help build EI. (A husband who does household work himself — previously dismissed as trivial — realises its difficulty; a good role-playing example.)
- Role modelling / mentorship / learning from leaders: e.g., M.S. Dhoni mentoring someone on captaincy would stress processing one’s emotions and staying calm in stressful situations; learning from the Buddha’s calm reaction. Learning from leaders is very important.
- Enhancing self-awareness: by habitual (self-)introspection and meditation.
- Enhancing social awareness: e.g., LBSNAA’s “Bharat Darshan,” where officer-trainees are taken

to different areas to understand the problems of different regions; Gandhiji's train journey across India to build social awareness; media, which can sensitize people ("what the eyes do not see, the heart does not grieve about" — e.g., the Manipur incident used to spread awareness).

- Regulating emotions: yoga, meditation, pranayama, deep breathing (e.g., the deep breaths candidates take before a UPSC interview), and diversion of activity (as Virender Sehwag reportedly diverted attention — singing a song, punching a pillow — to divert oneself).
- Religious lessons: e.g., Buddhism's focus on Karuna (compassion) — understanding others' pain and removing it; every religion teaches such lessons.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- LBSNAA "Bharat Darshan" builds social awareness among officer-trainees by exposing them to different regions.
- Media can inculcate EI by sensitizing people (e.g., Manipur incident); "what the eyes do not see, the heart does not grieve about".

KEY CONCEPT

- Self-awareness → habitual introspection + meditation.
- Social awareness → tours (Bharat Darshan), media, role modelling.
- Regulation → yoga, meditation, pranayama, deep breathing, diversion of activity.
- Also: sensitivity training, role playing, mentorship/learning from leaders, religious lessons.

5.7.2 Emotional Intelligence Can Be Misused

Because EI is only an ability, it can be misused. Hitler was emotionally intelligent — what we call relationship management can, for someone with unethical character, become manipulation. EI means understanding others' pain and managing (motivating) relationships; but if your character is unethical, you use that understanding to change others' attitudes for your own benefit — which is manipulation. Hitler convinced all of Germany that, "for the rebirth of Germany, killing of Jews is important," and most stayed silent while Jews were killed.

Political leaders and religious leaders sometimes mislead their followers for their own benefit; they are emotionally intelligent — they understand what statement will produce what reaction — but their intentions are unethical, so they misuse their ability to manage emotions. Therefore emotional intelligence, by itself, does not lead to ethical decision-making, because the ability can be misused.

CRITICAL POINT

- EI is value-neutral (an ability) → it can be misused; by itself it does NOT ensure ethical decision-making.
- Misuse examples: Hitler; hate speeches by political leaders; manipulation by some religious leaders; terrorist brainwashing / ISIS recruitment & propaganda; misleading advertisements (e.g., "fair and lovely" type ads); "divide and rule" (British).

EXAMPLE

Media is a double-edged tool: it can sensitize (build EI) OR be misused (misleading ads, propaganda).

QUICK REVISION

- EI CAN be learned: training, role playing, role modelling/mentorship, introspection, meditation, yoga/pranayama/deep breathing, diversion, religious lessons, media.
- Enhance self-awareness by habitual introspection; social awareness by Bharat Darshan / media.
- EI can be MISUSED (Hitler, hate speech, ISIS propaganda) → EI alone ≠ ethical action.

5.8 Attitude: Meaning & Structure

5.8.1 What is Attitude?

Attitude is a relational term. “Relational” means that attitude is always discussed with respect to something; you never ask about attitude “in general,” but always attitude towards a particular attitudinal object.

Definition: Attitude is your predisposition (or tendency) to act in a certain way towards an attitudinal object.

KEY CONCEPT

- Attitude = predisposition / tendency to act in a certain way towards an attitudinal object.
- Attitude is always RELATIONAL — measured only with respect to an attitudinal object.

An attitudinal object can be anything: a person, a song, a singer, an actor, a particular ideology, a food item, or any race, caste, sex or religion, etc. For example, my predisposition towards a particular singer or song shows whether my attitude is positive or negative towards it; my attitude towards a particular political party (say, positive or negative) is a political attitude. Predisposition is the tendency — e.g., I like Arijit Singh’s songs, so my tendency is to listen to them (positive attitude); I do not enjoy a certain actor’s acting, so my predisposition is not to watch that actor’s movies. Likes and dislikes about food (mushroom, paneer, eggs) are likewise attitudes towards those objects.

EXAMPLE

- Attitudinal objects can be: a person, singer, actor, song, ideology, political party, food, or a race/caste/sex/religion.
- Positive attitude → tendency to approach (e.g., listen to a liked singer); negative attitude → tendency to avoid.

5.8.2 Structure of Attitude — the CAB (ABC) Model

Every attitude has three major components. The model is called the CAB (or ABC) model:

Component	Meaning	Illustration
Cognitive	Your belief pattern — whatever you hold to be true; the information you have. This shapes your attitude.	“Trees conserve the environment, stop soil erosion, aid wildlife, give food & fibre” → belief supporting a positive attitude to trees.
Affective	How you FEEL about the attitudinal object — your emotional overtone.	Liking greenery / feeling happy on seeing trees; feeling disgust at a cockroach.
Behavioural	Your behavioural tendency — what you would actually do.	A pessimist tends to run from challenges; a thief tends to run on seeing police; if you can, you plant a tree.

Worked example — attitude towards trees / tree plantation Cognitive (belief): trees conserve the environment, stop soil erosion, support wildlife conservation, and provide food and fibre — so I believe trees are beneficial. Affective (feeling): I like greenery and feel happy seeing trees around me. Behavioural (tendency): if I get the chance, I will plant trees and motivate others to do so. All three components correspond to the same object (trees).

Worked example — racial prejudice (for illustration only) Cognitive: a belief that “whites are intellectually superior.” Affective: feeling hatred/discomfort on seeing a black person. Behavioural: a tendency to discriminate. This combination is what constitutes prejudice — a belief, an emotional overtone, and a discriminatory behavioural tendency towards the object. (Used purely to illustrate the components, not as the teacher’s view.)

KEY CONCEPT

- CAB model: Cognitive (belief) + Affective (feeling/emotion) + Behavioural (behavioural tendency).
- Prejudice = belief + hatred (affect) + discriminatory tendency towards an object.

5.8.3 Components May Not Be in Congruence

The three components are not always in sync. Sometimes one dominates the others:

- Bitter medicine: Cognitive is strong (I believe it will treat me), affective is very negative (it is bitter), yet the behavioural outcome is that I take it — the cognitive component dominates. Generally, when something is very important in our life, the cognitive component usually dominates.
- Cheap impulse purchase: You know it is wasteful (cognitive: “I don’t need it”), but you like it (affective is strong) and it is cheap, so you buy it — the affective component dominates. In consumerism, smoking addiction and drug addiction, the affective component tends to dominate even when we know the harm.
- Congruence: Sometimes all three align — e.g., I believe I should exercise (cognitive), I enjoy

the gym (affective), and I actually go (behavioural).

CRITICAL POINT

- The three components (C, A, B) may or may not be congruent.
- For important matters → cognitive usually dominates (e.g., bitter medicine).
- For consumerism/addictions → affective usually dominates (impulse buys, smoking, drugs).

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Gandhiji's statement (quotation theme): "What you think, you become" — belief pattern shapes attitude, which shapes behaviour and ultimately character.

5.9 Functions of Attitude

"Function" means the utility of something for you — how does an attitude help you in your life? (This functional perspective is familiar from anthropology/sociology.) There are four important functions:

5.9.1 Knowledge Function

Attitude helps us make sense of the outside world without having to evaluate every object again and again. Think of an attitude as a "scheme" or classification — a pair of glasses through which we categorize things.

- Snakes: We know snakes can kill, so our usual attitude towards snakes is cautious/fearful — we keep a distance. Even though 60–70% of snakes are non-venomous, we still keep our distance, because it saves our life; we cannot verify each snake, and it might turn out to be venomous.
- Water: If water looks muddy or smells off, we do not drink it — even if it might be clinically safe — because our attitude is that clean water is odourless and clear. We do not clinically test every glass of water we ever drink; the attitude simplifies life.
- Medicine: We take medicine without evaluating whether it is fake each time, because we have formed the attitude that government-checked medicine is fine.

So the knowledge function reduces cognitive load and simplifies life. Its negative consequence is stereotyping — e.g., assuming all snakes are dangerous, or that all trees are good (whereas some, like the eucalyptus tree, are water-intensive and problematic where water is scarce).

KEY CONCEPT

- Knowledge function: attitude acts as a "lens/scheme" to make sense of the world and reduce cognitive load — no need to re-evaluate every object.
- Negative side: STEREOTYPING (e.g., "all snakes dangerous"; "all trees good" ignoring water-intensive eucalyptus).

5.9.2 Utilitarian / Socially-Adjustive Function

Some attitudes help us adjust to, and be accepted by, our social group, by conforming to expected norms. We adopt certain attitudes to be likeable and socially acceptable within a group (relevant, for instance, to how politicians present themselves to groups and at elections). This is the socially-adjustive (utilitarian) function — the attitude helps you adjust to or be welcomed by the group because you are conforming to expected norms. (This also links to why honesty is easier to sustain — a truthful attitude spares you the tangle of remembering and defending lies later.)

KEY CONCEPT

Socially-adjustive / utilitarian function: attitudes that help you fit in and be accepted by conforming to group norms.

5.9.3 Ego-Defensive Function

Some attitudes are held to protect our own mental health and self-image. Adopting a certain attitude helps us defend ourselves against criticism. For instance, the doctor's measured detachment helps him defend his own mental health; or accepting in advance that "some people will always criticize me, whatever I do" protects one from being wounded by that criticism (even Lord Ram was questioned by people). This is the ego-defensive function.

KEY CONCEPT

Ego-defensive function: attitudes adopted to protect one's own mental health and self-image against criticism.

5.9.4 Value-Expressive Function

Some attitudes we "wear on our sleeve," because they express who we are — our identity and character. Virat Kohli's aggressiveness and Dhoni's calmness are attitudes they carried because these express their identity. Another example: in inter-caste relationships, someone may say "my father will never agree," because the attitude against inter-caste marriage is very important to that parent's identity — they disapprove of it entirely, so the attitude expresses their identity and is very significant to them. Danveer Karna (his commitment to donation) and Bhishma Pitamah (his vow) are cases where value-expressiveness was extremely important.

KEY CONCEPT

Value-expressive function: attitudes that express one's identity/character (e.g., Kohli's aggression, Dhoni's calm; Danveer Karna; Bhishma).

QUICK REVISION

Four functions of attitude: (1) Knowledge (lens; reduces cognitive load; risks stereotyping); (2) Utilitarian/Socially-adjustive (fitting in); (3) Ego-defensive (protects mental health/self-image); (4) Value-expressive (expresses identity).

5.10 Attitude's Influence on Thought & Behaviour

5.10.1 Influence on Thought

There is a cyclical relationship. The cognitive component (belief) goes in as an input into attitude formation. But once an attitude has been formed, it in turn influences all the subsequent thoughts that arise in your mind.

Example: if I have already formed a casteist attitude (from a belief that certain “menial/polluting” jobs should be done by certain castes), then when a social incident occurs and WhatsApp forwards reach me, I will most likely fall prey to confirmation bias. Confirmation bias means I treat as true the information that confirms my existing attitude/bias — “I already knew people of that caste behave this way,” even if the forward is false, because my attitude was already formed.

Another example: if I have a communal attitude and receive information that “that community did something wrong,” I will most likely accept it as true even if it is fake, because my attitude is already set. So attitude shapes our thought process: thoughts (beliefs) form the attitude, and the attitude then shapes further thoughts.

KEY CONCEPT

- Cyclical: belief (cognitive) → attitude formed → attitude then filters/shapes further thoughts.
- Attitude → confirmation bias: we accept information that confirms our existing attitude, even against evidence.

The patriarchy example: if a person holds a patriarchal attitude and a rape incident occurs, he thinks “I already knew — they roam in short clothes, so this happens,” even when there is contradictory evidence (e.g., the victim was fully/traditionally clothed). NCRB data show that most sexual-harassment cases involve people known to the victim — but the biased person will ignore this and see only what fits the attitude. “As is the lens on the eye, so is the vision.”

DATA & FACTS

Per NCRB data, most sexual-harassment cases involve persons known to the victim — evidence a biased attitude tends to ignore.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- Quotation theme: “We don’t see things as they are; we see things as we are.” (We view the object through our own lens/attitude.)
- Related: “Your perception of me is a reflection of you; my reaction to you is an awareness of me.”

5.10.2 Influence on Behaviour

Attitude is only a predisposition/tendency; it may or may not translate into actual behaviour. This line is very important: an attitude may or may not translate into actual behaviour.

- Mismatch example: Many politicians may hold a patriarchal attitude but not display it when meeting people or giving speeches; their public behaviour may keep a full distance from their actual attitude. A bureaucrat may speak against corruption publicly while holding an attitude that is quite positive towards it.

- Everyday example: You may have a positive attitude towards study (you feel like studying) but not actually study — so a positive attitude alone does not let us predict the behaviour.
- Hypocrisy: e.g., a person who plants a tree but also cuts trees; a police officer who beats his wife in private life. Attitude and behaviour need not be congruent.

CRITICAL POINT

- Attitude = tendency/predisposition; it may or may not translate into actual behaviour.
- Hence attitude–behaviour mismatch (e.g., anti-corruption speeches vs. corrupt attitude; positive study attitude but no studying) — and hypocrisy.

Factors determining when attitude predicts behaviour

Factor	How it strengthens the attitude–behaviour link
Strength of attitude	A stronger attitude is more likely to be in alignment with behaviour. E.g., Gandhiji's very strong attitude to non-violence lets us predict he would not support violence; Danveer Karna's strong attitude to donation predicts he would never refuse to donate.
Specificity of attitude	The more specific the attitude, the more strongly it guides behaviour. "I believe in sustainability" is broad; "I have a negative attitude towards plastic straws" is specific and guides behaviour better. "Study 8 hours daily" is more specific (and predictive) than "study a lot".
Accessibility of attitude	Attitudes we think about frequently are more accessible and more likely to guide behaviour (e.g., someone constantly thinking about tree plantation is more likely to plant/motivate others).
Moderating role of external factors	The surrounding environment can change behaviour — e.g., an honest person in a very corrupt office; whether the group is liberal or not. Politicians don't reveal everything publicly because the surrounding factors are not in their favour.
Perceived behavioural control (Theory of Planned Behaviour)	If you feel you can actually carry out the behaviour in the circumstances (control over your own behaviour), you are more likely to act; if not, you stay silent or comply.

Perceived behavioural control — examples An honest person joining a very corrupt office may hold a strong, specific, accessible positive attitude ("I will not take a bribe"), but external factors and perceived control matter: if being honest could get him harmed, his perceived control is low, so he may stay silent, or show indifference to bribery ("take it if you must; I won't"), without openly protesting. Similarly, a girl may hold a strongly negative attitude towards dowry, yet dowry is still given at her marriage, because she perceives little control — protesting might mean even her own parents will not listen. Perceived behavioural control is the extension (of the model) that captures how effectively you feel you can perform the behaviour in the given circumstances.

KEY CONCEPT

- Theory of Planned Behaviour: perceived behavioural control — how effectively you believe you can perform the behaviour in the circumstances — strongly affects whether attitude becomes action.
- Low perceived control (e.g., honest officer in corrupt office; girl vs. dowry) → attitude may not translate into behaviour.

QUICK REVISION

- Attitude → thought: forms attitude, then filters thoughts → confirmation bias (“we see things as we are”).
- Attitude → behaviour: only a tendency; predicts behaviour better when it is **STRONG, SPECIFIC and ACCESSIBLE**, moderated by **EXTERNAL FACTORS** and **PERCEIVED BEHAVIOURAL CONTROL**.

5.11 Cognitive Dissonance

When there is a large difference between what you are actually doing (behaviour) and what your attitude is, there is a sense of guilt and mental discomfort. This mental discomfort arising from misalignment between a strongly-held attitude and actual behaviour is called cognitive dissonance.

For example, we may have a strong attitude that we should study hard, but our actual behaviour is not that of studying — so we should feel guilt/dissonance. If this misalignment is large and the attitude is strongly felt, we experience mental discomfort.

KEY CONCEPT

Cognitive dissonance = mental discomfort/guilt from a large misalignment between a strongly-held attitude and actual behaviour.

Ways to resolve cognitive dissonance

- Change the cognition: Alter what you believe. E.g., not studying despite a strong study-attitude, you add a new cognition — “so-and-so also didn’t study much and still managed; I’ll be fine” — to reduce the guilt.
- Add a new cognition: Introduce an additional belief to reduce discomfort. E.g., “I’ll eat one chocolate despite the diet, but I’ll run an extra kilometre” — adding a cognition so the attitude–behaviour dissonance is neutralised.
- Change the behaviour: Bring behaviour back in line with the attitude (e.g., actually start studying).

EXAMPLE

- Diet vs. chocolate: “I’ll eat one chocolate but run an extra kilometre” — adding a cognition to remove dissonance.
- Study attitude vs. no studying: rationalising (“others managed too”) to reduce guilt.

CRITICAL POINT

Resolving dissonance is important to avoid continuous mental discomfort — done by changing cognition, adding a new cognition, or changing behaviour.

5.12 Formation of Attitude

Attitudes are formed with respect to an attitudinal object, through several mechanisms:

5.12.1 *Classical Conditioning (learning through association)*

We build attitudes by associating something with an experience over time. For example, songs or movies heard/watched while entering a relationship get associated with that positive experience; you later remember those songs/movies, and your attitude towards them stays positive because they are associated with a positive experience. Learning through association is classical conditioning.

KEY CONCEPT

Classical conditioning = learning through association (e.g., songs/movies tied to a positive experience gain a positive attitude).

5.12.2 *Operant Conditioning (reward and punishment)*

Attitudes are inculcated through reward and punishment. A child who works hard and shows discipline is rewarded and encouraged by parents (praise, chocolate); a child who does something wrong is scolded (punishment). A child who steals and is punished forms a negative attitude towards stealing. Similarly, a child who touches fire and gets burnt has a negative experience/association and thereafter fears and avoids fire — an attitude formed from experience/association.

KEY CONCEPT

Operant conditioning = attitude shaped by reward and punishment (e.g., stealing → punishment → negative attitude; touching fire → burn → avoidance).

5.12.3 *Observational Learning, Culture, Media, Family*

We also learn much by observing others (observational learning), as discussed under value inculcation — patriarchy and similar attitudes are learned this way. Culture plays a big role: we are born into a culture (e.g., the Bishnoi community's culture) and absorb its attitudes; a patriarchal society tends to produce patriarchal attitudes. Media plays a very important role, and family — the family we are born into — also contributes to attitude formation, as discussed under the role of value inculcation.

KEY CONCEPT

Other sources: observational learning; culture (e.g., Bishnoi community); media; family — all contribute to attitude formation (as in value inculcation).

5.12.4 Values vs. Attitudes

Values are our likes and preferences and are very broad in nature (e.g., sustainability, justice). Attitudes are specific — towards a particular object. A broad value guides many specific attitudes: the value of sustainability guides a negative attitude towards plastic, a positive attitude towards trees, and a positive attitude towards water conservation. “Justice” is broad; “justice for tribals” or “social justice for one section” is more specific.

Values	Attitudes
Broad in nature; our likes and preferences (e.g., sustainability, justice).	Specific; directed at a particular attitudinal object.
The broadest guiding layer.	The specific expression guided by values (e.g., sustainability → anti-plastic, pro-tree, pro-water-conservation).

5.12.5 Moral, Immoral and Amoral Attitudes

Just as values are of three types (moral, amoral, immoral), attitudes are also of three types:

- Amoral attitude: has no sense of right or wrong — e.g., a positive attitude towards the colour black, or liking an Arijit Singh / Lata Mangeshkar song. No one would call these right or wrong.
- Immoral attitude: e.g., greediness — always thinking about money — is an immoral attitude. Saying “black people are bad people” is a racist (immoral) attitude, unlike merely liking the colour black.
- Moral attitude: what good values lead to. Cultivating good values ultimately leads to moral attitudes; otherwise it leads to immoral attitudes.

KEY CONCEPT

- Attitudes are of three types: moral, immoral, amoral (mirroring values).
- Amoral = no right/wrong sense (liking black colour, a song); immoral = e.g., greed, racism; moral = product of good values.

QUICK REVISION

- Attitude forms via: classical conditioning (association), operant conditioning (reward/punishment), observational learning, culture, media, family.
- Values (broad) guide attitudes (specific).
- Attitudes may be moral, immoral or amoral.

Attitude, Deontology and Utilitarianism

Class Notes L11-12

Attitude • Deontology (Immanuel Kant) • Utilitarianism (Bentham & Mill)

6.1 Attitude (continued)

6.1.1 Cognitive Dissonance

KEY CONCEPT

- Cognitive dissonance is the mental discomfort that results from holding two conflicting beliefs, values or attitudes.
- It arises when what we think and what we do are not in harmony, or when our attitude and our behaviour are not in harmony (incongruence between attitude and behaviour).
- This incongruence produces mental discomfort, which in turn creates problems for the individual.

Cognition simply means a belief. When our behaviour contradicts a belief we hold, dissonance is generated.

EXAMPLE

A person has a strong positive attitude towards smoking, but also holds the belief that smoking causes cancer. The clash between the two produces mental discomfort — this is cognitive dissonance.

Ways to reduce cognitive dissonance

- Change the behaviour: for example, quit smoking so that the behaviour aligns with the belief.
- Change / add to the belief pattern: justify the behaviour by adding a new belief — e.g. “I am allowed to have some cheat meals every once in a while.”
- Justify or deny the conflicting cognition so that the conflict is neutralised.

In every case, dissonance is reduced by changing behaviour, or by changing the conflicting cognition that is in conflict with the behaviour.

QUICK REVISION

- Cognitive dissonance = mental discomfort from two conflicting beliefs / values / attitudes

(attitude–behaviour incongruence).

- Reduced by (a) changing behaviour, or (b) changing / justifying / denying the conflicting cognition.

6.1.2 Political Attitude

KEY CONCEPT

- Attitude is a predisposition to act in a certain way. Predisposition means our tendency to act towards an attitudinal object.
- In political attitude the attitudinal object is fixed as politics — a political party, a leader, an ideology or a policy — and the question is whether our tendency is to support it or to oppose it.
- It is therefore an expression of favour or disfavour towards particular ideologies, political parties, political culture and politicians — essentially everything concerning politics.

Evaluation here means favour or disfavour (e.g. a positive or negative attitude towards a leader). Attitude is a relational term; in political attitude that relation is established with politics.

Factors that shape political attitude

Historical factors

- Historical experiences such as the freedom struggle taught us the importance of sovereignty — that all of us must safeguard it.
- Having lived through colonial subjugation under the British East India Company, if asked today to choose between the comfort of aid from a developed nation and sovereignty, most of us would choose sovereignty. History thus shapes our political attitude towards sovereignty.

Social factors — caste

- Caste-based societies and caste-based political parties mean our attitude is often shaped by our own caste identity. As it is said: “In India, you don’t cast your vote, you vote your caste.”
- Many political parties have emerged from caste-based politics; if a leader belongs to your caste, you are most likely to favour that party.

Gender

- Women may vote for parties that favour women’s agendas or issues.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Example — Nitish Kumar (then Chief Minister of Bihar) promised liquor prohibition (sharab-bandi), addressing the problems of women subjected to domestic violence by alcoholic husbands. This women-centric policy helped form a positive political attitude towards his party.

Family

- People say “we are Congress people” or “we are BJP people.” Generation after generation a

family votes for one party / ideology, so an individual's political attitude tends to remain the same.

Education

- As education increases, a person understands rights better, becomes more liberal, grows more conscious of their rights, and demands them from government — protesting or posting on social media. All of this is an expression of political attitude.

Age

- Young people tend to believe in total revolution and rapid change; older, more mature people favour incremental reforms, understanding that real change on the ground happens slowly. Age therefore shapes the maturity of one's political attitude.

Economic status

- A poor person who benefits from government subsidies favours parties aligned with subsidies and welfare programmes; a rich person may favour parties offering tax breaks and reductions and dislike subsidies.

Media

- Social media and media narratives, through campaigns and advertisements, are used to build a narrative or a positive attitude towards a particular political party.

Circumstances

EXAMPLE

- The rise of Hitler in Germany was significantly shaped by circumstances. His party won more votes during economic uncertainty — after the 1929 Great Depression, Germany faced very high inflation, unemployment and severe economic challenges, and in that context people looked to Hitler to solve their problems.
- In dire circumstances people seek massive change, and charismatic leaders who promise it are able to influence them.

Additional factors (from the PDF): educational institutions, leaders in society, and political groups themselves also play a large role in shaping political attitude. This can appear as an independent question in UPSC.

QUICK REVISION

- Political attitude = favour / disfavour towards parties, ideologies, leaders and policies.
- Shaping factors: historical, caste, gender, family, education, age, economic status, media, circumstances (plus educational institutions, societal leaders, political groups).

6.1.3 Social Influence

KEY CONCEPT

- Social influence is the change in our behaviour or attitude caused by an external / actual factor around us (for instance, “this boy fell into bad company” — his attitude and behaviour changed wrongly because of his company).
- The external pressure may be real or imaginary.
- The influence may be intentional or unintentional.

EXAMPLE

- A celebrity such as Ranveer Singh dressing in a certain way may not himself know how many people he influences — the influence is unintentional. Social-media influencers are similar.
- In the Samay Raina controversy, the concern was that such content may adversely impact children; mature people can process it more maturely, but on children it may have a negative influence.
- A child enters college, sees others smoking, and starts smoking to look ‘cool’ — no one told him to, he was simply influenced by the people around him (a real or imaginary pressure).

Bollywood stars, cricketers, celebrities, social-media influencers and the people immediately around us all influence our behaviour and attitude.

How social influence operates

Informational influence

- Social influence is more operative when it comes from a source of credibility.

EXAMPLE

- During COVID, a reputed doctor held a press conference urging people to stop getting repeated CT scans — too many scans were taking a toll on medical infrastructure, so those who genuinely needed them could not get them. When a credible, professional person speaks, the influence is stronger.
- IPCC reports similarly provide informational influence about the consequences of climate change and global warming (such as sea-level rise).

Situational influence

- The situation a person is in also influences their attitude and behaviour.

Normative influence

- Norms influence us — society expects certain behaviour, e.g. that we respect our elders. When you talk to your parents knowing that everyone is watching, the (normative) influence increases; when onlookers do not know the parents, that normative influence does not operate as strongly.

Factors determining the degree of social influence

- Group size: a larger group exerts more influence.
- Cohesiveness: the more cohesive the group, the greater its influence.
- Importance: if a matter is highly important for one's individual decision (e.g. one's own marriage), the person will not be easily influenced even within a large group.
- Power distance / power equation: if the power distance is very low we are not influenced easily; a very powerful person (e.g. a celebrity, the PM, a DM) has high power distance and can influence us more easily.
- Individual (moral) character: a person of strong moral character is less easily influenced.

CRITICAL POINT

Distinguish undue influence from coercion. "Everyone is doing it, so I did it too" is undue influence — a negative example of social influence.

QUICK REVISION

- Social influence = external factor (real or imaginary; intentional or unintentional) changing attitude / behaviour.
- Operates through: informational, situational and normative influence.
- Degree depends on: group size, cohesiveness, importance, power distance, individual character.

6.1.4 Persuasion**KEY CONCEPT**

- Persuasion involves an intentional communicative act that excludes force and achieves private acceptance.
- It is deliberate and intentional — the purpose is to intentionally change someone's attitude or behaviour.

CRITICAL POINT

Persuasion is a specialised case of social influence: every persuasion is a case of influence, but not every influence is a case of persuasion. In social influence the change need not be intentional (celebrities may or may not intend to influence you); in persuasion we truly and deliberately intend to influence.

Techniques of persuasion

(a) Social proofing Showing what other people are doing in order to influence a person — telling them "you are not alone, many others have done it," so they too should change their attitude or behaviour.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- PM CARES Fund: "people from all walks of life have contributed ... they have given their

heart and money to sharpen the fight against COVID-19”; celebrity names (e.g. Badshah, Guru Randhawa) were added.

- ‘Give it up’ subsidy campaign: telling people that one crore citizens have already given up their subsidy, so they are not alone in doing so.
- Selfie-with-Daughter campaign: people post pictures showing pride in their daughters — signalling that a daughter is a matter of pride, not shame.
- ‘My Waste, My Responsibility’ campaign.

(b) Default rule Humans are by nature status-quoist — we generally do not change things. Making something the default therefore changes attitude and behaviour. This is why every app asks you to ‘make it default.’

DATA & FACTS

Austria treats every individual as an organ donor at the time of death by default; those who do not wish to donate can follow a simple opt-out process. Result: more than 90% of people are registered to donate their organs.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Government uses the auto-debit facility to enrol people in insurance by default (automatically enrolled, can withdraw anytime).
- TDS (Tax Deducted at Source): the employer deducts a set percentage of salary and deposits it with the tax department by default; if the tax liability does not arise, the person files an ITR and claims the amount back. The default is TDS.
- Aadhaar was made the default in many services, which made it easy to change people’s behaviour — they began using Aadhaar everywhere.

(c) Scarcity complex Showing that something is limited (“only a few seats left”) creates a FOMO effect and nudges quick action. Used by organisations and government (limited free seats, fees thereafter); e-commerce sites (Myntra, Flipkart) show “only one / two items left.”

(d) Reciprocity Creating a moral debt — give something first, build trust, and the other person then feels obligated to reciprocate (e.g. by buying your product).

EXAMPLE

- Jio gave free internet initially; people got used to it and later paid.
- On roadways buses, a person applies balm on your forehead unasked, creating a moral debt so you feel you should give something in return.
- Coaching institutes offer free open mock tests — doing something for you first to create obligation.

(e) Attention & clear messaging A very clear, targeted message changes attitude.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- ‘Do boond zindagi ki’ (two drops of life) — the polio vaccine is equated with life itself.
- ‘Give it up, feel the joy of giving’ — giving is equated with joy.
- Namami Gange: the Ganga is addressed as ‘Ma’ (mother) and ‘Namami’ means we bow to her — so how can we pollute her? The name itself carries the message (as do names like Mudra Yojana).

(f) Messenger liking Using a liked celebrity or brand ambassador so that people respond to the messenger more than the message.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- The Election Commission of India appoints cricketers as brand ambassadors during elections; MS Dhoni appeals to Jharkhand, Ganguly to Bengal, Sachin Tendulkar broadly. ‘Pehle matdaan, phir jalpaan’ (first vote, then refreshments) links voting to responsibility.
- People buy Patanjali products because they like Baba Ramdev. Kailash Satyarthi is used for child-welfare messaging because he evokes respect.
- Swachh Bharat Mission engaged many celebrities — a classic case of persuasion and attitudinal change.

(g) Public commitment Making people publicly commit to something (e.g. at an anti-addiction rally). A public commitment creates guilt if not followed, because people wish to protect their self-image, credibility and trustworthiness.

EXAMPLE

‘Mirror, mirror on the wall’ — mirrors installed at spots where people urinate in public in Bengaluru, to instil public shame and deter the behaviour.

CRITICAL POINT

Persuasion can be misused and slip into manipulation (e.g. misleading coaching advertisements). Avoiding manipulation is an important ethical concern.

QUICK REVISION

- Persuasion = deliberate, intentional attitude / behaviour change without force (a special case of social influence).
- Techniques: social proofing, default rule, scarcity complex, reciprocity, attention & clear messaging, messenger liking, public commitment.

6.1.5 Nudging

Behaviour change lies on a spectrum with two extremes:

- Laissez-faire — the choice is left entirely to the individual (e.g. the ‘Give it up’ campaign leaves the decision to each person).

- **Mandate** — the behaviour is compelled by law.

Between these two extremes lie nudging and incentives.

EXAMPLE

Incentive example: a high tax on tobacco raises its cost and thereby reduces tobacco consumption — behaviour changed through (dis)incentive.

KEY CONCEPT

Nudging is a ‘choice architecture’ that alters people’s behaviour in a predictable way, without changing the choices available and without significantly changing economic incentives. It is a soft push that still respects individual autonomy.

Examples of nudging

- **Metro staircase:** the number of kilocalories burnt is printed on the stairs, placed beside an escalator. Both options remain available; the arrangement nudges you to think “if I take the stairs I’ll burn calories.” No option is removed and there is no mandate.
- **Supermarket shelves:** products the store wants you to buy are placed at eye level, while others require you to bend down. All choices remain available; the arrangement nudges the choice.
- **Selfie-with-Daughter, sugar boards, and food-menus with bigger pictures** are all nudges; government promotion of EVs is a soft push (nudge) too.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Nudging is a likely UPSC question — expect a question on nudging this year or next.

CRITICAL POINT

Nudging is part of persuasion: like persuasion, it intentionally changes people’s attitude — but it does so through choice architecture rather than force or mandate.

QUICK REVISION

- Behaviour-change spectrum: laissez-faire → nudging → incentive → mandate.
- Nudging = choice architecture that predictably alters behaviour without removing choices or significantly changing economic incentives (a soft push).

6.2 Normative Ethics & Deontology (Immanuel Kant)

6.2.1 Normative Ethics — The Ethical Standards

KEY CONCEPT

- Normative ethics deals with prescriptive ethical standards — what we should consider when deciding the right and wrong of a human action (‘norm’ = prescription).

- Different schools prescribe different standards for judging whether an action is ethical.

Approach	An action is right when ...	Focus is on
Deontology	you do your duty / the means are right	Duty & means
Teleology	it leads to good consequences / good ends	Ends / consequences
Virtue ethics	it makes you a virtuous person	Character of the person
Justice	it leads to fairness and justice	Justice / fairness
Rights-based	it upholds someone's rights (e.g. a consumer's rights)	Rights

6.2.2 Case Study — SP Sunil (Applying the Standards)

EXAMPLE

Sunil is a young, dynamic SP officer posted in a district infamous for illegal sand mining. He begins taking action against the sand mafia; the mafia, rattled, threatens him and his family. One option available to Sunil is to seek a transfer. We evaluate this course of action through the different ethical standards.

Standard	Verdict	Reasoning
Deontology	Unethical	Seeking a transfer means he is not doing his duty — he is running away from it.
Teleology	Unethical	Bad consequences dominate: more corruption, more illegal sand mining, a bad precedent, poor leadership, and demoralised subordinates (if a senior SP could do nothing).
Virtue ethics	Unethical	Seeking a transfer makes him behave like a coward; it does not build good character.

CRITICAL POINT

The same action (seeking transfer) is judged wrong from three different bases — deontology, teleology and virtue ethics. Examining an action through multiple standards is how you generate dimension in an ethics answer.

6.2.3 Kant's Deontology — Goodwill

KEY CONCEPT

Immanuel Kant: the only thing that is unconditionally / absolutely good is a goodwill. Everything else is a conditional good — good only depending on how it is used.

Everything else is only a conditional good

- Courage: a thief, a terrorist and a suicide bomber also need courage — so courage is a conditional good, depending on how it is used.
- Love: in the name of love people do terrible things (Dhritarashtra and Gandhari for their son in the Mahabharata; parents willing to pay for leaked exam papers out of love). Love too is a conditional good.
- Physical strength: it can be misused to beat, threaten or intimidate — so it is a conditional good. The same applies to beauty and power.

6.2.4 The Two Features of a Goodwill

Kant holds that every human being is a rational human being (all of us can think logically). A goodwill has two features.

(i) It must be a Free Will

- Free of threat: if a gun is pointed at a person forcing them to steal, they act under threat, not free will.
- Free of uncontrollable natural urges: a person who has not eaten for fifteen days and steals bread is not acting under free will — hunger (like the urge to use the washroom) is a natural urge that cannot be controlled.
- Free of bias / prejudice: if we carry a bias, we are again not operating under free will.

Illustration — the Veil of Ignorance

CRITICAL POINT

- The idea of freedom from bias is explained using the Veil of Ignorance. NOTE: this term was given by John Rawls, not by Immanuel Kant — it is used here in simplified form only to explain Kant's point.
- 'Veil' means a curtain; 'ignorance' means we are ignorant about something. Rawls says that whenever we make a decision we should place a veil of ignorance before our eyes — remaining ignorant of our own identity and interests — so that we can think rationally and freely.

EXAMPLE

- Untouchability: eight people in a caste-based society with no government must decide the rules. Under the veil of ignorance they do not know their own caste. Deciding whether untouchability should exist, everyone rationally concludes it should not — because "I might turn out to be from the untouchable caste." When prejudiced about our own caste, we cannot think freely.

- Women's education: deciding whether women should be allowed to study, and not knowing their own sex under the veil, everyone concludes women should be allowed to study — "because I don't know whether I am male or female."

(ii) Follow the Moral Law for the Respect of the Moral Law

- A goodwill follows the moral law out of respect for the moral law — not because of consequences. Consequences mean either reward or punishment.

EXAMPLE

At 12 a.m. you are driving and reach a red light — no CCTV, no policeman, no other car. If you still stop at the red light, knowing there would be no consequence for crossing it, you are following the traffic law for the respect of the traffic law, not to avoid punishment. This is following a moral law for the respect of the moral law.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- PYQ (last year): "In law you are considered guilty when you violate the rights of others; in ethics you are guilty when you even think of doing so."
- Explanation: if a Dalit person is present and I merely think of a casteist remark without uttering it, I am not guilty under law (no right violated) but I am guilty in ethics — because I am refraining only out of fear of punishment (e.g. the Prevention of Atrocities Act against SC/ST), not out of respect for the moral law. Had I truly respected the law, the thought would not have arisen (just as, respecting our parents, abuse does not come to mind). Kant stresses intentions strongly.

6.2.5 The Moral Law & the Categorical Imperative

KEY CONCEPT

Since acting under outside dictation would violate free will, the moral law is something each individual must generate on their own. As per Kant, the moral law is given to individuals by themselves — the decision of right and wrong is made by the individual by thinking in a free, rational and logical way.

(a) It must become a Universal Law (Universalisability)

- Because every individual thinks freely and logically without prejudice, everyone arrives at the same law — there is no difference between what I think and what you think. Hence the moral law a person gives themselves should be able to become a universal law.
- Kant's formula: "Act in such a way that you could will that the maxim of your act become a universal law." ('Maxim' = as if everyone acted as you do.)

CRITICAL POINT

- The test of universality exposes the rationality of an argument — whether we are being selfish, prejudiced or narrow.

- Sunil seeking a transfer cannot become a universal law: it is not rational to hold that every officer should seek a transfer whenever threatened (if every officer, doctor or engineer ran away, who would run the country?). So the action is biased, not rational.

Further tests of universality

EXAMPLE

- Encounter 'justice': In a Gurugram case, a child was found murdered in a school and allegations fell on the bus driver; police held a conference and the media built an atmosphere against him. Later it emerged that another school-going child had committed the act. Had a fake encounter been carried out on the driver, justice would never have been served — so 'encounter' cannot become a universal law.
- Instant justice: In a crowded metro a girl beside you screams that she was inappropriately touched (perhaps due to a jerk). If bystanders also believe in instant justice, they start beating you without any enquiry. You would then demand a fair trial — and if you want a fair trial for yourself, you must want it for an accused too. Universality exposes this inconsistency.
- 'Encounter after thorough investigation': an officer who performs 49 encounters in six months and becomes a media celebrity cannot deliver the '50th' once investigation shows the accused is not guilty — conditionality means the rule cannot become universal, and the negative consequences are very high.

CRITICAL POINT

'An under-the-table bribe is ethical because it speeds up decision-making, like grease in the system' — the test of universality shows this is neither logical nor rational, so it cannot be a universal law. An illegal act cannot even be considered for universalisation.

(b) Humanity as an End, Never Merely as a Means

KEY CONCEPT

- "Act in such a way that you treat humanity never merely as a means but always as an end in itself." Because every person is a rational being, we must never use anyone merely as a means; we must treat them as an end — respecting their dignity. 'Merely' means 'only.'
- 'Merely' vs respect: if students paid for a course only to get marks and saw the teacher merely as a means to earn marks, that would be 'merely as a means.' But where there is mutual respect — the teacher respecting the student and the student the teacher as human beings — it is not 'merely.'
- 'Whether in your own person or in the person of another': we must not treat even ourselves merely as a means. An aspirant who, after several failed attempts, feels life has no value beyond clearing the exam and dies by suicide is treating their own person merely as a means — as if life has no other value.

EXAMPLE

- Cadre-management marriage — two scenarios. Scenario 1: a man dissatisfied with his cadre talks love to a girl with the sole purpose of marrying to change his cadre — using her merely as a means (the chief intention is exploitation). Scenario 2: two officers of different services genuinely fall in love and then marry and change cadre — done out of love, not merely as a means. Marriage should happen out of love.
- The ‘white man’s burden’ to ‘civilise’ colonies treated colonised peoples as not rational enough, and ultimately used them merely as a means. Racism and slavery followed the claim “we are intellectually superior and should decide for the blacks.”
- A fake cardiologist ‘treating’ a patient with no intention or skill to cure, only to earn money, uses the patient merely as a means — unlike a genuine cardiologist who treats and charges a fee.

DATA & FACTS

- In manual scavenging there is roughly 97% Dalit representation, because Dalits are treated merely as a means and not as ends in themselves.
- A non-profit organisation in Jaipur district, Rajasthan, allegedly sold over 1,500 girls and women from one river section into marriages over eight years — using human beings merely as a means.
- Other examples of ‘merely as a means’: misleading advertisements / wrong information, bonded labour (not paying workers fully), human trafficking, the illegal sale of organs, brainwashing / terrorism (arming children who cannot consent), using voters only for votes (bribing voters), marriage for dowry, fake relationships, fake ingredients (fake paneer, fake medicine).

(c) Legislator and Legislated (Reciprocity)**KEY CONCEPT**

“Always act in such a way that you are both a legislator and legislated.” When you make a law, you must not merely want everyone else to follow it — you must follow the same law yourself. This is the requirement of reciprocity, and it is what fairness demands.

EXAMPLE

Reservation: I make the law that reservation should exist because there is inequality in society (as a legislator). But if I am born into a higher caste and then say reservation should not exist because it harms me, I have failed to be both legislator and legislated. Fairness demands I also follow the law I make for others.

In such a society, human beings are seen as ends whose dignity is respected — Kant’s idea of a ‘Kingdom of Ends.’

6.2.6 *Categorical Imperative, Merits & Demerits of Kant*

KEY CONCEPT

- The moral law must be self-given, universal, and absolute (unconditional). Kant is deadly against conditional laws.
- Conditional test — ‘Lying is right if you have to save your friend’s life’: imagine a society where everyone believes this. If Suresh and Ramesh are friends and I am chasing Suresh to kill him, Ramesh’s lie about where Suresh went will not work on me — I already know he is lying to save his friend. For a lie to work, the precondition is that I assume he speaks the truth; but here the universal law is lying, so the law is irrational and can never work.
- Hence such a law must be a categorical imperative — universal and absolute — not a hypothetical (conditional) imperative. ‘Imperative’ means ‘we ought to do this.’

Merits of Kant

- Respect for human dignity.
- Emphasis on universality and rationality (promotes fact-based, logical decision-making).
- Avoids the slippery slope. A slippery slope begins when a universal rule is first broken conditionally — e.g. “I will study 10 hours daily,” then take a break ‘just today,’ then keep slipping; or a PDS officer who breaks the rule for a poor woman without documents and then keeps breaking it (eventually for himself). Because Kant’s law has no conditionality, there is no slippery slope.
- Emphasis on objectivity, rationality and integrity.

Demerits of Kant

- People are judged not only on principles but also on consequences. When the President of India’s car was being taken to hospital in Kanpur and a traffic policeman stopped it citing rules, saying “I was only following the categorical imperative” is not enough — one is also responsible for the consequences.
- Rigidity can lead to inflexible moral rules.
- There may be a conflict of duties (e.g. RTI Act versus the Official Secrets Act).
- Kant ignores the diversity of rational opinion — he assumed everyone reaches the same conclusion, but rational people can genuinely differ.

QUICK REVISION

- Goodwill = the free and rational choice to act according to the moral law, out of respect for that law, not for personal desire, emotion, reward or consequence.
- Categorical imperative: (i) act on a maxim that can become a universal law; (ii) treat humanity never merely as a means but as an end; (iii) act as both legislator and legislated. The moral law is self-given, universal and absolute.
- Merits: dignity, universality / rationality, avoids slippery slope, objectivity & integrity. Demerits: ignores consequences, rigidity, conflict of duties, ignores diversity of rational opinion.

6.3 Teleological Ethics: Utilitarianism

6.3.1 Utilitarianism — The Core Idea

KEY CONCEPT

- In deontology an action is ethical if we do our duty / the means are right; in teleology an action is ethical if the consequences / ends are right.
- Utilitarianism is a school of thought under teleology. ‘Utility’ means usefulness — the benefit derived as compared to the cost.

6.3.2 Jeremy Bentham — Quantitative Utilitarianism

KEY CONCEPT

- “Nature has placed mankind under the governance of two sovereign masters (pleasure and pain).” Every human being experiences pleasure and pain.
- “An action is moral, or has utility, if it maximises pleasure and minimises pain.”

Hedonic Calculus

- To measure pleasure as well as pain, Bentham gave the Hedonic Calculus. It consists of various parameters — duration, intensity, certainty, purity, etc. Other things being equal, a longer duration, higher intensity, greater certainty and greater purity mean more pleasure, and so a more ethical action.

CRITICAL POINT

Based on this calculus, pleasure and pain can be quantified. According to Bentham there is NO qualitative difference between different kinds of pleasure — e.g. intellectual pleasures are the same as spiritual pleasures; only quantity matters (“all intoxication is the same intoxication”).

The four sanctions According to Bentham our actions are regulated by four sanctions (a sanction being a source of pain).

Sanction	Underlying fear	Note
Natural	Fear of death	Self-preservation
Political	Fear of punishment	Fear of the law
Social	Fear of boycott	e.g. the incest taboo — relationships society does not accept
Religious	Fear of God	—

KEY CONCEPT

It is because of these sanctions (pain) that an individual looks beyond his personal pleasures and acts for the happiness of all.

6.3.3 John Stuart Mill — Qualitative Utilitarianism

KEY CONCEPT

- Certain pleasures are qualitatively superior to others — intellectual and spiritual pleasures are superior to bodily / sensual pleasures.
- A human being has an inherent sense of dignity with which to test the quality of a pleasure.

CRITICAL POINT

Key line: “It is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied.” A person would rather remain dissatisfied (e.g. not qualify by unfair means) than behave like a pig and get satisfied. A rapist, or an alcoholic lost in bodily pleasure while neglecting family and duty, behaves like a pig — lacking the inherent sense of dignity that would reveal how the act violates human dignity.

CRITICAL POINT

Mill added a fifth sanction to Bentham’s four — CONSCIENCE. A person avoids wrong actions because their conscience knows what they did (guilt), regardless of belief in God or society. Conscience thus becomes a source of pain that should guide us. (Related ideas: the marshmallow experiment and delayed gratification — choosing a higher-order pleasure such as clearing the exam over a lower-order pleasure such as a party.)

6.3.4 Act Utilitarianism vs Rule Utilitarianism

Aspect	Act Utilitarianism (Bentham)	Rule Utilitarianism (Mill)
What is judged	The rightness of an action is judged by the consequences of the action itself.	We follow rules that generally maximise happiness.
Method	Every action is evaluated individually, each time.	Rather than evaluate each action, follow a good general rule.
Result	Can be unstable — e.g. a Robin Hood recalculating every act of looting and distributing.	Provides a more practical and stable ethical guide.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Liberty example: unrestrained (absolute) liberty for all leads to chaos — ‘matsya nyaya’ (the big fish eats the small fish) and autocracy — so overall liberty falls. Liberty with reasonable restrictions maximises overall liberty and yields the greatest good to the greatest number. Article 19 (freedom of expression with reasonable restrictions) is chosen precisely because its consequences are better — a rule-utilitarian choice.

CRITICAL POINT

Rule utilitarianism vs deontology: both follow rules, but for different reasons. In deontology we follow the moral law for the respect of the moral law (not for consequences); in rule utilitarianism we follow the rule because it leads to greater utility — the greatest good to the greatest number.

6.3.5 Utilitarianism in Governance**KEY CONCEPT**

Every governance action carries both merits and demerits; the aim is to maximise net utility — maximise merit / pleasure and minimise demerit / pain — to serve the greatest good to the greatest number.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Lockdown: merit — saving lives; demerit — impact on GDP growth, employment and industry.
- Dam / development projects: merit — power generation, irrigation, employment, GDP growth; demerit — ecological damage and displacement. The Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) prioritises merit over demerit — an application of utilitarianism.
- AFSPA: demerit — curtails liberty; merit — saving lives and maintaining law and order.

6.3.6 Merits & Demerits of Utilitarianism**Merits**

- Result-oriented — ultimately results matter, which keeps ethics relevant.
- Practical and action-oriented.
- Flexible — rules can change with consequences (unlike Kant's rigidity).
- A moral form of democracy — like democracy, it seeks the greater good of the greater number ('morality in the form of democracy').
- Avoids conflicting rules. For RTI vs the Official Secrets Act: the RTI Act provides that where there is a conflict, information may be disclosed even if protected under the OSA, provided it serves the public interest — i.e. the greatest good to the greatest number.

Demerits

- May lead to majoritarianism and the violation of the human rights of minorities — 'greatest good' can be used as a euphemism / shield to justify oppression.

EXAMPLE

- Nazi Germany justified killing Jews 'for the rebirth and greatest good of Germany' — 'greatest good' used as a euphemism to violate the rights of a minority.
- Social injustice: development projects that displace tribals are justified by utilitarianism, but the costs fall disproportionately on the tribals — violating their rights.
- May promote a slippery slope because of its conditionality (rules keep changing, e.g. lock-

downs).

- Difficulty in measuring happiness — how, and whose, happiness is measured? (A tribal may be happiest remaining in the forest.)

QUICK REVISION

- Utilitarianism (teleology): an action is ethical if it maximises net utility — the greatest good to the greatest number.
- Bentham (quantitative): two sovereign masters (pleasure & pain), hedonic calculus, no qualitative difference, four sanctions. Mill (qualitative): higher vs lower pleasures, dignity, 'better a human dissatisfied than a pig satisfied,' fifth sanction = conscience.
- Act utilitarianism (Bentham) judges each action; rule utilitarianism (Mill) follows happiness-maximising rules. Merits: relevant, practical, flexible, democratic, avoids conflict. Demerits: majoritarianism, social injustice, slippery slope, hard to measure happiness.

Ethical Egoism, Virtue Ethics, Weber & Rawls

7.1 Ethical Egoism

KEY CONCEPT

- Ethical egoism is a teleological approach (consequence-based) — not deontological, because it uses an ‘if...’ condition: an action is considered ethical if it maximises one’s self-interest.
- Unlike utilitarianism (greatest good to the greatest number), ethical egoism focuses purely on the individual: an action is ethical if it maximises self-interest.
- Core claim: if we maximise individual interest, we will automatically maximise societal interest — ‘you are fine, the world is fine.’ Society is a collection of individuals; if every individual’s health, education and liberty are cared for, collectively society benefits.

Why ethical egoism becomes relevant

- Utilitarianism’s pursuit of the greatest good to the greatest number can lead to the exploitation of minorities — individuals may be sacrificed for collective benefit.
- In that context, ethical egoism provides a counter-argument: instead of always looking at the collective, focus on each individual’s rights and wellbeing first.

EXAMPLE

- The narrative that women should only fulfil social roles (mother, wife, daughter) neglects the woman as an individual entity. Ethical egoism would insist: focus on her mental health, her own wellbeing — because when she is fine, her family is fine.
- A citizen refuses to give up land for a road project because it is not in her individual interest. This is a self-interest argument. Countering it requires showing the greater good.

Demerit of ethical egoism

CRITICAL POINT

- Best for the individual may not necessarily be best for society. Ethical egoism can make people selfish — ‘I will not give up land for the road because it doesn’t benefit me,’ even if the road benefits thousands.
- UPSC angle: the question tag ‘best for individual may not be best for society’ directly captures this limitation.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

‘The good of an individual is contained in the good of all’ — this quote promotes utilitarianism (public interest ultimately benefits the individual too). It can be balanced by noting that overemphasis on collective interest leads to individual exploitation, so individual rights and ethical egoism also have a place.

QUICK REVISION

Ethical egoism (teleological) = an action is ethical if it maximises self-interest. Used to counter utilitarianism’s tendency to sacrifice minorities. Demerit: best for individual $\neq$ best for society; can promote selfishness.

7.2 Virtue Ethics**KEY CONCEPT**

- While deontology focuses on means (duty) and teleology focuses on consequences (ends), virtue ethics focuses on the character of the person.
- Central question: ‘What sort of person will I become if I do this action?’
- Virtue = positive characteristic traits (e.g. honesty, loyalty, discipline). Vice = negative characteristic traits (e.g. deception, dishonesty, laziness).

The Four Cardinal Virtues (Socrates, Plato, Aristotle)

All major Greek thinkers agreed that four cardinal (primary/essential) virtues must be present in every person’s character:

Virtue	Meaning	Examples
Prudence	Ability to make sound judgment — knowing how to balance multiple obligations and find the best middle path.	A PDS officer who neither blindly refuses the old lady (legal but unethical) nor simply gives away government ration from personal salary (ethical but ineffective), but finds a sound institutional solution. Case study answers test prudence.
Fortitude	Showing courage in the face of adversity.	Soldiers sacrificing their lives; COVID warriors; ASI Tukaram Ombale pressing Kasab's AK-47 against himself during 26/11; firefighters entering burning buildings.
Temperance	Self-restraint — regulating emotions and desires.	Not drinking excessively; controlling anger; not posting abusive comments even when provoked (you may feel them, but you do not express them).
Justice	Giving everyone their due (discussed in depth in the John Rawls section below).	Fair distribution of rewards and punishments as per nature of the act.

CRITICAL POINT

Governance relevance of prudence: in government, you face obligations from farmers, tribals, industrialists and naxalites simultaneously — sound judgment to balance all of them is prudence. Budget-making, policy decisions, land acquisition — all demand prudence.

QUICK REVISION

4 Cardinal Virtues: Prudence (sound judgment), Fortitude (courage in adversity), Temperance (self-restraint on emotions/desires), Justice (giving everyone their due).

7.3 Virtue Ethics: Socrates

KEY CONCEPT

- Only thing that is good is knowledge; only thing that is bad is ignorance.
- Exploitations in society are possible because people are ignorant. When we are knowledgeable, we question wrong assumptions and stop committing bad things.

EXAMPLE

- Sati pratha was followed generation after generation because of ignorance — people mistak-

only believed the Vedas sanctioned it. When Raja Ram Mohan Roy asked ‘show me where it is written in the Vedas,’ he dispelled that ignorance.

- Racial prejudice (‘white people are intellectually superior’), caste prejudice, religious hatred — all stem from ignorance, not from reason or knowledge.

Dialectic Method (Socratic Method)

KEY CONCEPT

- The dialectic method is a form of argumentative dialogue between individuals based on asking questions and answering them to stimulate critical and rational thinking.
- Structure: Thesis → Antithesis → Synthesis. By questioning a thesis, an antithesis emerges; through dialogue the two are resolved into a superior synthesis.

EXAMPLE

- Thesis: ‘We should pursue high GDP growth.’ Antithesis: ‘We should conserve the environment.’ Synthesis: ‘Development should be sustainable — every project should undergo Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA).’
- Thesis: Sustainable development. Antithesis: ‘But what about equitable distribution of gains?’ Synthesis: Development should be both sustainable and inclusive.
- Scientific knowledge publication: a researcher’s claim must pass peer review (antithesis / questioning) before it is accepted into the body of knowledge. Similarly PhD theses are defended against opposition.
- Cancer cure example: no one would accept a claimed injection without government clinical-trial approval — the antithesis (questioning) ensures only validated knowledge is accepted.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

‘Thinking is like a game; it does not begin until there is an opposition.’ Meaning: thinking reaches its full potential only when there is opposition/questioning, because opposition forces us to refine our arguments, exit confirmation bias, and exit our prejudices.

Unexamined Life is Not Worth Living

KEY CONCEPT

- The central tenet of Socrates: all of us should examine our lives.
- People lost in mindless consumerism, gambling, addiction or routine without self-reflection are simply existing like animals — slaves to their own prejudices and ignorance.
- By examining our thought process and behaviour, we challenge and refine ourselves and evolve, realising our true potential.

EXAMPLE

- Prince Siddhartha examined his life → became Gautam Buddha. Narendra examined his life → became Swami Vivekananda. Ashoka examined his life after Kalinga → became Ashoka the Great. Mohandas Gandhi examined his South Africa train experience → became Mahatma Gandhi.
- UPSC aspirants: examining your attempt, your answers and your routine is what separates a topper from a perpetual aspirant. Without examining your answer you do not improve. Unexamined preparation is also not worth giving.
- Application to governance: governments, private organisations, and teachers must also examine their actions. Profit should not come at the cost of the environment or consumers.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- RTI Act: promotes examination of government facts and decisions.
- Social audit: community examines government schemes on the ground.
- Citizen's participation / public consultation: government sends bills to citizens for input, recognising it does not have all knowledge.
- Parliament's question hour, CAG audits, JPC inquiries: all are institutional expressions of the dialectic — questioning to arrive at better knowledge.
- Limited knowledge and need for domain expertise: even a civil servant should know she does not know everything and must rely on specialists (philosopher king concept — see Plato).

Other key Socratic learnings

- **'I know that I know nothing'**: the more genuinely knowledgeable you are, the more you realise the limitations of your knowledge. This humility is what drives continued learning.
- **True happiness (eudaimonia)**: does not lie in wealth, power or sensory pleasure. True happiness comes when you become a virtuous, knowledgeable soul and realise your potential ('eudaimonia').
- **Knowledge is virtue**: knowledge and virtue are equated. A knowledgeable person becomes a virtuous person. Knowledge is dynamic and ever-evolving through the dialectic.

QUICK REVISION

Socrates: only good = knowledge; only bad = ignorance. Dialectic method: thesis → antithesis → synthesis (argumentative dialogue refines knowledge). Unexamined life is not worth living. True happiness (eudaimonia) = becoming virtuous and knowledgeable.
 PYQ: 'Thinking is like a game; it does not begin until there is an opposition.'

7.4 Virtue Ethics: Plato

Plato was a student of Socrates. He broadly upheld the same values — dispel ignorance, become knowledgeable, exercise rationality — and added three key concepts.

1. Allegory of the Cave

KEY CONCEPT

- People are chained in a cave, unable to look backward. They can only look at a wall on which shadows of objects are projected (by a fire burning behind them). They mistake the shadows for reality and give their own interpretations to them.
- When one person breaks free and sees the actual objects, he realises the others were watching mere shadows, not real things.
- Meaning: when we are ignorant and do not employ reason, we contemplate things that are not even real — we live in fear, prejudice and delusion.

EXAMPLE

- Eco-chamber effect: people already living in a prejudice readily accept fake news confirming that prejudice because they do not employ reason.
- Fake news about a community spreads because the receiver is already biased against that community and does not question the information.
- Living in fear of a 'majority under threat' narrative even when it is statistically unfounded — this is mistaking shadows for reality.

2. Tripartite Soul (Allegory of the Chariot)

KEY CONCEPT

- The soul consists of three parts: Reason, Spirit (emotions), and Appetite (desires).
- Plato uses the allegory of the chariot: the charioteer represents Reason; the two horses represent Spirit and Appetite.
- A virtuous individual is one whose charioteer (Reason) is able to control and guide the horses (emotions and desires) towards the right path.
- Emotions (Spirit): if uncontrolled, they lead to road rage, honour killing, mob lynching.
- Desires (Appetite): if uncontrolled, they lead to rape, consumerism, alcoholism.
- Reason as charioteer: tells you 'don't drink excessively,' 'don't give in to road rage,' 'focus on preparation now, party later.' Emotional intelligence (EQ) is the same concept.

EXAMPLE

- Charity (controlling both horses): giving to the poor is Reason directing both the emotional impulse and the desire for recognition — the act is virtuous only if Reason, not impulse, drives it.
- Alcoholic neglecting family: entirely driven by desire (appetite), Reason has lost control of the horses.

3. *Philosopher King*

KEY CONCEPT

- The ideal state is ruled by a Philosopher King — a person who pursues knowledge, is virtuous and has wisdom.
- Contemporary relevance: our bureaucrats, politicians and administrators should also be knowledgeable and wise, not merely procedural.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Lateral entry into civil services: the argument for it rests on the need for domain expertise — a bureaucrat needs specialist knowledge in their field, not just generalist administration.
- Problem when civil servants lack domain expertise: they cannot make sound decisions in technical areas (health policy, environment, finance).
- IRDAI, SEBI, TRAI etc.: regulatory bodies need experts who understand the sector they regulate — philosophical basis = philosopher king concept.

QUICK REVISION

Plato's three concepts: (1) Allegory of the Cave — ignorance → delusion; knowledge → reality. (2) Tripartite Soul: Reason should control Spirit (emotions) and Appetite (desires). (3) Philosopher King — rulers should be knowledgeable and wise.

7.5 Virtue Ethics: Aristotle & the Golden Mean

Aristotle was a student of Plato. He also supported rationality, critical thinking and knowledge. His original contribution to virtue ethics is the concept of the Golden Mean.

KEY CONCEPT

Golden Mean: virtue is the middle path between two extremes — a deficiency (too little) and an excess (too much). Both extremes are vices; the golden mean between them is the virtue.

Deficiency (Vice)	Golden (Virtue)	Mean	Excess (Vice)
Cowardice (kayarta)	Courage / Fortitude		Recklessness (e.g. a drunk person kissing a cobra)
Lack of love (selfishness)	Love (balanced, sacrificial)		Obsessive love / Moh (e.g. Dhritarashtra & Gandhari enabling Duryodhana)
Laziness / Sloth	Diligence		Workaholism (harms mental health, family, relationships)
Lack of ambition (sloth)	Ambition		Over-ambition / Greed
Idleness / apathy (no respect for elders)	Respect		Idolatry (blind devotion; no questioning — against Socratic virtue)
Passivity	Judicial Restraint		Judicial Activism / Overreach
No subsidy / zero state support	Rationalised subsidies		Irrational freebies / Fiscal profligacy
No rules / anarchy	Pragmatic rule-following		Rules as ends in themselves (red-tapism)
Excessive development (ignoring environment)	Sustainable development		Excessive environmentalism (ignoring poverty)

EXAMPLE

- Recklessness: a person drunk on excessive courage grabs and tries to kiss a cobra — excess of courage becomes recklessness.
- Love gone wrong: parents who buy leaked exam papers 'out of love' for their children; enabling behaviour.
- Idolatry is a vice because it prevents you from questioning the person you idolise, keeping you in ignorance — against Socratic virtue. A religious leader given judgment but whose followers still believe he is being framed — that is idolatry.
- True love is measured by sacrifice: how much you give up for the other person at the cost of your own interest. Parents' love, a teacher's dedication, a doctor's commitment at personal cost — all are measured in sacrifice.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- UPSC expected question: ‘What do you mean by golden mean? Why is it relevant in today’s context?’
- Tribal policy: Tribal Panchsheel — after independence, two extreme approaches existed: assimilation (absorb tribals into mainstream) and museum approach (isolate them). The golden mean is a balanced approach that lets tribals develop on their own terms.
- Judicial restraint is the golden mean between judicial passiveness and judicial hyperactivism (overreach into the executive’s domain).
- Rationalisation of subsidies is the golden mean between zero subsidies and irrational freebies.
- Buddhist ‘middle path’ (Madhyamarg) is another expression of the golden mean.

QUICK REVISION

Aristotle’s golden mean: virtue = middle path between deficiency and excess. Both extremes are vices. Apply in answers wherever a balanced approach is needed (sustainable development, judicial restraint, subsidy rationalisation, courage vs recklessness).

7.6 Max Weber & Bureaucracy**KEY CONCEPT**

- Before modern bureaucracy, authority was based on (a) charisma or (b) tradition — both led to nepotism, favouritism, corruption, and low efficiency.
- Max Weber argued for Legal-Rational Authority: we follow an officer’s orders because law grants that authority — not because of personal charisma or tradition. The same law holds the officer accountable when she misuses authority.

EXAMPLE

A DM’s Section 144, a curfew, a lockdown order — we follow these because law authorises the DM to issue them, not because we personally know or like the DM. If the DM abuses that authority, the same law holds her accountable.

Features of Weberian Bureaucracy

Feature	Meaning & Rationale
Legal-rational authority	Authority derived from law, not personal loyalty. Enables accountability.
Value neutrality	No personal values/preferences in decision-making. Facts-based, objective decisions. (Lady Justice with a blindfold.)
Impersonality	Doesn't matter who the officer is — decisions follow rules uniformly. Ensures uniform service delivery to all citizens.
Hierarchy	SP → DSP → Inspector → Constable. Enables close supervision and accountability. Imagine if the PM had to supervise all 700+ DMs directly — impossible without hierarchy.
Division of labour	Each official specialises in one area, building expertise and efficiency.
Merit-based recruitment	No favouritism, nepotism or spoils system — UPSC / competitive exams.
Career orientation	Bureaucrats are career professionals managing a unit, not its owners.
Written documentation	All decisions recorded in writing — enables audit, accountability and transparency.

CRITICAL POINT

- Value neutrality is different from apathy. It means objective, fact-based decision-making — not emotional detachment that makes you indifferent to human suffering.
- Impersonality ensures that whether DM Piyush or any other DM, citizens get the same quality of service. It is a democratic virtue.
- Written documentation: if I gave a tender to your company and five years later am asked about it, written records prove it was the best bid — they protect officers and ensure accountability.

Criticisms & Demerits of Weberian Bureaucracy

- **Rules may become ends in themselves (red-tapism):** a traffic constable in Kanpur stopped a VVIP convoy strictly following protocol; a sick woman was caught in the traffic and died. Following rules rigidly without regard for consequences.
- **Tribal land acquisition (Odisha):** officers who follow acquisition rules without considering tribal culture and rights — rules becoming ends.
- **Value neutrality → apathy:** a PDS officer tells a starving woman without documents 'I can't

help you' — technically correct, morally indifferent.

- **Value neutrality** → **lack of initiative** / **status quoism**: if I only mechanically implement rules, I will never innovate (e.g. the Amreli crowdfunding road example — why crowdfund when there is no budget? Because of initiative beyond routine rules).
- **Hierarchy** → **top-down approach** → **destroys team building**: strict hierarchy stifles lateral communication and team spirit.
- **Excessive division of labour** → **tunnel** / **segmented vision** → **lack of coordination**: in SBI, going from counter to counter for each sub-task — too many specialised counters create coordination failures.
- **Over-emphasis on regulatory approach; lacks citizen-centric orientation**: regulatory bureaucracy asks only 'did you comply?' It does not ask 'how can I help you develop?'

COMPARISON

Regulatory vs Developmental orientation: IRDA (Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India) = both regulatory (compliance) and developmental (promoting insurance inclusion). A bureaucrat should not just enforce compliance but also facilitate development. Colonial bureaucracy was purely regulatory; modern governance demands a developmental orientation. RBI also promotes financial inclusion (developmental), not just regulates banks.

Environmental Pollution Control Board case study: purely regulatory approach = fine/shut down polluting industry. Developmental approach = help industry comply (e.g. show them how to get green certification, access green finance, charge premium for eco-products). Both enforce the law AND facilitate development.

Is bureaucratic attitude also a democratic attitude?

KEY CONCEPT

- Yes — Weberian bureaucracy, when functioning correctly, embodies democratic values.
- Impersonality → no bias → equality before law.
- Merit-based recruitment → equality of opportunity.
- Hierarchy + accountability → citizens' right to accountable government.
- Legal-rational authority → rule of law.
- Division of labour + specialisation → efficiency → quality service delivery to citizens.

CRITICAL POINT

But also: excessive hierarchy, rigid rules, apathy, lack of initiative, tunnel vision and regulatory-only focus undermine democratic values of responsiveness, flexibility and citizen-centricity.

QUICK REVISION

Max Weber: legal-rational authority, value neutrality (objective decisions), impersonality (uniform service), hierarchy (supervision), division of labour (efficiency), merit recruitment, career orientation, written documentation.

Demerits: red-tapism, apathy (value neutrality taken too far), status quoism, top-down culture, tunnel vision, regulatory-only mindset.

Bureaucratic attitude is broadly democratic (equality, rule of law, accountability, quality service) but demerits undermine that.

7.7 John Rawls: Justice as Fairness

KEY CONCEPT

- Justice is fairness — everyone gets their due, both in reward and in punishment.
- Due means what a person is rightfully entitled to: if you paid for a course, you are due the lectures; if you committed rape you are due punishment; if you committed simple theft you are due a lesser punishment proportionate to the crime.
- Fairness means distributing rewards and punishments as per each person's due — not uniformly, but appropriately.

EXAMPLE

- Three people: one committed murder, one committed rape, one stole bread out of hunger. All three have some punishment due, but the nature of punishment must differ with the nature of the crime. This is fairness.
- Paying for a course creates an entitlement (due) to the lectures. Stopping lectures would be unfair because the person paid for them.

1. Just Institutions

KEY CONCEPT

- We can create a just society by creating just institutions (social, political and economic institutions).
- Just institutions will distribute rewards and punishments fairly, as per each person's due.
- Examples: UPSC (fairly distributes civil service positions based on merit); Judiciary (fairly distributes punishment based on the nature of crime).

2. Veil of Ignorance & Original Position

KEY CONCEPT

- Institutions can act fairly by operating under the veil of ignorance.
- Veil of ignorance = a hypothetical situation where people are unaware of their own status / position in society (called the 'original position').
- By being ignorant of one's circumstances, one can think more objectively and rationally, without bias.

EXAMPLE

- UPSC answer-evaluation: the evaluator does not know the candidate's name or roll number (the first page is replaced by a fictitious number) — she evaluates under a veil of ignorance, enabling fair marking.
- Judiciary: the blindfolded Lady Justice symbolises operating under a veil of ignorance — the judge must not see who the parties are, only the facts.
- If asked which optional subject should get more marks, you would demand equal treatment only when you don't know which optional you chose. If you know, you become biased. That is the veil's purpose.
- Caste system: under the veil of ignorance, no one would vote for untouchability because they might be born into the untouchable caste. Free from that bias, everyone rationally concludes untouchability should not exist.

3. Fair Equality of Opportunity

- It is not enough to merely conduct a merit-based exam (formal equal opportunity). There must also be reasonable opportunity to acquire the skills on which merit is assessed.
- Example: UPSC is open to all, but if weaker sections cannot afford to prepare, formal equality of opportunity is empty. Hence government coaching schemes for SC/ST/OBC and EWS are justified.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Government coaching schemes for weaker sections (Delhi's Jai Bhim Mukhya Mantri Yojana etc.).
- Reservation (positive discrimination): inequality is allowed if it benefits the least fortunate (the 'difference principle').

4. Difference Principle**KEY CONCEPT**

- Inequalities are acceptable in society only when they benefit the least fortunate / most vulnerable.
- Reservation is positive discrimination (an inequality) but is justified because it favours the least fortunate.
- Basic rights and liberties: all citizens should have a similar set of basic rights and liberties.

5. Criticism of Rawls (incl. Amartya Sen's critique)

- Veil of ignorance is idealistic: it is not always possible to be completely ignorant of one's status — people are inherently biased towards themselves.
- Evaluation of fairness is not easy (Amartya Sen): three children, one flute — child A has no toys at all, child B knows how to play the flute, child C made the flute. Who gets it? Each claim is valid; fairness is hard to adjudicate.

- Creating just institutions does not ensure justice on the ground (Sen's *niti* vs *nyaya*): *niti* = institutional rules / policy; *nyaya* = actual justice on the ground. Just because you enact reservation (*niti*) does not mean everyone who deserves it receives it (*nyaya*) — EWS certificate misuse, KPSC paper leaks, delayed judicial decisions are all cases where institutions exist but justice does not reach.

QUICK REVISION

John Rawls: justice = fairness = everyone gets their due (in reward and punishment). Create just institutions (UPSC, judiciary) → they distribute fairly under a veil of ignorance (original position). Fair equality of opportunity + difference principle (inequality OK if it benefits least fortunate). Criticism: veil is idealistic; fairness is hard to evaluate (three-children-one-flute); institutions alone don't guarantee justice on the ground (*niti* vs *nyaya* — Amartya Sen).

7.8 Rights, Natural Rights & Social Contract

1. What is a Right?

KEY CONCEPT

- A right is a justified claim / just entitlement. It is what you are entitled to — it protects your dignity, allows you to experience liberty, grow and experience your individuality.
- Rights protect you against: (a) the tyranny of the state, and (b) the tyranny of powerful individuals in society.
- This is why fundamental rights matter: even if everything else changes, they preserve your dignity.

EXAMPLE

- If a teacher stops lectures mid-course without notice, students have a justified claim (entitlement) because they paid for the lectures — that entitlement is their right.
- A landowner whose land is acquired for a road has a property right — that is why compensation is due. The right justifies the entitlement to compensation despite the state's argument of 'greater good.'

2. Conventional Rights vs Natural Rights

Type	Definition	Examples
Conventional Rights	Created by humans through law, custom or constitution.	Fundamental Rights (Constitution), RTI, RTE, legal rights under statutes.
Natural Rights	Not dependent on laws, customs or beliefs of any culture or government. Belong to you simply by virtue of being born a human being.	Life, Liberty, Property (John Locke). Even where law does not recognise them, they morally belong to you.

CRITICAL POINT

- Why natural rights matter: if we only recognise conventional rights, societies that do not create those rights (e.g. the Taliban not recognising women's liberty) would mean women have no rights at all. Natural rights assert that women deserve liberty regardless of whether the law recognises it.
- John Locke's three natural rights: Life, Liberty and Property. These cannot be taken away by anyone because they are inherent to being human.

3. Social Contract Theory (John Locke)

KEY CONCEPT

- In a pre-political state, every individual has absolute liberty. But absolute liberty leads to chaos: powerful people dominate the weak ('bigger fish eats the smaller fish' — matsya nyaya). Overall liberty actually falls.
- To prevent this, citizens collectively enter a social contract with the state: they willfully surrender some of their rights (freedoms) to the state, giving it authority, in exchange for the state protecting their other rights and maintaining peace.
- The authority citizens give the state is NOT unlimited — it is limited to the purpose for which it was given: protecting rights and ensuring collective welfare.
- This limited authority of the state is called constitutionalism (not the same as implementing the constitution — Emergency in India was constitutional but against constitutionalism, because government overstepped its limited authority).

CRITICAL POINT

The state is the only legitimate authority to use violence (police, military) — because citizens authorised it to do so through the social contract, for the purpose of maintaining peace and protecting rights. Any use of that violence beyond the authorised purpose (e.g. fake encounter) violates the social contract.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Reasonable restrictions on Article 19 (sovereignty, security of state, public health, morality) = all are expressions of the collective good the citizens authorised the state to protect.
- Lockdowns, Section 144, AFSPA = state using surrendered rights for collective peace (legitimate if purpose-bound).
- Article 21, POCSO, forest rights, consumer protection = state fulfilling its obligation to protect natural rights.

EXAMPLE

- Paper leak = violation of social contract (state failed in its duty to ensure fair opportunity).
- Air pollution not addressed = violation (state failed to protect right to life and health).
- Terrorist attack / failure of law and order = violation (state failed to protect life — the very first natural right).
- Fake encounter = violation (state's authority was given to protect, not to kill without due process).
- Emergency in India = constitutional but against constitutionalism (went beyond the limited authority given by citizens).
- Tamil Nadu custodial death case = violation of social contract (state using violence beyond its authorised purpose).

QUICK REVISION

Rights = justified claims / entitlements (protect dignity, liberty, individuality). Conventional = human-made; Natural = inherent in humanity (Locke: Life, Liberty, Property).

Social contract: citizens → willfully surrender some rights to state → state gets limited authority → to protect remaining rights and maintain peace. Authority is NOT unlimited (constitutionalism).

Violations = paper leak, air pollution, fake encounter, custodial death, terrorism, Emergency.

7.9 Ethical Dilemma**KEY CONCEPT**

- An ethical dilemma is a situation involving two moral alternatives (not a simple right-vs-wrong choice) where each alternative has a moral basis and the decision-maker cannot easily choose.
- Dilemma is always between two rights, not between right and wrong. If one option is simply wrong, there is no dilemma.

EXAMPLE

- Sunil SP is threatened by the sand mafia: (a) protect his family by seeking a transfer (moral basis: family responsibility) vs (b) continue his duty (moral basis: duty to society and law). Both have moral basis — that is an ethical dilemma.

- A firefighter: (a) save her own life (moral basis: self-preservation) vs (b) enter the burning building to save others (moral basis: professional duty and compassion).
- Budget making: health vs education vs welfare vs infrastructure — all are legitimate, but money is limited. Choosing involves an ethical dilemma.

Why does ethical dilemma arise in governance?

- **Variety of interest at play:** tribals, industrialists, farmers, women, children — all have legitimate interests that may conflict. DM doing land acquisition faces conflict between industrial development and tribal culture.
- **Diverse set of values in conflict:** Fundamental Rights vs DPSPs, fiscal prudence vs subsidy, transparency vs confidentiality, efficiency vs equity.
- **High level of discretion:** reasonable restrictions, public interest, emergency provisions are not black-and-white. The officer must exercise judgment, which creates dilemma.
- **Multiple legitimate duties:** a scientist discovering a danger in a government project faces: transparency (duty to public) vs confidentiality (duty to employer) vs safety (duty to humanity).

QUICK REVISION

Ethical dilemma = choice between two moral alternatives (both with moral basis). Arises in governance due to: multiple legitimate interests, conflicting values (FRs vs DPSPs), high discretion, multiple duties.

7.10 Conflict of Interest

KEY CONCEPT

- Conflict of interest arises when a person has multiple interests that work against each other — typically a private/personal interest clashing with a public/professional duty.
- It compromises the impartiality and objectivity of decision-making and reduces public trust.

EXAMPLE

- **Actual conflict of interest:** a senior officer oversees a road-construction tender; his brother is one of the bidders. His professional duty = evaluate tenders fairly; personal interest = favour his brother. These conflict.
- **Potential conflict of interest:** a retired Finance Secretary is appointed as CAG (Comptroller & Auditor General). He may later have to audit his own earlier decisions as Finance Secretary. Conflict has not yet occurred but the structural possibility exists.

DATA & FACTS

- Kerala CEO case: the Chief Electoral Officer who conducted elections was later appointed Principal Chief Advisor to the CM of Kerala — potential conflict of interest (the same person who certified the election now advises the beneficiary government).

- West Bengal CEO case: the Chief Electoral Officer was made Chief Secretary of West Bengal after the elections he conducted — same structural concern.
- Finance Secretary becoming CAG of India: potential conflict of interest because she may examine her own earlier decisions.

How to resolve conflict of interest

Resolution Method	Meaning
Disclosure / Declaration	Openly declare the conflict upfront ('my brother is bidding in this tender'). This creates a record and signals intent to be transparent.
Restriction / Recusal	Remove yourself from the specific decision/process where the conflict exists. You can remain in the role but step away from that matter.
Recruiting an independent third party	Have an independent body oversee the process (Supreme Court-monitored investigation; expert committee-based decision making; multi-member UPSC interview panels).
Removal from the process altogether	Completely exit the matter — e.g. recuse from the interview panel entirely when a family member is the interviewee.
Relinquishing private interest	Give up the personal/private interest that creates the conflict — e.g. divest from a company whose policy you will regulate; resign from a board position.

CRITICAL POINT

- Principle: no one should be a judge of their own case (*nemo iudex in causa sua*). Resolving conflict of interest is essential to maintain public faith and trust in institutions.
- Why disclose even if you recuse: disclosure itself builds transparency. If the outcome later looks favourable to your relative despite your recusal, the record shows you declared it and stepped back — protecting your integrity.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Multi-member UPSC interview board: no single person can unilaterally favour a candidate; collective oversight reduces conflict of interest.
- SC-monitored CBI investigations: removes potential bias when the investigating agency itself may have a conflict (e.g. the government is both the employer of CBI and the subject of investigation).
- Cooling-off period for retired officers before joining private-sector companies (revolving-door problem): prevents potential conflict of interest from prior regulatory decisions.

QUICK REVISION

Conflict of interest = personal interest vs professional duty, making impartial decision-making difficult. Types: actual (current) vs potential (structural, future).

Resolutions: disclosure, recusal, independent third party, removal from process, relinquishing private interest.

Principle: no one should judge their own case. Goal: maintain public trust and institutional credibility.

Institutions, Law, Conscience, Corporate Governance & Ethics in IR

8.1 Ethical Concerns & Dilemmas in Public and Private Institutions

8.1.1 Foundational Backdrop — The Social Contract

Before discussing institutions, recall the idea that binds the citizen to the state and limits its power.

KEY CONCEPT

- Social contract: citizens implicitly agree to submit to a powerful authority (the state) which, in return, protects them and secures a peaceful society.
- Constitutionalism: this authority is deliberately kept a limited authority — the state is powerful but bound, so it cannot use its power for personal ends. Limited authority is the essence of constitutionalism.

8.1.2 Public Administration vs Private Administration

The core distinction lies in their ultimate objective. Everything else — accountability, decision-making, dilemmas — flows from this.

KEY CONCEPT

- Public administration ultimately exists to serve the public interest. Whether it earns a profit or not, it must serve the public interest.
- Private institutions exist for profit-making. Profit is a central parameter in their decision-making. Making a private company profitable is itself an ethical obligation — the employee is paid a salary out of that profit.

UPSC Case Study — Manager of a Hospital during COVID-19. A UPSC case study in two parts, first as a public hospital, then as a private hospital.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- Setting: You are the manager of a hospital during COVID-19. COVID-19 is a highly infectious disease; resources are limited and human resources (doctors, nurses, staff) are limited and unlimited doctors do not exist. Staff can catch the infection and even lose their lives; once a COVID case appears, that part of the apparatus must be sealed, causing loss to the whole hospital.

- Part 1 (public hospital): Knowing fully well that resources are limited and the disease can threaten your staff, what criteria and justification would you give for treating COVID-19 patients — why put your people in harm's way?
- Part 2 (private hospital): If you were the manager of a private hospital instead, how would your criteria and justification change?

EXAMPLE

Answer direction

- Public hospital: the overriding justification is that you must uphold the public interest — a public institution cannot refuse the sick.
- Private hospital: merely treating patients is not sufficient. Survival of the institution also matters, because keeping a private hospital profitable is an ethical obligation and you must strive for profit.
- A government can print more money, borrow more money and has sovereignty; a private institution's survival rests on its own resources. Hence the reasoning legitimately differs between the two.

UPSC Case Study — *Faster Vaccine Development in a Private Firm.*

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- Setting: You work in a private drug/vaccine firm. Developing the vaccine faster gives a first-mover advantage; the matter is to be reported to the public authority.
- Key ethical principle: Ethics does not mean inaction, and it does not mean placing obstacles (“rode atkana”) in the path of legitimate work.

CRITICAL POINT

- A good answer must actively suggest how the vaccine can be developed faster and correctly — not merely warn against wrongdoing.
- You should reject wrong research and negative consequences, but you must also propose how the right work can be done, because contributing to the organisation is your ethical obligation. Inaction lets people suffer.
- Ethics = solution-oriented + effective. The ideal answer shows you are ethical, effective, a problem-solver, and loyal to the private company — all while remaining ethical and legal.

Dimension	Public Administration	Private Administration
Objective	Serve the public interest (wide, diverse: farmers, drivers, etc.)	Give the company profit; make profit
Accountability	Elaborate — citizens, media, NGOs, judiciary; sense of accountability much higher	Narrow set — shareholders; rights, share; employees
Ability to differentiate	Cannot differentiate between those who can pay and cannot pay; liable to all	Serves consumers; not really liable to pay
Political context	Operates in a political context; must weigh politically sensitive decisions	Largely free to make decisions taking into account
Decision-making speed	Slower — many rules & regulations to follow	Faster — company rules apply; more flexible
Salary / autonomy	Same salary for all (e.g. IAS); government cannot make distinctions	Decides salary based on performance; latitude/autonomy
Ethical dilemmas	More — dealing with multiple, competing interests	Fewer — relationship with shareholders and interests

EXAMPLE

- Bringing private stars into public administration: big names from the private sector, used to quick decision-making, often fail in public administration, where every decision must be checked for political sensitivity.
- Laptop procurement: a student wanted to procure laptops for a government office during an Amazon Diwali sale (cheaper), but could not — a tender and full process were mandatory. Spending public money triggers heavy accountability mechanisms, whereas a private institution would simply buy from Amazon at once.

Applied Question — Changing Nature of Institutions & of Dilemmas.**PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**

Applied (not yet asked, anticipated): How will the changing nature of public and private institutions change the nature of ethical dilemmas and ethical concerns?

Nature of dilemma

- Private institution: profit is always a central angle — e.g. heavy environmental-regulation compliance lowers profit, so the firm must balance sustainability of profit against workers'

safety and wages. The dilemma is tied largely to profit.

- Public institution: the dilemma is far wider, because public interest itself is wide — tribal welfare, development, equity, efficiency, accountability, justice, DPSP, fundamental rights — obligations that constantly come into conflict.

Nature of ethical concern

- Public administration → red-tapism. Because of heavy rules and regulations, decision-making is slow, raising the chance of red-tapism (*laal feeta shaahi*, “red tape”). Max Weber’s stress on written rules and regulations slows decisions further.
- Private administration → discrimination. Because of high autonomy, the concern shifts to discrimination — e.g. the glass ceiling: an employer can pay a woman less and a man more and simply claim a “merit” difference. High autonomy enables gender discrimination.
- In public administration the “glass ceiling” is generally not heard of, because pay is governed by law — a woman IAS and a man IAS are paid equally.

8.1.3 Changing Values under Globalisation

The neat split (public interest = public bodies; profit = private bodies) is blurring in both directions.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Private firms adopting public interest: CSR is now mandatory for eligible companies, so private companies are adopting public-interest goals.
- Public bodies adopting profit: PSUs are classified as Maharatna, Miniratna and Navratna. Each PSU has profit and revenue targets; depending on target-fulfilment they are granted more autonomy in decision-making. Government even considers winding up loss-making PSUs — so profit is becoming important for public bodies too.

8.1.4 Note — Conflict of Interest vs Ethical Dilemma

CRITICAL POINT

- Ethical dilemmas do not necessarily involve a private interest. Example: the government building a dam has no private interest but is genuinely conflicted between environment and development; obligations may be immediate vs long-term.
- In a lockdown the dilemma is GDP/economy vs people’s lives — again no personal interest.
- Broader category: which ethical values you pursue (no personal interest). Narrow category: conflict of interest, where a personal interest is involved.

QUICK REVISION

Public administration serves public interest; private serves profit — and this drives every other difference.

Accountability, dilemmas and rules are greater in public bodies; autonomy and speed are greater in private bodies.

Concerns diverge: red-tapism in public bodies vs discrimination / glass ceiling in private bodies. Globalisation is blurring the split — CSR pulls private firms toward public interest; Ratna targets pull PSUs toward profit.

8.1.5 *Ethical Imperative in Public Administration*

This asks: why should public administration follow ethical standards? These arguments were built earlier (foundational values for civil services; consequences of ethics for an organisation) and are merely restated here.

- Trust and confidence — e.g. the Election Commission as an institution that runs on public trust.
- Effective delivery — e.g. Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) shows why ethical conduct matters for outcomes.
- Ethical standards such as integrity, objectivity and non-partisanship are themselves the answer to “why be ethical.”

KEY CONCEPT

- Two-layer argument technique: for any ethical value, combine a generic argument (why any organisation should be ethical) with a specific argument for that value.
- Non-partisanship example: generic layer — corruption, efficiency, legitimacy, accountability; specific layer — three levels of impact: (i) bureaucracy’s motivation and morale; (ii) transfers, postings, promotions on merit vs party interest; (iii) the citizen and political parties. Generic + specific = a high-scoring answer.

8.1.6 *Ethical Challenges in Public Administration*

These are the problems public administration faces because of the mixed and often excessive expectations placed on it. Whatever was earlier discussed as “negativity” or “concerns” in government becomes an example of an ethical challenge here.

- Red-tapism; rigid hierarchy; poor team-building; top-down implementation.
- Well-meaning neutrality becoming apathy; rules becoming ends in themselves; lack of coordination; prevailing corruption.
- Violations of non-partisanship; discrimination; lack of integrity; limitations of objectivity; plus the limitations of the Max Weber model.

EXAMPLE

- West Bengal: bureaucrats appointed as Chief Secretary and Chief Advisor across governments.
- Bureaucrats resigning from service to immediately join a political party and contest elections — a violation of non-partisanship.

CRITICAL POINT

- The listed ethical challenges to reproduce in an answer: corruption, political interference, lack of accountability, lack of transparency, weak ethical training, cultural factors.
- The challenges of government work culture are the same set of challenges; a lack of emotional intelligence can also be cited as an example.

QUICK REVISION

Ethical imperative = why to be ethical (trust, delivery, integrity/objectivity/non-partisanship) using generic + specific arguments.

Ethical challenges = what goes wrong (red-tapism, apathy, corruption, political interference, weak training, cultural factors, non-partisanship violations).

8.2 Law as a Source of Ethical Guidance

Recall the earlier “Sources of Ethics” diagram: how does a person know what is right and wrong? Multiple sources tell us — our religion, the law, our culture. This topic examines in detail how law guides us on right and wrong.

8.2.1 Importance of Law

Codification of Public Morality.

KEY CONCEPT

- Law is the codification of public morality through the legislature. In a democracy: we hold elections → elected representatives debate → they declare what is legal and illegal.
- What society collectively believes to be right and wrong is expressed by its representatives and turned into law. The overlap is not total — not every public morality becomes law — but law, at least to some extent, expresses what society desires through its representatives.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Nirbhaya case: public demand led to the Criminal Law Amendment; the definition of sexual harassment was widened and the death penalty was provided for certain acts. Because juveniles were going “scot-free” (lenient punishment), the Juvenile Justice Act was amended so that 16–18 year-olds committing heinous crimes can be tried as adults.
- Online betting: as online betting spread (suicides, unemployment), the government moved to ban it — new social problems being codified into law.

Fighting Social Evil. Law identifies and fights social evils — e.g. child labour, child marriage, dowry — ensuring how such evils are to be combated.

Delivering Social Justice. Through reservation, affirmative action and EWS, law becomes an instrument of social justice.

Adding New Ethical Standards.

DATA & FACTS

Because law is enforceable, it can add entirely new ethical standards that society did not previously observe. India became the first country to legally mandate CSR — companies did not do CSR before; the law added a new ethical standard.

Business of Rights & Protecting Dignity. Rights become the “business” of law — Fundamental Rights, MGNREGA, RTI, RTE. Law protects your dignity: no discrimination on the basis of caste, religion or descent; no forced conversion. Instruments: Protection of Civil Rights Act; Manual Scavenging Act.

Promoting Good Governance. Law promotes good governance — e.g. the Jan Vishwas Act.

CRITICAL POINT

- Laws and regulations are a source of ethical guidance because they tell you clearly what is right and what is wrong, and they codify public morality through representation.
- They represent the spirit of society — what we collectively believe to be right and wrong (never a perfect overlap, but a genuine expression). Examples: Prevention of Corruption Act, Prevention of Atrocities Act.

QUICK REVISION

Six roles of law: codify public morality, fight social evil, deliver social justice, add new ethical standards, protect rights & dignity, promote good governance.

8.2.2 Limitations of Law

Law is a source of ethical guidance, but an incomplete one. The central limitation: something can be technically legal but not ethical.

Legal but Not Ethical.**EXAMPLE**

- Surrogate advertisement: promoting branded alcohol is not allowed, so firms bypass the law by advertising packaged mineral water under the same brand. The law has been bypassed — technically legal, but the intent is unethical.
- Marital rape: it is not clearly illegal in India, so the law fails to give ethical guidance in such cases — the law does not cover it even though the act is against dignity.

Enforcement Failures & Evasion.

- Lack of enforcement — dowry: dowry is prohibited yet widely practised, because enforcement agencies do not enforce the law. “The strength of society lies in law, but not in the morality of the people.” Law has failed to be a source of ethical guidance.
- Evasive tendency — Base Erosion and Profit Shifting (BEPS): MNCs exploit treaties, showing operations in low-tax countries to minimise tax. They misuse legal provisions and loopholes — legal but unethical, working against the spirit of the law.

Negative Perception — No Internal Change.

CRITICAL POINT

- Law is an external source of guidance, working through punishment and deterrence (“don’t be corrupt or you’ll go to jail”). It does not necessarily change a person’s behaviour or internal character.
- Where the law cannot reach — e.g. the image of people looting a fallen tanker, or everyday corruption — a person of poor internal character will still act wrongly. Law does not transform the inner self.

Law is Minimum Morality & Involves Discretion.**KEY CONCEPT**

- Law is minimum morality, not maximum morality — not every ethical standard is turned into enforceable law. Fundamental Duties are ethical standards but are not all legally enforceable.
- Law cannot envisage every situation, so it must leave discretion. Example: Article 19 reasonable restrictions — what counts as “reasonable” is left to discretion. Hence law cannot always provide ethical guidance in all situations.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

UPSC: “The rules and regulations provided to the civil servants are the same, yet positive-minded officers achieve much more than negative-minded officers.” — Positive-minded officers use the law in its positive spirit: they interpret reasonable restrictions correctly, do not file false sedition cases, do not resort to censorship. Because they are ethical, they use the same discretion for good.

QUICK REVISION

Limitations: legal ≠ ethical (surrogate ads, marital rape); lack of enforcement (dowry); evasion / loopholes (BEPS); no internal change (external deterrence only); law = minimum morality; and unavoidable discretion (Art. 19 reasonable restrictions).

8.3 Conscience as a Source of Ethical Guidance

Because law leaves so much discretion, conscience becomes crucial in filling the gap.

8.3.1 What Conscience Is**KEY CONCEPT**

- Conscience is our cognitive act of mind — our inner sense of right and wrong.
- It is a cognitive act (using our cognition), not merely a feeling. It is an inner sense, an internal compass, but ultimately a cognitive judgment in which reasoning is involved.
- It is shaped by experience — our life experiences, whatever we have lived and learnt, our teachers, the society we live in, the religion we follow, our parents and family. Everything contributes; conscience is a reflection of all those contributions.

8.3.2 *How Conscience Becomes a Source of Guidance*

When external sources do not clearly say what is right — e.g. what “reasonable restriction” means — one’s own sense of morality guides on right and wrong.

EXAMPLE

- Marital rape: the law does not call it illegal, but conscience forbids it as against dignity.
- Emergencies / disaster management: law gives no clear guidance, so conscience tells the officer what must be done.
- UBDT (Unbanked Direct Blood Transfer): conscience says this woman cannot be allowed to die — even if a rule must be broken to save her.

8.3.3 *Conscience Demands Personal Responsibility*

CRITICAL POINT

- Conscience is an inner moral compass and a reflection of values; ultimately it asks you to take personal responsibility for your judgment. You can never hide behind the law.
- President’s visit / VVIP protocol: during a VVIP movement a traffic protocol was imposed and a woman died; the officer pleaded “the traffic law was applied, what could I do?” But conscience should have questioned whether that rule outweighed a life.
- PDS officer: a woman lacking documents — conscience must weigh the rule against her survival.

EXAMPLE

Gandhiji & Chauri Chaura: his conscience insisted that a mass movement must remain non-violent, so he called off the movement. A classic example of conscience guiding decision-making.

8.3.4 *Conscience vs Law*

Aspect	Conscience	Law
Location	Inner source of guidance	External source of guidance
Control	You have control; shaped by upbringing and changeable through new experience	In others’ hands; enforced upon you
Mode	Cognitive judgment of right and wrong	Punishment / deterrence

8.3.5 Can You Always Rely on Conscience? (Is it an Infallible Guide?)

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

UPSC: Is conscience an infallible guide to ethical decision-making? Can you always rely on it? — No.

CRITICAL POINT

- Conscience is highly subjective and does not necessarily produce ethical decisions.
- Honour killing: parents believe they are right, “saving their honour.” Kasab / suicide bombers: felt no regret because they were trained that way.
- Conscience can be unethically trained — the internal sense of right and wrong can itself be wrong. Experiences and learnings can be narrow; religious doctrine can be absorbed uncritically.

KEY CONCEPT

- Therefore conscience should be trained in constitutional morality.
- Socrates: “The unexamined life is not worth living” — we need habitual self-reflection / introspection to train the conscience better.
- Abraham Lincoln: “Nothing in this world is considered wholly good or wholly bad.” Knowledge needs constant churning and critical thinking; what is just in one context can become unjust in another.

EXAMPLE

- HDFC Bank chairman resigned citing conscience — he could no longer accept certain practices.
- Kasab’s lawyer initially refused to defend him — a matter of conscience.
- Parents paying for paper leaks — a conscience issue.

8.3.6 UPSC PYQ — Max Weber on Bureaucratic Morality

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

UPSC (Max Weber): “It is not wise to apply to public administration the sort of moral and ethical norms we apply to matters of personal conscience. It is important to realise that state bureaucracy might possess its own independent bureaucratic morality.”

First half — Weber’s point.

- The norms we apply to our personal conscience cannot run a government. A bureaucrat must be impersonal.
- Example: a Jain who believes in non-violence, if appointed head of a fishery board / food-processing body (meat value-addition, poultry, fisheries), cannot administer if he imports his personal conscience. Personal conscience would also push him to help his brother and friends → nepotism. Hence Weber’s value-neutrality, objectivity, impersonality.

KEY CONCEPT

Independent bureaucratic morality = value-neutrality, impersonality, legal-rational authority, hierarchy, division of labour, career as a profession, and adherence to written rules and regulations. If you are part of the bureaucracy, follow these; keep personal matters out of the equation.

Second half — but conscience is still needed.**CRITICAL POINT**

- If you keep your own morality entirely out, the result is apathy, rules becoming ends, and red-tapism.
- Weber says follow laws, rules and regulations — but laws do not tell you what is right and wrong (e.g. what “reasonable restriction” means). So you must, at times, listen to conscience, especially in emergencies and where lives are at stake.
- Conclusion: ultimate responsibility is yours; but conscience has limits and can be wrong, so all of us should train our conscience in constitutional morality and practise reflective thinking.

8.3.7 Crisis of Conscience**KEY CONCEPT**

- Crisis of conscience is the deep sense of guilt and crisis that arises when you firmly believe something is right (your conscience says so) yet act against it. That immense guilt — even from a mistake made knowingly or unknowingly that you regard as wrong — is a crisis of conscience.
- Conscience is an important sanction mechanism (the “fifth sanction”): acting far from one’s conscience causes psychological suffering / mental pain.
- Whistleblower: if you fail to blow the whistle and many people die because of your inaction, the later guilt and shame is a crisis of conscience — which is why conscience works as a sanction.

COMPARISON

Crisis of conscience vs cognitive dissonance: choosing a blue vs a pink phone can create guilt / cognitive dissonance, but not necessarily a crisis of conscience. A crisis of conscience is always about ethics — the ethical angle is the key difference between cognitive dissonance and a crisis of conscience.

QUICK REVISION

Conscience = inner, cognitive sense of right/wrong, shaped by experience; fills the discretion left by law.

It demands personal responsibility — never hide behind rules.

But it is not infallible (can be unethically trained) → train it in constitutional morality with habitual self-reflection.

Weber PYQ: keep personal conscience out for impersonality, yet conscience is indispensable where

law is silent.

Crisis of conscience = guilt from acting against one's conscience; distinguished from cognitive dissonance by the ethical angle.

8.4 Corporate Governance — Ethics in Private Institutions

8.4.1 Why We Study This Topic (The Core Argument)

KEY CONCEPT

- The private sector pursues profit and often assumes that being ethical and being profitable are opposed — controlling pollution, paying fair wages, ensuring fire safety, working honestly all raise cost and seem to cut profit. Believing this, some firms resort to unethical means.
- The single purpose of this topic is to be able to argue that being ethical actually helps good business — “good ethics is good business.” This exact argument is what you will use in case studies and answer-writing.

8.4.2 What Corporate Governance Is

- When you buy a share (Jio, Reliance, Tata, etc.) you become an owner — which requires trust.
- Management (the CXOs) runs the company day-to-day using shareholders' funds as a trustee, and therefore has an ethical obligation to use those funds ethically for the company's growth.
- The Board of Directors supervises the functioning; regular board meetings approve plans.

KEY CONCEPT

- Corporate governance is the fairness of company management — being fair to every stakeholder, not just shareholders.
- Stakeholder = whosoever is impacted by the operations of the company: owners/shareholders, consumers, employees, suppliers, competitors, government/regulators and society.
- The firm must navigate between profitability, morality, legality and all social & environmental obligations — and we argue that by being environmentally sustainable, legal, moral and socially conscious, a company becomes more profitable in the long run.

8.4.3 Obligations Towards Shareholders

- Do not misuse funds for private purposes. Money raised for the company must not be diverted to personal use.

EXAMPLE

Blue Smart Cab: the sole promoter (Jain) raised investors' money and bought apartments/flats worth crores for himself — a clear violation, since the money came for the company, not private use.

- Ensure a fair and sustainable return (at least the intention to). People invest for growth and returns; having no intention to return their money is a form of deceit.

- Protect minority shareholders. Just as society has majoritarianism, the shareholding pattern has majoritarianism — a large holder (e.g. Reliance) nominates most of the board and can control ~95%, so minority-shareholder interest can be compromised.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Companies Act provision: at least one-third of directors must be independent directors — directors with no connection to company management, who independently verify that the interest of minority shareholders is not compromised.

- Provide accurate and fair information. When a company brings an IPO it advertises its performance; it must give accurate, fair information so investors make an informed decision. Shareholders receive updates, may participate in the general meeting and may vote.

EXAMPLE

Satyam scam: the company faked data to raise more money — violating the duty of accurate information so that investors could not decide in an informed way. Ultimately the truth came out and the business collapsed.

DATA & FACTS

- Good ethics = good business (shareholders): timely repayment builds credibility → cheaper loans and better valuations (higher company value); transparency attracts investors.
- HDFC Bank: on the chairman's resignation the bank lost lakhs of crores in a single day and its valuation dropped — public perception of unethical conduct causes business loss.
- IndusInd Bank: an accounting-mismatch news item wiped ~27% off the share in one day. Yes Bank is a similar example.

8.4.4 Obligations Towards Consumers

- Uphold consumer rights — including the right to safe products, right to be informed, and other consumer rights.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

UPSC case study: a reputed food company licensed to sell food products in the domestic market was selling unsafe/substandard products. Ethical issue: consumer rights violated — specifically the right to safe products. The firm failed precisely because it did not value its consumer.

KEY CONCEPT

Valuing the consumer → word of mouth → brand value, market loyalty, lower marketing spend → more sales → profit. Ethical service can itself be a source of distinction from competitors.

EXAMPLE

- Tata Motors — cars seen as safe → brand value → lower marketing expense. iPhone — valued for privacy → people buy it.

- Certifications signalling ethics: ISI Mark (safety); Organic certificate; Kimberley Certification (diamond is ethically sourced, not a “blood diamond” financing murder); ethically-sourced cocoa/chocolate; “no refined oil” / vegetable-oil claims; Biotique animal-cruelty-free products; “baked, not fried.”
- Patagonia donates 1% of sales to the environment. A CP restaurant (“Indus Flavour”) advertised “we prepare fresh curries” — ethical practice used as a point of distinction.

8.4.5 *Obligations Towards Employees*

- Merit-based appointment, promotion and pay; no favouritism, casteism or gender bias.
- Will not discriminate on the basis of race, caste, sex, etc.; will not indulge in exploitation (no child labour); ensure work-life balance, overall well-being and mental health.
- The glass ceiling (women not promoted) is wrong.

EXAMPLE

- Google: rewards employees handsomely, trusts them, does not micromanage, offers flexibility and even nap pods → attracts merit; people compete to work there.
- Tata: after employee deaths during COVID, Tata supported the families with education and financial assistance — building deep trust and faith.
- Negative: the Noida protest; the TCS Nashik/Pune case (sexual harassment with no hearing).

KEY CONCEPT

Fairness to employees reduces attrition (saving recruitment and training cost) and yields better motivation, higher productivity and long-term sustainability — i.e. higher efficiency. Good ethics is good business.

8.4.6 *Obligations Towards Government / Regulators*

Why should a company comply with regulations? Note that “to avoid penalty” is a weak ethical argument — like saying “don’t steal because you’ll go to jail.” The stronger arguments follow.

- Avoid legal cost — penalties; non-compliance can shut operations. (A real reason, but not a deep ethical one.)
- Gain credibility and the trust of consumers — complying with regulations (e.g. bank regulations) allows consumers to trust you.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Risk management: profit-making involves risk; regulations help manage it. In a bank, deposits are liabilities and loans are assets; reckless (greedy) lending creates NPAs (Non-Performing Assets).
- RBI regulations require a buffer mechanism (Tier-1, Tier-2 capital) under Basel Norms, plus the Prompt Corrective Action (PCA) framework and due diligence — so that a bank is not exposed to excessive risk.

- Sustainability of business operations — environmental-conservation norms require firms to mitigate environmental consequences.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Delhi air pollution / GRAP: when PM 2.5 and PM 10 exceed limits, construction activities are halted; not following such government regulations causes economic loss.
- Level playing field: avoid anti-competitive practices (e.g. e-commerce deep discounts vs retail shops). The Competition Commission of India (CCI) protects against monopolies and maintains a level playing field.

Reducing Negative Externalities & Inequality.

KEY CONCEPT

Operations can cause environmental degradation and rising inequality, both of which government must contain because they ultimately hurt the market economy.

EXAMPLE

- Great Economic Depression: if all companies take all profits and do not share with workers, no one can buy their products → recession → the market economy fails.
- New Deal (USA): put money into people's hands through employment programmes and public expenditure to generate demand — the “poster boy of capitalism” adopted socialist measures because the economy required it. Hence government must reduce inequality.
- IndiGo crisis: to avoid market failure, government capped domestic fares (Rs. 34,000) when demand-supply broke down.

QUICK REVISION

Comply with regulations → more credibility, sustainability, risk management, level playing field, and reduced negative consequences & inequality. “Don’t steal because of jail” is weak; “compliance protects the market economy that is in your own interest” is strong.

8.4.7 Obligations Towards Society

- A company is a product of society (it takes resources — water, air, raw materials — and leaves negative consequences on society). It is therefore always in debt to society and has obligations towards it.

KEY CONCEPT

- By contributing to society (e.g. healthcare and education), a company gains better employees and better consumers: good health/education → skilled human capital and consumers with better paying capacity → more demand and more productive workers.
- Legitimacy / licence to operate: serving society earns the legitimacy to operate. Without it, a firm faces opposition and disruption.

EXAMPLE

- Sterlite copper plant, Thoothukudi (Tamil Nadu): protests over environmental concerns → loss of legitimacy to operate.
- Google data centres: even very large MNCs may not yet have earned local trust, and so may lack the legitimacy to operate, inviting opposition.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

UPSC: How will CSR / corporate ethical governance make companies profitable? — Argue through brand value, lower marketing expenditure, legitimacy to operate, employee commitment, productivity and motivation → profitability. When you are ethical you do no favour to anyone; you help only yourself.

8.4.8 Ethical Concerns in Corporate Governance (India)**KEY CONCEPT**

- Importance of good corporate governance: raises investor confidence and foreign investment and lowers vulnerability to corruption.
- Economic crises arise when morals fail and firms do not comply with corporate-governance norms — Satyam scam (greed), Blue Smart Cab, the NPA crisis of banks, collusion (compliances skipped, nepotism shown).

The Independent-Director Problem.**CRITICAL POINT**

- The independent director exists to protect minority investors and provide a separate, in-house monitoring mechanism. But independent directors are often not truly independent.
- Government PSUs: government holds a major stake and appoints ruling-party spokespersons as “independent” directors → favouritism, nepotism → they cannot monitor independently. “Nepotism/favouritism in independent directors and boards can undermine the board’s ability to provide unbiased oversight.”

Other Concerns.

- Collusion (a huge risk — e.g. bank NPAs), lack of oversight, lack of independence, nepotism/favouritism.

EXAMPLE

- Crony capitalism: a private company funds a political party’s election campaign; after winning, the ruling party favours those companies in contracts and tenders — unfair, and it destroys the level playing field.
- Simply reverse the positive stakeholder points to generate concerns: glass ceiling, employee discrimination/exploitation, protest cases, fund misuse (Blue Smart), cheating consumers.
- Further examples: Kingfisher Airlines (excessive risk), the NPA crisis, the Harshad Mehta

scam, and “front-hunt” collusion.

8.4.9 Companies Act 2013 — Provisions for Ethical Governance

Women Director.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Mandatory to appoint at least one woman director in every listed company — addressing the glass ceiling and ensuring representation.

Independent Directors.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- At least one-third of directors as independent directors — purpose: protecting the interest of minority shareholders, improving corporate credibility, and fraud prevention & detection. An in-house independent mechanism monitors the company and can detect fraud before it occurs. “Independent” means no dealings with the owners.
- Misuse: appointing ruling-party spokespersons as independent directors of PSUs.

Audit Committee.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- Qualification: members must be able to read and understand financial statements — a check so that not just anyone can be appointed.
- Role: examination of financial statements and reports (verifying profit/loss/revenue are genuine, not faked); evaluation of internal financial control and risk management (the most important keyword); and monitoring the end-use of funds.
- Analogy — a bank minimises risk through KYC, CIBIL score, collateral and due diligence; the audit committee checks whether such risk-reduction systems are in place. It maintains corporate credibility and helps identify mistakes/scandals early.

Stakeholder Relationship Committee.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Purpose: to reduce and address grievances between shareholders and the board of directors.

Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR).

DATA & FACTS

- Eligible companies must spend 2% of their (3-year average) net profit on society. India became the first country to legally mandate CSR.
- Tata Steel spends 5–7% of its profit after tax on CSR.

EXAMPLE

- Tata Steel — tribal areas: with many plants in tribal regions of Jharkhand and Odisha, Tata

shows gratitude to tribal culture by establishing tribal cultural centres showcasing the legacy of tribes.

- Atul initiative (Tata): trains persons with physical disability in the art of making recycled paper.
- MANSI initiative — Maternal and Newborn Survival Initiative (Tata Steel): aims to reduce child and infant mortality in states like Jharkhand; the MANSI project was awarded by the government.
- Other positives: Patagonia (1% of sales to environment); ITC e-Choupal (helping farmers).

KEY CONCEPT

Consequences of ethics for a private organisation: employee satisfaction, better public image, licence to operate, and profitability.

8.4.10 *Issues / Limitations of CSR*

- Additional corporate tax — CSR is seen as a burden, so it is often not done in letter and spirit.
- Projects not aligned to people's needs — e.g. a company builds toilets where residents actually wanted a library; projects should follow the community's need, not the company's preference.
- Dearth of well-meaning NGOs — most credible NGOs are concentrated in urban and peri-urban areas, not in rural/remote regions, so projects are hard to execute where they are most needed.
- Lack of a robust CSR policy — firms lack a plan to spend large sums sustainably; CSR funds are viewed as a one-time disbursement with no long-term policy.
- Others: corruption, duplication of activity, poor implementation and a skewed pattern of expenditure.

QUICK REVISION

Corporate governance = fairness to every stakeholder (shareholders, consumers, employees, government/regulators, society).

Across all of them the refrain is “good ethics is good business” — ethics helps the firm itself in the long run.

Companies Act 2013 tools: woman director, one-third independent directors, audit committee, stakeholder relationship committee, CSR (2%).

Concerns: fake independence of directors, collusion, crony capitalism, NPAs, discrimination. CSR limits: burden mindset, mismatch with need, NGO scarcity, weak policy.

8.5 Ethics in International Relations

8.5.1 *Background — “There is No Place for Principles in Politics”*

KEY CONCEPT

A common belief holds that there is no place for principles in politics — politics is all about power: how to acquire it and how to remain powerful.

EXAMPLE

- Machiavelli: “the central goal of the ruler is to maintain and increase power,” and the ends justify the means.
- Chanakya / Kautilya: the doctrine of *sām*, *dām*, *daṇḍa*, *bheda*.
- Bismarck (Unification of Germany): “the great questions of the day will not be settled by speeches and majority decisions, but by iron and blood” — i.e. conflicts are settled by the policy of war, not democratic decision-making.
- Donald Trump (to Zelensky): “you don’t have the cards” — implying a weak country is not in a position to argue; poor/weak countries never hold power.
- Domestically the same is visible — rising criminalisation, the role of money power, misuse of the Governor’s office, and misuse of the anti-defection law to manufacture governments — showing politics and principles not going hand in hand.

8.5.2 Why International Relations Are Different — The Analogy

A ladder of examples explains why regulation is weakest at the international level.

KEY CONCEPT

- Individual: if a person says “I will do whatever I want,” he cannot — police, judiciary, law and the rule of law stand above him.
- State government: if a state says “I will be independent and follow nothing,” it cannot — the central government, Constitution, army and judiciary stand above it.
- Country: if a country says “I will do whatever I want,” at the international level there is no corresponding enforcement power / rule of law. UN mechanisms are dysfunctional; the USA does much as it pleases, and no one stops it.

CRITICAL POINT

The crux: at the international level there is nothing as enforceable as domestic law. Enforcement is what matters, and it is missing — hence the deep challenge in regulating countries’ behaviour internationally.

8.5.3 Why Countries Should Be Ethical — The Arguments

Since there is no international enforcer, the argument must be that it is in a country’s own interest to be ethical. Each argument below pairs a reason with an example.

Global Nature of Problems.**KEY CONCEPT**

Terrorism, climate change, global warming, cyber-security and global pandemics (COVID) are global problems, and global problems require global solutions. No nation can tackle them alone → all share responsibility, which is the essence of ethics (duty beyond narrow self-interest). Violation example: the USA withdrawing from the Paris Climate Deal.

To Resolve Conflicts Amicably & Peacefully.

KEY CONCEPT

Given the great inequality in military capabilities, if all conflicts are settled by military means the bigger fish always eats the smaller fish — that suppresses conflict rather than solving it, so there is never lasting peace. “Peace can never be kept by force”; “the absence of tension does not mean peace.” We must believe in peaceful resolution and a rule-based architecture.

For Inclusive & Sustainable Growth.**KEY CONCEPT**

Because of developmental inequalities, not all countries can fight all problems equally. India cannot say “if Pakistan has polio, it is not our problem.” Helping other countries helps ourselves — e.g. providing vaccines/medicines to Africa, since it is better to contain a disease in its source region than to face it at home. The EU helps African nations tackle conflict and refugee flows in the source region.

Overarching Rule-Based Architecture.**KEY CONCEPT**

National laws may not be sufficient — a global law on terrorism is needed. Hence international conventions. (Afghanistan/Pakistan illustrate the terrorism gap.)

To Have Flourishing Trade.**KEY CONCEPT**

Flourishing trade needs a level playing field and fair mechanisms to negotiate trade deals — trade must not be enforced through bullying, or it will not last. Hence multilateral frameworks like the WTO (made dysfunctional by the USA, e.g. the paralysed dispute-settlement appellate mechanism).

EXAMPLE

India & TRIPS: India changed its IPR laws to move from process patents (a weaker form — only the specific process is protected, so the product can be reverse-engineered by another process) to product patents (a stronger form — the product itself cannot be made by any process). A concession made through international negotiation for the sake of flourishing trade.

To Uphold Rule of Law & Accountability. Countries committing genocides against their own citizens must be held accountable — upholding the international rule of law.

To Uphold Cultural Relativism & Tolerance.**KEY CONCEPT**

Powerful nations tend to impose “our culture is the best.” (Trump to Zelensky: “where is your suit?” — as if wearing a suit were a precondition for peace talks.) Without institutions like UNESCO promoting cultural diversity, the result is cultural imperialism — powerful nations imposing their cultures. So we must promote diversity of culture and tolerance.

Interdependence in the Age of Technology & Globalisation.

KEY CONCEPT

“In this age of technology and globalisation we are all interdependent on each other; the sooner we understand this, the better it is for all of us.” A war in one place (e.g. Iran) affects everyone through energy supply, trade routes and global value chains. We must believe in humanity and collective well-being.

CRITICAL POINT

Common tone of all arguments: ethics benefits us; ethics is logical and rational. In effect you are telling every nation — do not be selfish, or we all suffer.

8.5.4 Which Ethical Principles to Follow in IR**PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**

Cosmopolitan Moral Theory (Immanuel Kant) — a PYQ: every person is of equal moral worth; one cannot say American citizens are worth more than Africans. Therefore political/territorial boundaries are morally irrelevant — where there is genocide or killing, borders do not excuse inaction. This guides us to uphold human rights and preserve humanity.

- Panchsheel principles — respect for sovereignty and related tenets.
- Solidarity and global cooperation — the responsibility to help others.
- Mutual respect for cultural diversity.
- UN principles and human rights.

8.5.5 Ethical Concerns in IR (Current-Affairs Examples)

Human-rights violations, war crimes, environmental degradation, refugee crises, cyber-security problems and cultural imperialism — in each you can show how international ethical principles are being violated.

QUICK REVISION

IR lacks an enforcer (unlike domestic law) → argue ethics as self-interest.

Eight arguments: global problems, peaceful conflict resolution, inclusive growth, rule-based architecture, flourishing trade, rule of law/accountability, cultural relativism, interdependence.

Principles: Cosmopolitan Moral Theory (Kant), Panchsheel, solidarity & cooperation, cultural respect, UN & human rights.

8.5.6 Ethical Issues in International Funding

Funding may be bilateral (country A to country B) or multilateral (IMF, World Bank, Asian Development Bank). On the surface it helps and promotes democracy — but there can be hidden problems.

EXAMPLE

Hidden interests — Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant: the IB report stated the protests had hidden foreign-funded interests aimed at stalling India's development story / delaying the project — funding arriving under the guise of environment or democracy but with a sinister design.

CRITICAL POINT

- Conditionality: country A funds country B on condition that, say, 70% of the fund is spent buying equipment from country A — reducing the recipient's sovereignty, even though it may have a cheaper, safer or different alternative.
- Neo-imperialism: IMF/World Bank aid conditionalities (limit fiscal deficit, cut subsidies, reduce support programmes) promote only one, Western mode of development (liberalisation, private-sector-led growth, lower fiscal deficit) — as if the recipient were not wise enough to have its own model. This restricts sovereignty (e.g. a party that promised free healthcare/education finds its options cut).

EXAMPLE

- Diversion of funds / terror funding: the Falah-e-Insaniyat Foundation (FIF), operated by Hafiz Saeed (26/11), is cited as an NGO diverting funds to terror activities; corruption is a further concern.
- Clinical trials: developed-country firms shift trials to poor countries to exploit cheaper labour, weak regulatory capacity and lower penalty risk. The Bhopal Gas Tragedy (1984) shows how consequences that would be enormously costly in the USA were not so in India.
- China's Belt and Road Initiative (One Belt One Road): an example of hidden interest / debt-trap diplomacy.

QUICK REVISION

International-funding concerns: hidden interests (Kudankulam/IB report), conditionality (loss of sovereignty), neo-imperialism (IMF/WB, one Western model), diversion / terror funding (FIF-Hafiz Saeed), clinical trials (Bhopal), and debt-trap diplomacy (BRI).

8.6 Just War Theory

8.6.1 The Logic of Foreseeable Consequences

KEY CONCEPT

- If you know the consequences of an action beforehand, you are held more responsible for it (e.g. smoking despite knowing it causes cancer; eating sugar despite diabetes).
- Yet we still undertake certain actions despite negative consequences because they also carry positive consequences — e.g. abortion (a life taken, but a mother's life saved) or law-and-order management (a lathi-charge or firing may cost lives, but saves lives and preserves order).

CRITICAL POINT

War is similar: it means people will be killed — own soldiers, the enemy, and innocents. Because this is foreseeable, the decision-maker is more responsible and the decision must be taken with great care. War must be a method of last resort.

8.6.2 Principles Before War (*Jus ad Bellum*)

- **Last resort** — war only after all peaceful alternatives are exhausted. In the Ramayana, Angad and Hanuman were sent first; in the Mahabharata, Krishna sought just five villages — war came only when refused.
- **Legitimate authority** — war may be waged only by a legitimate authority (the state/government), which alone has the legitimacy and the duty to protect. Individuals waging war would be terrorists; Congress or BJP as parties cannot wage war.
- **Reasonable assurance / probability of success** — if the objective cannot be achieved, killing is unjustified. Terrorists have no probability of success, which is one reason their actions are unethical.
- **Right intention** — the objective of a just war is to re-establish peace; the intention must be just (justice, not image-protection or chest-thumping). Kant stressed intention above all.
- **Proportionality** — resorting to war must lead to more good than harm; violence should escalate gradually (lathi-charge → water cannon → tear gas), not straight to tanks. India's use of force is gradual, non-escalatory and voluntarily self-restrained.

EXAMPLE

Legitimacy to decision-making — all-party meeting: convened to lend legitimacy to a decision on the use of force, keeping the response non-escalatory.

8.6.3 During War (*Jus in Bello*) & After War (*Jus post Bellum*)**KEY CONCEPT**

- During war: minimise civilian harm and risk; commit no war crimes (e.g. mass rape, killing of civilians).
- Post-war: ensure justice, rehabilitation and accountability mechanisms.

8.6.4 Purpose & Exam Application**PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**

UPSC — “War is also a tool of diplomacy”: not *every* war qualifies; only a just war that follows these ethical principles can be a tool of diplomacy.

CRITICAL POINT

Just War Theory does not advocate or glorify war. It exists to explain when war can be ethical, because the decision to kill is grave and must be reasoned. War, like abortion, is inherently a

grave wrong undertaken only under strict justification.

EXAMPLE

1971 War: had it not happened, the refugee crisis would have been far worse — a case where war, as a last resort, produced a just result. The Ramayana war is similarly cited.

QUICK REVISION

Foreseeable killing makes the war decision grave → last resort.

Before war (jus ad bellum): last resort, legitimate authority, probability of success, right intention (re-establish peace), proportionality (more good than harm).

During war: minimise civilian harm, no war crimes. After war: justice, rehabilitation, accountability.

The theory explains ethical war; it does not promote war. Just war = a tool of diplomacy (1971).

Service Delivery, Codes, Transparency, Accountability & Probity

9.1 Just War Theory — During War and After War

The Just War Theory provides an ethical framework that prescribes principles governing conduct before, during, and after war. The pre-war (jus ad bellum) principles were discussed previously. Below are the principles for during war (jus in bello) and after war (jus post bellum).

9.1.1 During War (Jus in Bello) — Principles

Proportionality of Force. During war, the force used must be proportional to the military objective. Disproportionate violence — such as using excessive force against a minor target — is ethically impermissible. Proportionality ensures that the destruction caused during conflict does not exceed what is necessary.

KEY CONCEPT

Proportionality of Violence: The degree of force used in war must be proportionate to the military objective being pursued. Excessive or indiscriminate force violates ethical norms of warfare.

Distinction Between Civilian and Military Targets. Combatants must distinguish between civilian and military targets. Deliberately targeting civilians or civilian infrastructure (hospitals, schools, places of worship) is a violation of the just war framework. Only legitimate military targets may be engaged.

CRITICAL POINT

Combatants must distinguish between civilian and military targets. Intentional attacks on civilian populations constitute a war crime under international humanitarian law.

Humane Treatment of Prisoners of War and Wounded Soldiers. Prisoners of war (POWs) and wounded soldiers should be treated humanely. Atrocities, torture, and inhumane treatment are strictly prohibited. This principle aligns with the Geneva Conventions.

KEY CONCEPT

Humane Treatment: Prisoners of war and wounded soldiers must be treated humanely. No atrocities or inhumane treatment should be inflicted upon them.

9.1.2 After War (*Jus Post Bellum*) — Principles

Holding Individuals Accountable for War Crimes. After a war concludes, individuals responsible for war crimes must be identified and held accountable. International tribunals and courts of justice serve this function.

Establishing a Just and Lasting Peace. The post-war phase must focus on establishing a just and lasting peace. This includes rebuilding societies, restoring institutions, ensuring justice for victims, and creating conditions that prevent future conflicts.

KEY CONCEPT

Post-war objectives include: (a) Accountability for war crimes; (b) Establishing a just and lasting peace; (c) Rebuilding societies and institutions.

Note: The before-war (*jus ad bellum*) principles are the most important from a decision-making perspective, as they deal with the ethical question of whether to go to war at all. During-war and after-war principles provide the ethical guardrails for conduct once war has begun.

QUICK REVISION

During War: Proportionality of force; Distinction between civilian and military targets; Humane treatment of POWs and wounded soldiers.

After War: Holding individuals accountable for war crimes; Establishing a just and lasting peace; Rebuilding societies.

Before war (already discussed) involves the most critical decision-making about whether war is justified at all.

9.2 Quality of Service Delivery

9.2.1 Definition

Quality of service delivery refers to the extent to which the services provided by an organization (especially government) meet or exceed the expected standards of citizens. When a service meets or exceeds expectations, it is considered qualitative. The topic is essentially about understanding the parameters or standards against which any service delivery can be evaluated.

KEY CONCEPT

Quality of Service Delivery: A service is considered qualitative when it meets or exceeds the expected standards. This topic involves understanding the parameters for evaluating any service delivery system.

9.2.2 Parameters of Quality of Service Delivery

Availability. Whether a service is available to all intended beneficiaries. If a section of society cannot access the service, it fails the availability test.

EXAMPLE

- Under the National Food Security Act, 5 kg of food grains were promised to certain populations through PDS. However, migrants could not avail these benefits because they were not at their registered locations. This was an availability problem.
- The One Nation, One Ration Card scheme was introduced to address this availability gap, allowing migrants to access rations anywhere in the country.

Accessibility. Services must be accessible to all citizens, including persons with different abilities. Barriers to access must be identified and removed.

EXAMPLE

The Election Commission provides wheelchairs and ramps at polling stations for persons with disabilities, thereby increasing accessibility of the voting process.

Responsiveness. How quickly and effectively an organization responds to grievances is a key dimension. A responsive administration acknowledges complaints and resolves them promptly.

EXAMPLE

Many citizens who are dissatisfied with railway services tag railway officials on Twitter or social media, and their grievances are resolved through that channel — demonstrating responsiveness through digital platforms.

Reliability. A service is reliable if citizens can depend on it consistently. If a service is unreliable, citizens must make alternative arrangements, which undermines trust.

EXAMPLE

- If one needs to book a Tatkal ticket for travel to Bihar during Chhath Puja, can one rely on the Tatkal system? If not, alternative arrangements are needed. Government reforms such as linking Tatkal booking with Aadhaar and fixing booking time windows were introduced to improve reliability.
- Similarly, choosing an internet service provider depends on whose service is more reliable in a given area.

Quality Per Se. The inherent quality of the service itself matters greatly. If the quality of inputs or outputs is poor, the service fails regardless of other parameters.

EXAMPLE

- In PDS, it has been observed that good quality food grain is often sold in the open market while poor quality food grain is given to beneficiaries — a direct quality failure.
- Many people would not choose government schools or government hospitals for their families if given a choice, reflecting a perceived quality deficit in government service delivery.

Effectiveness. A service is effective if it achieves its intended objective. If a school does not deliver learning, or a hospital does not deliver treatment, the service is ineffective.

EXAMPLE

In many government schools, subject teachers (mathematics, physics, chemistry) are absent for long periods. This means learning is not happening, making the education service ineffective.

Sustainability. Services must be sustainable over time. Intermittent or temporary services are not truly qualitative.

EXAMPLE

If municipal water supply comes for only 9 months out of 12, it is not sustainable. Any government service must be consistently available over time.

Economy, Efficiency, and Cost-Effectiveness. If the cost of delivering a service is disproportionately high relative to the benefit (e.g., spending one rupee and only 16 paise reaching the beneficiary), the service is not cost-effective and will not be sustainable in the long run.

EXAMPLE

Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT): Before DBT, benefits often did not reach beneficiaries' accounts due to corruption and leakages (efficiency problem). DBT improved both efficiency (reducing leakages) and effectiveness (ensuring the intended beneficiary actually receives the benefit).

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) improved both efficiency and effectiveness of government welfare delivery by transferring benefits directly to beneficiaries' bank accounts.

Ease and Convenience. The ease with which a citizen can access a service is an important quality parameter. Reducing procedural complexity increases quality.

EXAMPLE

- The Jharkhand government explored home delivery of rations to improve ease of access.
- UPSC introduced One Time Registration (OTR), eliminating the need for candidates to submit their information repeatedly across multiple examination cycles — improving convenience.

Timeliness. Services must be delivered within a reasonable and expected timeframe. Delayed services lose their value and relevance.

EXAMPLE

Birth certificates, death certificates, and marriage certificates must be issued in a timely manner. A death certificate that is not issued promptly can cause serious legal and financial problems for the family of the deceased.

Grievance Redressal. A robust grievance redressal mechanism is essential. Citizens must have a channel to register complaints when services fail.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

CP-GRAM (Centralized Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System): A government portal for grievance redressal related to central government departments. It has been integrated with AI (through a tool called ‘Samadhan Didi’) for improved grievance resolution.

Citizen-Centricity. Services must be designed around the needs of citizens. Private sector organizations like Domino’s replace a pizza if the customer is dissatisfied — a consumer-centric approach. Government services often lack this orientation.

CRITICAL POINT

In the private sector, consumer-centricity drives accountability. In the government sector, citizens often have no alternative provider, making citizen-centric design even more important.

QUICK REVISION

Parameters: Availability, Accessibility, Responsiveness, Reliability, Quality per se, Effectiveness, Sustainability, Economy/Efficiency/Cost-effectiveness, Ease/Convenience, Timeliness, Grievance Redressal, Citizen-centricity.

Key examples: One Nation One Ration Card (availability), Ramps at polling stations (accessibility), Social media grievance handling by railways (responsiveness), Tatkal reforms (reliability), PDS quality issues (quality per se), DBT (efficiency + effectiveness), OTR by UPSC (convenience), CP-GRAM with Samadhan Didi AI (grievance redressal).

9.2.3 Reasons for Poor Quality of Service Delivery

Overburdening of the System / Population Pressure. When the carrying capacity of public infrastructure is breached, service quality declines. Overburdened systems cannot maintain quality.

EXAMPLE

- Mumbai local trains are overcrowded due to massive population pressure, degrading the quality of transport.
- Tourist places often face strain on sewer systems, drinking water supply, and waste management when tourist numbers exceed carrying capacity.

Lack of Skilled Workforce. When government employees, especially teachers and front-line workers, are not adequately trained, service delivery suffers. Many government teachers are not trained in sound pedagogy and rely on rote learning methods.

EXAMPLE

- Government teachers who rely on rote learning rather than conceptual teaching reduce the effectiveness of education delivery.
- Skills India and Digital India initiatives aim to bridge the skill gap, but the training of government employees themselves remains a challenge.

Corruption. Corruption diverts resources meant for public services. Where corruption exists, poor service delivery will inevitably follow. Both supply-side (officials demanding bribes) and demand-side (citizens offering bribes) corruption contribute.

Bureaucratic Problems. Several systemic issues within the bureaucracy lead to poor service delivery. These include colonial attitudes, top-down implementation, a culture of secrecy, red-tapism, resistance to change, and poor accountability mechanisms. These factors have been discussed in detail under bureaucratic challenges earlier in the syllabus.

Resource Constraints. Inadequate investment in public services directly affects quality. Without sufficient financial resources, infrastructure remains poor and human resources are inadequate.

DATA & FACTS

India's spending on healthcare and education as a percentage of GDP remains lower than that of many developed nations. For education, it is approximately 3% of GDP, which is considered insufficient to provide quality services across the country.

Digital Divide. Many services are now delivered digitally, but significant portions of the population lack internet access, digital skills, or face vernacular language barriers. Where electricity infrastructure itself is absent, digital delivery is impossible.

Cultural and Societal Factors. Even when the government provides good infrastructure, cultural factors can undermine service delivery. Poor civic sense, vandalism of public property, and normalization of wrong means all contribute to declining service quality.

EXAMPLE

- In trains, mugs in toilets are chained due to trust deficit — people steal public property.
- People throw stones at Vande Bharat trains, damaging public infrastructure.
- Government can provide dustbins, but ultimately citizens must use them. Government can build toilets, but citizens must use them.
- Corruption has a demand side too — citizens themselves offer bribes, normalizing the practice.
- Traffic law violations by citizens themselves degrade the quality of transport services.

CRITICAL POINT

Cultural and societal factors play a huge role: absence of good role models, normalization of wrong means, rising materialism, and poor civic sense all contribute to declining service quality despite government infrastructure.

Political Interference. Political interference in tender processes, appointments, and implementation distorts service delivery. When contracts are given to political allies rather than the most competent bidder, quality suffers.

EXAMPLE

Crony capitalism, where contracts are awarded based on political connections rather than merit, is an example of how political interference degrades service delivery.

QUICK REVISION

Reasons for poor quality: Overburdening/population pressure, Lack of skilled workforce, Corruption, Bureaucratic problems, Resource constraints, Digital divide, Cultural/societal factors, Political interference.

Two broad categories: (1) Society-side factors (civic sense, cultural attitudes, demand-side corruption); (2) Governance/bureaucracy-side factors (colonial attitude, red-tapism, resource constraints, political interference).

Work culture topics (discussed below) add further bureaucratic challenges to this list.

9.3 Code of Conduct and Code of Ethics

9.3.1 The Three-Tiered Framework (Second ARC Recommendation)

The Second Administrative Reforms Commission (ARC) recommended a three-tiered framework for guiding the behavior of civil servants. This framework is visualized as a triangle/pyramid:

- **Apex (Top):** Statement of Values — the broadest, most fundamental values (e.g., integrity, sustainability, justice).
- **Middle:** Code of Ethics — ethical standards and principles derived from those values. Broader than code of conduct.
- **Base (Bottom):** Code of Conduct — specific do's and don'ts for particular situations. Most specific and detailed.

KEY CONCEPT

The Second ARC recommended three levels: (1) Statement of Values at the apex; (2) Code of Ethics derived from those values; (3) Code of Conduct as specific do's and don'ts. Each level becomes progressively more specific.

9.3.2 Understanding Code of Conduct

Code of conduct refers to the specific do's and don'ts that clearly tell a civil servant what actions are permissible and which are not. It functions like a rulebook — explicit, directive, and situation-specific.

Key Features of Code of Conduct.

- Specifically tells you what to do and what not to do in clear terms.
- In India, the Civil Services Conduct Rules serve as the code of conduct for civil servants.
- Examples of specific rules: Civil servants cannot accept dowry; cannot criticize the government publicly; cannot accept gifts above a certain value; cannot accept lavish hospitality from friends; cannot help family members in official matters; cannot express personal opinions on political matters; must declare political activities.

EXAMPLE

- Civil servants are not supposed to take dowry.

- Civil servants cannot criticize the government publicly.
- There are specific limits on gifts that can be accepted.
- Lavish hospitality from friends cannot be accepted.
- Civil servants cannot help family members (bhaibanduo ki madad) in official matters.

Code of Conduct and Conflict of Interest. Code of conduct gives specific guidance on avoiding conflict of interest in different contexts:

- Recruitment/Interviews: If your relative is appearing for an interview, you must recuse yourself from the panel.
- Tender Process: If you have a conflict of interest in a tender, you must record it and recuse yourself.
- Judicial Proceedings: If a case involves someone you know, mere recording of the conflict of interest is sufficient in some contexts.

All these different do's and don'ts in different contexts are guided by the same code of ethics principle: there should not be any conflict of interest in decision-making.

9.3.3 Understanding Code of Ethics

Code of ethics defines the standards of behavior that should guide our actions. It is broader than code of conduct. While code of conduct tells you exactly what to do and what not to do, code of ethics provides the underlying ethical principles that guide behavior across all situations — including unforeseen ones.

KEY CONCEPT

Code of Ethics: Standards of behavior that should guide our action. Broader than code of conduct. Provides ethical principles applicable across multiple situations, including those not specifically covered by rules.

9.3.4 Relationship Between the Three Tiers

The three tiers are interconnected. A single value can generate multiple ethical standards, and each ethical standard can be applied as specific do's and don'ts across many situations.

EXAMPLE

- Value (Statement of Values): Integrity → Ethical Standard (Code of Ethics): Avoid conflict of interest → Code of Conduct: In recruitment — recuse from panel if relative is a candidate; In tender process — record conflict and recuse; In judicial proceedings — record conflict.
- Value: Sustainability → Code of Ethics: Ethical resource management, Wildlife conservation → Code of Conduct: No single-use plastic; E-waste buyback requirements; Project-specific conservation rules (e.g., Project Tiger, Project Elephant).

COMPARISON**Analogy with the Indian Constitution:**

- Preamble = Statement of Values (democratic, social, secular, republic, justice, equality, fraternity).
- Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSPs) = Code of Ethics (broad ethical guidelines — e.g., state should minimize inequality).
- Fundamental Rights and specific legislation = Code of Conduct (specific enforceable rules — e.g., taxation to reduce inequality).

9.3.5 Code of Conduct is Application of Code of Ethics in Specific Situations

Code of conduct is nothing but the application of code of ethics in specific situations that provides further clarity. If one simply states ‘avoid conflict of interest’ (code of ethics), an individual can claim there is no conflict. To prevent such misuse of discretion, code of conduct provides specific rules.

CRITICAL POINT

Code of conduct is an application of code of ethics in specific situations. Code of ethics is broader; code of conduct is more specific with clear do’s and don’ts.

9.3.6 Limitations of Code of Conduct

The limitations of code of conduct overlap significantly with the limitations of laws, rules, and regulations (previously discussed in the ‘Law versus Ethics’ topic).

- Cannot envisage all situations: Being a set of do’s and don’ts, it cannot conceive all probable situations. New challenges (AI, blockchain, disaster management) may not be covered.
- Discretion remains: Even with specific rules, some degree of discretion is unavoidable.
- Implementation gaps: Like any rule, effective implementation is necessary. Without enforcement, rules remain on paper.
- Lack of awareness: Many civil servants and citizens may not be fully aware of all conduct rules.
- Vagueness in certain provisions: The rule that ‘a civil servant should not do anything that is unbecoming of a civil servant’ is extremely broad and vague. ‘Unbecoming of a civil servant’ can mean virtually anything.
- Mixing of ethics and conduct: Rule 3 of conduct rules emphasizes integrity, duty, and ethical behavior — these are essentially code of ethics principles placed within a code of conduct document, because India currently does not have a separate code of ethics.
- Political interference: Political partisanship, improper appointments, and violations of conduct rules are common.
- Weak enforcement and inadequate monitoring.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Civil Services Conduct Rules: The rules that constitute the code of conduct for Indian civil servants. These are essentially ‘rules’ — and therefore share all the limitations of laws and regulations in ensuring ethical guidance.

CRITICAL POINT

Key insight: When discussing limitations of code of conduct, the same arguments from ‘limitations of laws, rules, and regulations’ (Law vs Ethics topic) apply directly, because code of conduct IS a set of rules. This overlap/congruency is a crucial theme for answer writing.

9.3.7 Why Code of Ethics Is Important

Given the limitations of code of conduct (which is essentially a set of rules), code of ethics becomes essential. The same reasoning that makes ethics important over mere laws applies here: laws and rules have limitations; ethical principles provide guidance where rules fall short, where discretion exists, and in unforeseen situations.

As of now, India does not have a formal code of ethics for civil servants. The Second ARC has recommended that there should be a statement of values and a code of ethics to complement the existing code of conduct.

Aspect	Code of Conduct	Code of Ethics
Nature	Specific do’s and don’ts	Broad ethical standards/principles
Scope	Narrow — covers specific situations	Broad — guides behavior across all situations
Flexibility	Rigid — prescriptive rules	Flexible — allows judgment in unforeseen situations
Example	Cannot accept gifts above Rs. X; must recuse from panel if relative is candidate	Avoid conflict of interest; uphold integrity
Indian Con-text	Civil Services Conduct Rules	No formal code of ethics exists yet (recommended by 2nd ARC)
Limitation	Cannot cover all situations; vague in places	May be too broad; depends on individual interpretation

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

UPSC has asked about the difference between code of conduct and code of ethics multiple times. The three-tiered approach (Statement of Values → Code of Ethics → Code of Conduct)

recommended by the Second ARC is a frequently tested concept.

QUICK REVISION

Three tiers (Second ARC): Statement of Values (apex) → Code of Ethics (middle) → Code of Conduct (base/most specific).

Code of Conduct = Specific do's and don'ts (Civil Services Conduct Rules in India). Code of Ethics = Broader ethical standards that guide action across all situations.

Code of Conduct is an application of Code of Ethics in specific situations.

Limitations of Code of Conduct = Limitations of laws and regulations (Law vs Ethics topic applies directly).

India lacks a formal Code of Ethics — Second ARC recommends creating one.

Key vagueness: 'Unbecoming of a civil servant' — too broad, defeats the purpose of specificity.

9.4 Citizen Charter

9.4.1 Background and Context

Traditionally, bureaucracy operated under a closed-system approach where citizens were seen merely as passive recipients of goods and services — not as active participants in governance. The administration implemented policies made by the political executive without evaluating whether those services were actually relevant to or beneficial for citizens. This was not citizen-centric administration.

Under the New Public Management (NPM) approach, originating in the United Kingdom, the idea emerged that administration should be made citizen-centric — borrowing the efficiency and accountability mechanisms of the private sector. In the private sector, consumers are at the center of service delivery; organizations are responsive because they know that ignoring consumers will have consequences.

In government services, however, there was no such orientation. Whether a government school teacher's teaching was effective, or a government doctor's treatment was working, was often not the administration's concern. The perspective that 'all services exist to serve citizens' was missing.

KEY CONCEPT

Citizen Charter emerged from the New Public Management approach, which sought to make government administration citizen-centric — just as private sector organizations are consumer-centric. It is a partnership document between an organization and its citizens.

9.4.2 Definition and Components

A citizen charter is an agreement (a partnership) between an organization and citizens, in which the organization specifies:

- Quantity and quality of services it will provide.
- Expected timelines for service delivery.
- Grievance redressal mechanism if services are not delivered as promised.

Essentially, the organization enters into a partnership with citizens, placing them at the center of administration and promising: ‘This is what you can expect from me, and if I fail, here is how you can hold me accountable.’

9.4.3 Case Studies

NTPC Citizen Charter. NTPC’s citizen charter includes:

- Vision: To be the world’s leading power company.
- Mission: To provide reliable power and related solutions.
- Core Values: Integrity, consumer focus, etc.
- Services to various stakeholders: Government (compliance, reports), Shareholders (dividends, annual reports), Consumers/State governments (supply of power).
- Expectations from stakeholders: Government should provide timely clearances; contractors/vendors must adhere to safety guidelines and provide quality services; optimum utilization of resources.
- Grievance redressal: Executive Director designated as head for grievance redressal; charter is reviewed periodically.

KEY CONCEPT

NTPC Citizen Charter provides for grievance redressal mechanism, expectations from stakeholders, and services provided to stakeholders. It demonstrates the partnership model of citizen charter.

RBI Citizen Charter. The RBI citizen charter provides timelines for various services such as loan processing, localized branch services, and other banking-related services.

Passport Seva Kendra. The passport citizen charter specifies timelines for passport processing — telling citizens exactly how many days different types of passport applications will take.

Hospitals (e.g., Gangaram). Hospital citizen charters detail patients’ rights (right to know diagnosis, available treatment options) and patients’ responsibilities (paying fees on time, treating doctors respectfully, not engaging in violence).

9.4.4 Purpose and Significance

- Ensures administration is accountable to citizens.
- Ensures administration truly serves the needs of citizens.
- Enables citizen participation in governance.
- Shifts the attitude from rule-implementation to citizen-centric service delivery.

9.4.5 Limitations of Citizen Charter

- Lack of Legal Enforcement: Citizen charters do not have legal backing. There is no law mandating them, leading to poor accountability.
- Non-existent Citizen Charters: Many organizations simply do not have citizen charters at all.
- One-Size-Fits-All Approach: When a ministry adopts a single citizen charter, all departments under it follow the same template — even though school education and higher education, for

example, deliver very different services.

- **Lack of Citizens' Participation While Formulating:** If citizens are not consulted during formulation, the charter will not capture their actual expectations.
- **Linguistic Barriers:** Many citizen charters are written only in English. Those who most need the charter often do not understand English. Charters are often not available in vernacular languages.
- **Absence of Grievance Redressal Mechanism:** Many charters make promises but do not provide a recourse mechanism if promises are not fulfilled.
- **Lack of Capacity Building:** Before making promises (e.g., service in 15 days), the organization must have adequate capacity (staff, infrastructure). Often, promises are made without corresponding capacity building.
- **Bureaucratic Mindset / Colonial Attitude:** The colonial, top-down, self-centered approach and culture of secrecy in the bureaucracy means they resist the citizen-centric orientation that citizen charters demand.
- **Inertia to Change and Red-Tapism.**
- **Culture of Secrecy in the bureaucracy.**
- **Lack of Awareness Among Public:** Citizens are often not aware that citizen charters exist or what rights they confer.

9.4.6 Measures to Improve (Second ARC Recommendations)

- Legal framework for enforcement of citizen charters.
- Consultation and participation of citizens during formulation.
- Standardization of charter formats while allowing adaptation by individual departments.
- Monitoring and evaluation mechanisms.
- Capacity building and training for staff.
- Effective grievance redressal mechanisms.
- Charters in vernacular languages.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Sevottam Model: A model for excellence in service delivery that provides a systematic approach to improve citizen charters. It is a good case study for exam answers.

QUICK REVISION

Citizen charter = agreement between organization and citizens specifying services, timelines, and grievance mechanisms.

Background: Emerged from New Public Management; borrowed consumer-centric approach from private sector.

Case studies: NTPC (stakeholder services + grievance redressal), RBI (service timelines), Passport Seva Kendra (processing timelines), Hospitals (patient rights and responsibilities).

Key limitations: No legal backing, non-existent in many organizations, one-size-fits-all, no citizen

participation in formulation, linguistic barriers, absent grievance redressal, bureaucratic mindset. Measures: Legal framework, citizen consultation, standardization with flexibility, capacity building, grievance redressal, vernacular languages.

Sevottam Model — a model for excellence in service delivery (good case study for answers).

9.5 Work Culture

9.5.1 Definition

Work culture refers to the shared values, attitudes, behaviors, and practices that define how work is conducted within an organization. It is not determined by a single person's attitude — it is defined by the collective values shared by employees. However, a single person (especially a leader) can change the work culture of an entire organization.

KEY CONCEPT

Work Culture = Shared values, attitudes, and behaviors that collectively define how an organization operates. It is collective, not individual — though a single leader can transform it.

9.5.2 Dimensions of Work Culture

- Leadership style: Authoritarian (top-down) vs. participatory (collaborative decision-making).
- Communication: Open and transparent vs. closed and hierarchical.
- Technology and innovation: Adoption of new technologies and openness to innovative approaches.
- Decision-making: Centralized vs. decentralized; fast vs. slow.
- Motivation and morale: How employees are motivated; collective morale levels.
- Accountability culture: Whether accountability is enforced or evaded.
- Transparency: Information sharing within the organization.
- Division of labor: How tasks are distributed.
- Hierarchy: Flat vs. deep hierarchical structures (related to Max Weber's bureaucratic model).
- Recognition and appreciation: Whether good work is recognized and rewarded.

9.5.3 Positive Work Culture — Characteristics and Examples

A healthy/positive work culture is characterized by clear and open communication, trust and respect among employees, a sense of belonging, opportunities for growth and development, a sense of purpose, and recognition and appreciation for good work.

EXAMPLE

- Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC): Under E. Sreedharan's leadership, DMRC developed a work culture of timely project delivery and punctuality. Despite government departments being notorious for delays, Sreedharan changed the culture so that all employees believed projects must be delivered on time. This is a classic example of positive work culture — shared

values of efficiency and punctuality.

- Google: Trusts employees; provides nap pods, flexible working; focuses on targets rather than micromanagement; promotes innovation; rewards employees for sincere effort even when mistakes happen. Google also provides three months of paternity leave.
- Tata Group: Known for ethical corporate governance, respect for employees and consumers, strong ethical values as the foundation of its business culture.

9.5.4 Negative Work Culture — Characteristics and Examples

A negative/toxic work culture is characterized by poor communication, lack of trust, high pressure without support, absence of work-life balance, corruption, and lack of recognition.

EXAMPLE

- Satyam Scam: A case study of negative work culture where lack of objectivity, poor corporate governance, and fraud became part of the organizational culture.
- Glass Ceiling: Discrimination against women in promotions and career advancement is an example of negative work culture, both in corporate and government settings.
- CRPF: High attrition rate and suicides among personnel due to work pressure — an example of negative work culture and poor work-life balance.
- Police: Working under high pressure, not getting adequate leave — a negative example of work-life balance and work culture.
- Work from Home concerns: Erosion of work-life boundaries; employees expected to respond at all hours; meetings scheduled late at night — privacy is destroyed and mental health is impacted. This highlights the need for a 'Right to Disconnect.'

9.5.5 Determinants of Work Culture

In the government context, both corporate governance principles (private sector) and foundation values for civil services (government sector) influence work culture. The factors that influence work culture in the government include those discussed under bureaucratic challenges and under value inculcation in society.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Right to Disconnect: The concept that employees should have the right to not respond to work communications outside of working hours. This is relevant in the context of work-from-home culture and its impact on mental health and work-life balance.

QUICK REVISION

Work culture = shared values defining how work is done in an organization.

Dimensions: Leadership style, communication, technology, decision-making, motivation, accountability, transparency, hierarchy, recognition.

Positive examples: DMRC (timely delivery, E. Sreedharan), Google (trust, flexibility, innovation), Tata (ethical governance).

Negative examples: Satyam Scam (fraud culture), Glass ceiling (discrimination), CRPF (work pressure/suicides), Police (poor work-life balance), WFH without Right to Disconnect. Work culture can be evaluated positively or negatively across any parameter; good or bad case studies can be cited.

9.6 Transparency and Accountability

9.6.1 Transparency

Definition. Transparency is about making information available to the people — timely, reliably, and in an accessible manner — so that it can be used for scrutiny and in the interest of the public. When citizens have information, they are empowered and can hold the government accountable.

KEY CONCEPT

Transparency: Making information available to the people in a timely, reliable, and accessible manner so that it serves as a tool for scrutiny and public accountability.

Types of Transparency. **Event Transparency:** Transparency about inputs, outputs, and outcomes. For example: a road was constructed using Rs. 1 crore, which produced 5 km connecting Village A and Village B. This tells you what was spent and what was achieved.

Process Transparency: Transparency about the procedures and processes followed. For example: how was the particular contractor (ABC Limited) selected? Was there a fair bidding process? If ABC Limited is the minister's son's company, there is a problem. Process transparency ensures citizens know how decisions were made — not just what the outcomes were.

EXAMPLE

UPSC mostly follows event transparency — it publishes results, marks, and answer keys (input, output, outcome). But exactly how copies are being checked, what methods are used for evaluation — that procedural information is not shared. That would be process transparency.

CRITICAL POINT

Transparency should not merely provide token information. The information must be meaningful enough for citizens to use it for accountability. Both event transparency AND process transparency are needed for genuine empowerment.

9.6.2 Accountability

Definition. Accountability is the obligation — especially of those in decision-making positions — to report, explain, and be answerable for their actions and inactions, and to face the resulting consequences. It involves an associated punishment or sanction mechanism for non-fulfillment of obligations.

KEY CONCEPT

Accountability: The obligation of decision-makers to explain their actions/inactions and face consequences. It includes: (1) Obligation to explain; (2) Answerability; (3) Facing consequences (punishment/sanctions).

Accountability vs. Responsibility.	Aspect	Accountability	Responsibility
	Timing	Usually after the task is completed	During the course of the task
	Assignment	Fixed on specific person(s) — assigned authoritatively	Can be shared; can be assumed voluntarily
	Nature	Cannot be taken voluntarily — must be assigned with prior knowledge of obligations	Can be taken up voluntarily (even in a collective responsibility environment)
	Example	DM/SP are held accountable after an incident — they knew beforehand they would answer	Keeping classroom discipline is a responsibility as a teacher
	Scope	Specific to assigned duties and expectations	Broader — can encompass social duties

9.6.3 Traditional Forms of Accountability

Traditional accountability mechanisms include:

- **Legal Accountability:** Laws such as the Prevention of Corruption Act that punish wrongdoers.
- **Political Accountability:** Opposition in Parliament holding the government accountable through questions, debates, and no-confidence motions.
- **Administrative Accountability:** Hierarchy (Max Weber's model) — superiors holding subordinates accountable. E.g., DC holds DSP accountable, DSP holds Inspector accountable.
- **Fiscal Accountability:** Institutions like the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) that audit government expenditure.
- **Judicial Accountability:** Courts pronouncing judgments and fixing punishment.
- **Separation of Powers:** Each branch of government checking the others.

9.6.4 Limitations of Traditional Accountability

- **Inward-looking/Institutional-centric:** Traditional mechanisms evaluate policies from the administration's perspective, not from the citizens' perspective. Closed system approach.
- **Slow decision-making:** Judiciary is slow; cases take years to resolve.
- **Reactive rather than proactive:** Issues are addressed only after they become problems (e.g., NEET leak controversy in Parliament). CAG does post-mortem auditing.
- **Focus on legality, not outcomes:** They check whether procedures were legally followed, not whether citizens actually benefited.

- Not people-centric: Citizens' perspectives and actual impact on their lives are often not evaluated.

CRITICAL POINT

Traditional accountability mechanisms are institutional-centric, slow, reactive, and focused on legality rather than outcomes. This creates a gap that social accountability mechanisms must fill.

9.6.5 Social Accountability Mechanisms

Given the limitations of traditional accountability, social accountability mechanisms have emerged to complement them. Social accountability involves citizens actively participating in holding government accountable.

- Citizen Charter: Empowers citizens to question service delivery.
- RTI (Right to Information): Allows citizens to access government information.
- Social Audit: Citizens collectively monitor and evaluate government schemes.
- Social Media: Debates, discussions, and protests on social media platforms.
- Citizens' Report Card: Citizens rate government services.
- Public Interest Litigation (PIL): Citizens approach courts on matters of public interest.
- Jan Sunwai (Public Hearings): Citizens participate in hearing processes.
- Protest movements and Janta Darbar.
- Participatory budgeting.
- NGO performance reports (e.g., ASER Report on learning levels).

QUICK REVISION

Transparency: Making information available — both event transparency (inputs/outputs/outcomes) and process transparency (procedures/decisions).

Accountability: Obligation to explain, be answerable, and face consequences. Different from responsibility (which can be shared and assumed).

Traditional accountability: Legal, political, administrative, fiscal, judicial. Limitations: institutional-centric, slow, reactive, legality-focused.

Social accountability: Citizen charter, RTI, social audit, social media, PIL, citizens' report card, jan sunwai, participatory budgeting, NGO reports (ASER).

9.7 Social Audit

9.7.1 Definition

Social audit is a participatory process through which citizens collectively monitor, verify, and evaluate the implementation of government schemes by comparing official records with the ground reality, in order to ensure accountability, transparency, and participation.

KEY CONCEPT

Social Audit: A participatory process in which citizens collectively monitor and evaluate government schemes by comparing official records with ground reality — ensuring accountability, transparency, and citizen participation.

9.7.2 Why Social Audit Is Needed

Traditional accountability mechanisms only check whether procedures were legally followed and money was legally spent. They do not assess whether citizens actually benefited from the expenditure. Social audit fills this gap by evaluating schemes from the beneficiaries' perspective.

EXAMPLE

Under MNAREGA: Traditional accountability would check whether Rs. 20,000 crore was legally disbursed, budgeted, and procedurally correct. But social audit checks whether the beneficiaries actually received benefits, whether the work was actually done on the ground, and whether the listed beneficiaries actually exist.

9.7.3 How Social Audit Works (MNAREGA Example)

- Gram Sabha meetings are convened with participation of all villagers.
- The list of MNAREGA beneficiaries is examined by the community.
- Villagers identify ghost beneficiaries — e.g., names like Amitabh Bachchan, Shahrukh Khan, Sunny Leone found in beneficiary lists, which are obviously fake identities used for embezzlement.
- Physical verification of work: If a pond was supposed to be built, villagers can see whether it actually exists.
- Comparison of official records with ground reality exposes corruption, fake muster rolls, and diversion of funds.

9.7.4 Case Study: Meghalaya**GOVERNMENT & POLICY**

Meghalaya Society for Social Audit and Transparency (MSSAT): Meghalaya has enacted a law making social audit mandatory for a number of schemes and departments. This is a model case study for social audit implementation.

EXAMPLE**Case examples from Meghalaya's social audit**

- **Old Age Pension Case:** A beneficiary's pension under the National Social Assistance Programme was stopped because his name was erroneously removed from the database — officially recorded as deceased. Social audit revealed the person was alive, and pension was resumed. (A similar case happened in Haryana where a person took out a procession with a banner saying 'Tumhara Phuppa Zinda Hai' — your uncle is alive.)

- **Non-Functioning School Case:** A school had not been functioning for three years. Midday meals were not provided. Parents had admitted children to other schools. Social audit revealed this, and the education department decided to recover the misused funds (Rs. 84,000 reimbursed to the department). This demonstrates holding administration accountable for non-functioning of midday meals.

9.7.5 *Benefits of Social Audit*

- Enhances transparency in government operations.
- Strengthens accountability of officials and institutions.
- Promotes citizen participation in governance.
- Detects corruption and leakages.
- Improves service delivery quality.
- Empowers beneficiaries to demand their rights.
- Builds public trust in government institutions.
- Provides continuous feedback for course correction.
- Strengthens grassroots democracy through Gram Sabha participation.
- Promotes ethical governance.
- Improves government legitimacy.

Additionally, utilitarian arguments can be added — social audit enhances the greatest good for the greatest number by ensuring resources reach actual beneficiaries.

9.7.6 *Limitations of Social Audit*

Many limitations overlap with those of citizen charter, since both lack comprehensive legal enforcement.

- Low public awareness about social audit processes.
- Political interference — local leaders (gram panchayat) may resist social audit to protect corruption.
- Bureaucratic resistance — attitude of secrecy, reluctance to share information.
- Poor quality or inaccessible records — officials may not maintain proper records or may refuse to share them.
- Inadequate institutional capacity and resources.
- Weak follow-up mechanism — no enforcement of audit findings.
- Lack of enforcement power — not legally mandated for most schemes (MNAREGA is an exception).
- Elite capture — powerful local elites manipulate the process to protect their interests.
- Limited capacity of citizens to analyze government documents.

CRITICAL POINT

Social audit is highly probable for UPSC Mains this year. Along with Citizen Charter and RTI, it is one of the three most likely topics for a question in GS Paper IV.

QUICK REVISION

Social audit = participatory process; citizens compare official records with ground reality. Needed because traditional accountability is institutional-centric and does not check citizen-level outcomes.

MNAREGA: Gram Sabha examines beneficiary lists, physically verifies work, identifies ghost beneficiaries.

Case study: Meghalaya Society for Social Audit and Transparency (MSSAT) — legally mandated social audit.

Benefits: Transparency, accountability, participation, corruption detection, empowerment, public trust, grassroots democracy, ethical governance.

Limitations: No legal backing (except MNAREGA), low awareness, political interference, bureaucratic resistance, weak follow-up, elite capture.

9.8 Right to Information (RTI)

9.8.1 Overview

RTI gives every citizen the right to access information held by public authorities. It is a key social accountability tool that empowers citizens to hold government accountable.

- Coverage: Applies to public institutions. Every department must appoint a Public Information Officer (PIO) to receive and process RTI applications.
- Timeline: Usually 30 days for response. If life/liberty is threatened, 48 hours.
- Proactive Disclosure: The Act mandates that organizations should proactively disclose certain information (e.g., UPSC publishes past year papers, declares answer keys).
- No Reason Required: The applicant does not need to state why they are seeking the information. This prevents intimidation — if reasons were required, the information could be used against the applicant.
- Appeal Mechanism: First appeal within the department (to a senior officer). Second appeal to the Central/State Information Commission (CIC/SIC).
- Exemptions: Certain information related to strategic interests, trade secrets, sovereignty, and national security is exempted.

9.8.2 RTI as a Social Accountability Tool

RTI enables citizens to:

- Verify tender processes — check if eligibility criteria were changed to favor a particular party.
- Access beneficiary lists — verify if benefits reached actual beneficiaries or were diverted.
- Check minutes of meetings — understand how decisions were made.

- Expose corruption and scams (e.g., the Adarsh Society scam was exposed through RTI).
- Improve service delivery by creating transparency pressure.
- Identify ghost beneficiaries in welfare schemes.

9.8.3 *Benefits of RTI*

- Increases transparency in government operations.
- Strengthens accountability of officials.
- Promotes citizen participation in governance.
- Helps detect corruption and leakages.
- Improves service delivery through transparency pressure.

Note: The arguments for benefits of RTI are similar to those for social audit and citizen charter — they all serve as social accountability mechanisms.

9.8.4 *Limitations and Challenges of RTI Implementation*

Infrastructural Issues.

- Poor record management: Officers do not properly maintain or categorize records. When RTI is filed, the entire file has to be searched, consuming resources and time.
- Lack of digitization of records.
- Poor infrastructure for processing RTI applications in many departments.

Bureaucratic Attitude.

- Officers are trained in secrecy — their default attitude is to share minimum information.
- Bureaucratic resistance to disclosure of information.
- Fear of scrutiny deters officials from frank decision-making — knowing that deliberations may be exposed via RTI, officers may avoid giving honest opinions in files, impacting administrative efficiency and innovation.

Capacity and Institutional Issues.

- Frequent transfers of PIOs: PIOs need time to develop the skill of deciding what information to divulge and what to withhold. Before they gain adequate experience, they are transferred — leading to capacity gaps.
- CIC and SIC composition: Central and State Information Commissions are often dominated by retired bureaucrats who have been historically trained in protecting information, not disclosing it. This creates a ‘parking lot’ mentality where these positions are used as post-retirement sinecures.
- Lack of independence: The government can influence salaries and terms of information commissioners, compromising their independence. Original provisions of the RTI Act did not allow government to change these terms, but subsequent amendments introduced this power.
- Overburdened Information Commissions: Vacancies in Information Commissioner positions are not filled timely, creating backlogs.

Enforcement Challenges.

- Penalties are not strictly enforced — poor deterrence for non-compliance.
- High rejection rate in certain departments with frivolous reasons for rejection.
- Rejection using broad exemption clauses like ‘wider public interest.’

Citizen-Side Challenges.

- Complex application process and financial burden of filing RTI for common citizens.
- Lack of awareness among citizens about RTI rights and procedures.
- Misuse of RTI: Some people file frivolous RTI applications (e.g., asking how many samosas were served in a meeting) or use RTI for personal vendettas. This diverts resources, reduces efficiency, and undermines RTI’s spirit.
- RTI used as harassment tool against officers — filing RTI to access personal opinions of officials on file, which chills honest deliberation.

Safety Concerns. Threat to life of RTI activists: Many RTI activists have been attacked or killed for exposing corruption. Lack of protection for whistleblowers compounds this problem.

Impact on Administrative Efficiency. When RTI is misused, officers spend excessive time responding to frivolous applications. This diverts resources from actual work, reduces efficiency, and makes officers risk-averse in their decision-making. The Economic Survey has also noted that RTI’s impact on decision-making deliberations discourages frank expression of opinions, which affects policy quality.

CRITICAL POINT

The impact of RTI misuse on administrative efficiency is an important point for answer writing: officers avoid giving honest opinions knowing deliberations may be disclosed, which impacts decision-making quality and innovation.

QUICK REVISION

RTI = right to access information from public authorities. 30-day timeline; no reason required; appeal to CIC/SIC.

Social accountability tool: verifies tender processes, exposes corruption (Adarsh scam), identifies ghost beneficiaries.

Limitations: Poor records, bureaucratic secrecy, PIO transfers, CIC/SIC composition (retired bureaucrats), lack of independence, penalties not enforced, high rejection rates.

Citizen-side: Complex process, misuse (frivolous/harassment RTIs), low awareness.

Safety: Threats to RTI activists, lack of whistleblower protection.

Impact: Chills frank decision-making, diverts resources, reduces efficiency.

9.9 Probity in Governance

9.9.1 *Probity vs. Integrity*

Probity. Probity is the term used in the context of organizations and professions. It is about maximizing ethical principles in organizational conduct — going beyond personal honesty to actively create systems, checks, and balances that minimize corruption and maximize ethical behavior in the organization.

KEY CONCEPT

Probity: Maximizing ethical principles in organizational/professional life. It includes leadership, creating checks and balances, and institutional mechanisms to minimize corruption. Probity mechanisms include: transparency improvements, accountability systems, RTI, social audit, DBT, and all systems designed to minimize corruption in governance.

Integrity. Integrity is about consistently following your principles and doing the right thing even when no one is watching. It applies to both personal and professional life. It is about being true to one's values across all contexts.

Aspect	Probity	Integrity
Context	Organizational and professional	Personal and professional
Focus	Maximizing ethical principles; creating systems	Consistency of personal values and actions
Scope	Institutional — checks, balances, mechanisms	Individual — character, honesty
Example	DBT, social audit, transparency mechanisms, anti-corruption institutions	A person not cheating even when no one is watching
Usage	'Lack of probity in governance' — refers to organizational/systemic failure	'Lack of integrity' — refers to personal moral failure (e.g., disloyalty)

9.9.2 *Reasons for Declining Probity*

The reasons for declining probity can be categorized into several dimensions:

Political Dimension.

- Political patronage and protection of corrupt officials.
- Political interference in administration.
- Lack of political will to implement probity mechanisms.

Administrative/Bureaucratic Dimension.

- Poor work culture in government organizations.
- Weak traditional accountability mechanisms.
- Red-tapism and procedural bottlenecks.

- Colonial attitudes and culture of secrecy.

Societal Dimension.

- Normalization of corruption in society.
- Poor role models — corruption glorified in movies and popular culture.
- Rising materialism and ‘ends justify means’ approach.
- Success measured only by wealth, regardless of how it was earned.
- Demand-side corruption — citizens themselves offer bribes.
- Poor civic sense and breaking of rules by citizens themselves.

Moral/Individual Dimension.

- Declining personal values and ethics.
- Rising greed and selfishness.
- Lack of moral courage to resist corruption.

Historical/Cultural Dimension. Bakshish system from the Mughal era — the cultural expectation of receiving extra rewards for performing one’s duty. This has evolved into a form of bribery where officials expect ‘something extra’ from citizens for doing their regular work (e.g., patwaris expecting payment for routine land records work).

Deterrence Dimension.

- Poor deterrence — insufficient punishment for corruption.
- Slow judicial process means corrupt officials are rarely punished quickly.
- Society does not create social pressure against corruption.

9.9.3 Philosophical Basis of Probity in Governance

This topic connects to all the philosophical perspectives on governance that have been studied under various thinkers:

- **Utilitarianism** (Bentham, Mill): Governance should maximize good for the maximum number of people. Lincoln’s statement about government ‘of the people, by the people, for the people’ reflects this.
- **Deontology** (Kant): Human beings should be treated never merely as a means — dignity and respect in governance.
- **Virtue Ethics** (Aristotle): Golden mean; those who rule should be persons of wisdom and virtue (Plato’s Philosopher King).
- **Max Weber**: Rational-legal authority with written rules, hierarchy, and division of labor for accountability.
- **Social Contract** (John Locke): Government authority is limited; derives legitimacy from consent of the governed.
- **John Rawls**: Just institutions; veil of ignorance; inequality should favor the weaker sections.
- **Machiavelli**: Politics is about power (his philosophical perspective, though contrasting with

ethical governance ideals).

- **Gandhi:** ‘Politics without principle is a sin’; Gandhian Talisman — test every policy by its impact on the poorest.
- **Bhagavad Gita and Mahabharata:** Philosophical foundations rooted in Indian traditions about dharma and governance.

Kautilya (Arthashastra). Kautilya’s philosophy on governance contains crucial insights on probity:

- ‘In the happiness of his subjects lies the king’s happiness; in their welfare, his welfare.’ — Administration must be citizen-centric, not self-serving.
- Corruption is inevitable — ‘Just like you cannot stop fish from drinking water, you cannot stop corruption.’ Therefore, the focus should be on probity mechanisms to minimize corruption.
- Recommended a network of spies (guptachars) for detection and hefty punishment for deterrence.
- Sam, Dam, Dand, Bhed — different strategies for governance and maintaining order.

KEY CONCEPT

Kautilya’s key insight: Since corruption is inevitable, the focus must be on creating robust probity mechanisms — detection systems, checks and balances, and deterrent punishments. This is the philosophical basis for all modern anti-corruption institutions.

QUICK REVISION

Probity = maximizing ethical principles in organizational context (not just personal honesty).
Integrity = consistency of personal values.

Declining probity: Political (patronage), Administrative (poor work culture, weak accountability), Societal (normalization of corruption, materialism), Moral (declining values), Historical (bakshish system), Deterrence (poor punishment).

Philosophical basis: Utilitarianism, Deontology, Virtue Ethics, Weber, Social Contract, Rawls, Machiavelli, Gandhi, Kautilya, Bhagavad Gita.

Kautilya: Citizen-centric governance (‘in their welfare, his welfare’); corruption is inevitable like fish drinking water; therefore create detection (spies) and deterrence (hefty punishment).

9.10 Utilization of Public Funds

9.10.1 Overview

When government and bureaucrats utilize funds, those funds are public funds — not from their personal pockets. Efficient and ethical utilization of these funds is a cornerstone of probity in governance. Problems with public fund utilization fall into two categories: under-utilization (funds not used effectively) and mis-utilization (funds diverted or misused).

9.10.2 Reasons for Under-Utilization of Public Funds

Procedural Bottlenecks and Red-Tapism. Projects get stuck at various stages due to bureaucratic procedures — environmental clearances not given, land acquisition delayed, approvals pending.

When projects stall, allocated funds remain unspent or are spent without delivering outcomes.

EXAMPLE

- A bridge project was started over a seasonal river. The bridge was constructed but the approach road (land) was never acquired. So the bridge stands unused — money was spent but the public cannot use it. This is under-utilization of funds due to lack of planning and procedural delays.
- Cost escalation occurs when projects are delayed — the original budget becomes insufficient, and additional funds are needed to complete the same project.

Lack of Community Participation / Top-Down Implementation. When schemes are designed at the center without consulting local communities, the expenditure may not be relevant to local needs.

EXAMPLE

- Centrally Sponsored Schemes (CSS): When the Planning Commission existed, states had to contribute a mandatory share (e.g., 40 crore out of 140 crore) even if they did not need that particular scheme. A state like Kerala might need more investment in tourism or land management rather than additional healthcare spending — but the top-down approach forced committed expenditure on pre-determined schemes.
- If the government builds many toilets in Karol Bagh (where they are not needed) instead of a library (which would be more useful), the funds are technically utilized but under-utilized in terms of optimal impact.

Delay in Fund Disbursement. When funds are not released on time, front-line workers (like ASHA workers) cannot plan activities. If funds arrive at the end of the financial year, there is insufficient time to implement programs effectively, leading to rushed and poor expenditure.

Incremental Budgeting. Bureaucracy has a tendency to demand incrementally higher budgets each year without adequate justification. If a department received Rs. 100 crore last year, it will demand Rs. 110–120 crore this year — simply because no bureaucrat asks for less. However, there may be no associated planning for the additional funds.

KEY CONCEPT

Incremental Budgeting: The practice of increasing budget demands year-on-year without justification. This leads to under-utilization because departments receive funds without having plans to use them effectively.

Zero-Based Budgeting: Recommended as an alternative — every year's budget starts from zero, requiring fresh justification for every expenditure line item.

Lack of Accountability. Traditional accountability mechanisms like CAG operate in a post-mortem fashion and are institutional-centric. Day-to-day scrutiny of expenditure quality does not happen routinely, leading to wasteful spending going unchecked.

9.10.3 Reasons for Mis-Utilization of Public Funds

Corruption. Bribery, embezzlement, and nepotism in tender processes all constitute mis-utilization. When tenders are given to friends or relatives ('bhaibanduo ko de diya'), the money goes to those it was never meant for. Corruption diverts public resources from their intended purpose.

Social Exclusion and Discriminatory Allocation. When public funds are allocated without considering all sections of society, it constitutes mis-utilization. If Rs. 100 crore meant for public welfare is spent entirely on facilities for one gender or one region while excluding others, the fund is mis-utilized.

EXAMPLE

- If all public toilets built are male toilets, the social category of women is excluded. The Rs. 100 crore was never meant exclusively for male facilities.
- Discriminatory allocation to politically significant states at the expense of others is also mis-utilization.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Gender-Based Budgeting: The practice of ensuring proportionate expenditure across genders. When making expenditure, government must ensure proportionate allocation for men, women, and third gender.

Ineffective Targeting of Beneficiaries. When benefits reach the wrong people (ghost beneficiaries, fake entries), the purpose of the fund is defeated.

EXAMPLE

Ghost beneficiaries in MNAREGA — names like Shahrukh Khan and Salman Khan in the muster rolls — represent funds diverted through fake identities.

Centralization of Decision-Making. When decisions about fund utilization are made at the top without understanding local needs, resources may be directed to projects that are irrelevant to the community.

9.10.4 Measures for Better Utilization

- Zero-Based Budgeting: Justify every expenditure from scratch each year.
- Outcome-Based Budgeting: Focus on outcomes, not just expenditure volumes.
- Gender-Based Budgeting: Ensure proportionate allocation across demographics.
- Strengthening social accountability mechanisms: RTI, social audit can improve transparency in fund utilization.
- Community participation in planning: Bottom-up approach to expenditure planning.
- Timely fund disbursement to implementing agencies.
- Strengthening probity mechanisms: Anti-corruption institutions, transparent tender processes, technology-enabled monitoring.
- Capacity building of implementing agencies.

- Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) to reduce leakages.

CRITICAL POINT

Utilization of public funds connects directly to GS Paper III (Economics) topics like budgeting reforms. Cross-referencing between Paper III and Paper IV strengthens answers significantly.

QUICK REVISION

Under-utilization: Procedural bottlenecks, lack of community participation, delayed fund disbursement, incremental budgeting, lack of accountability.

Mis-utilization: Corruption/nepotism, social exclusion/discriminatory allocation, ineffective targeting (ghost beneficiaries), centralized decision-making.

Measures: Zero-based budgeting, outcome-based budgeting, gender-based budgeting, social accountability mechanisms, community participation, timely disbursement, DBT, probity mechanisms.

Key insight: Incremental budgeting → Zero-based budgeting is a major reform recommendation. Cross-reference with GS Paper III economics topics for stronger answers.